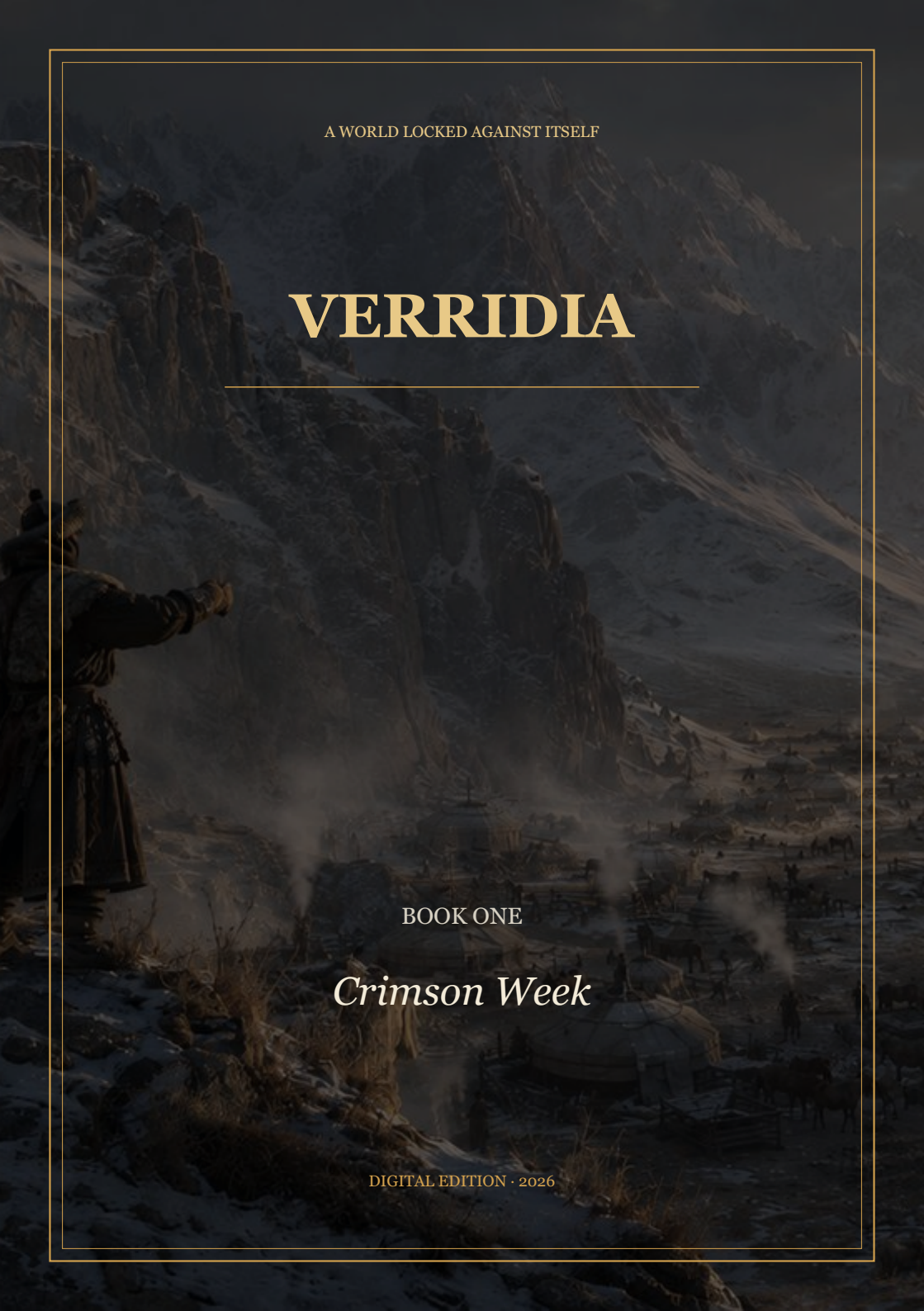


The background of the entire cover is a dark, atmospheric landscape. In the foreground on the left, a person wearing a dark, heavy coat and a hat stands on a rocky outcrop, their right arm extended as if pointing towards the distance. The landscape beyond is a vast, desolate valley. In the distance, a large, dark mountain range rises, its peaks partially covered in snow or ash. The valley floor is filled with numerous small, dark figures of people and animals, suggesting a large gathering or a settlement. Wisps of white smoke or steam rise from various points in the valley, adding to the sense of activity and perhaps conflict. The overall color palette is dark and muted, with shades of grey, brown, and black, punctuated by the white of the smoke and the yellow of the text.

A WORLD LOCKED AGAINST ITSELF

# VERRIDIA

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BOOK ONE

*Crimson Week*

DIGITAL EDITION · 2026

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# Verridia



*Four paths, one sky. A world sealed by light in the north,  
beneath the shadow of an approaching cycle.*

# 1. Part — The Oath of Ash and Blood

\* \* \*

## Section 1 — Ash on Four Horizons

### Chapter 1 — Silent Drills and Ashen Memories

*(TOGAN)*

When the sword drove into the dummy's chest for the third time, its wooden spine cracked.

Togan pulled the sword free. His breath roared in his ears, and the burn in his arms made him forget the bitter cold. He struck again. Then again. He had lost count of the blows and had no idea how far off dawn might be. Months of pacing the same ground had packed the dirt of the training yard hard beneath his feet. Each swing shook more chaff from the dummy's felt body.

Eaglehold slept below. Wind spilling down through the passes trembled the tent ropes, and somewhere in the distance a dog barked now and then. The One Eye hung above the northern ridges. Lower still, near the horizon, the Crimson Host appeared and vanished behind the passing clouds.

Burkut perched on one of the training posts. His talons worried ceaselessly at the wood, his head turning from side to side as if searching for a sound the wind had failed to carry.

"You're wearing out yourself, not the steel."

Togan knew Kaya's voice. He did not stop. He drove one last blow into the dummy's chest, left the sword lodged in the wood, and turned.

Kaya stepped out of the shadows carrying two wooden swords. Nine years older than Togan, she was his milk-sister. She held one out to him.

"Try swinging at flesh and bone for once. You might remember who you're striking."

Togan tore the iron sword from the dummy, threw it down, and took the wooden one.

Kaya did not wait for his first move. She slipped in lightly and tested his left shoulder. Instead of parrying, Togan brought his blade down hard against hers. The crack of wood rang across the empty yard.

"That anger might serve an Azgut." Kaya drew back and found another angle. "It will get a Windlistener killed."

Togan advanced on her.

Kaya yielded half a step with every blow, bleeding the strength from his sword. The more Togan thought he had her cornered, the wider he opened his guard. His breaths shortened. Sweat slicked his palms until the hilt began to slip. The calm on Kaya's face felt like an insult that grew with every strike he made.

He put all his weight behind the final blow.

Kaya slid aside. She struck his wrist and drove her shoulder into his chest. Togan's foot twisted in the mud, and the sky suddenly opened before him. He hit the ground flat on his back. The tip of the wooden sword pressed against his throat.

For a time, the only sound was his breathing.

Kaya withdrew the blade but did not offer him a hand. "That isn't a Sungur sword. You're holding the hilt, but your anger is the one striking."

Togan pushed himself upright in the mud.

Kaya raised the wooden sword again. "Get up."

"I fell. You saw."

"A fall doesn't end the drill."

Togan rose from one knee. This time he did not attack. Kaya traced a half circle around him and scored three short marks in the mud with the toe of her right boot.

"The first is where your opponent stands. The second is where you think you'll strike. The third is where your anger drags you." She set the tip of her wooden sword on the last mark. "You always step on the third."

Togan gripped his sword in both hands. Kaya fainted at his shoulder. Rather than meet the blow, he drew back and planted his foot beside the first mark she had shown him. Kaya's blade passed in front of his chest. Togan touched her wrist with his pommel and stopped without striking.

Kaya's brows lifted slightly. "So you can still hear."

"Hear what?"

"Someone other than yourself."

The small success brought Togan no relief. On Melira's final night, he had believed he could hear the people around him then, too. Once the flames rose, he had lost them all.

"Who is standing before you?" Kaya asked. "Me? Korgan? Or someone you haven't been able to bury for a year?"

Togan lowered his head. He knew Kaya was waiting for an answer. Anything he could give her would either be a lie or too true for him to bear saying aloud.

Kaya gathered up the wooden swords. As she left, her steps sounded more tired than angry.

The cold worked its way beneath Togan's wet clothes. He pressed his hands into the mud. Kaya was right. Over the past year he had grown stronger and faster. He had gone to sleep with a sword and woken with one. Yet every day there was a little less of him left.

"Where do you strike a ghost?" he whispered.

\* \* \*

The smell of the clan fire reached him first: bison meat, mountain thyme, root vegetables roasting in the coals. Then came the measured steps of someone who stubbornly refused to use a walking stick.

"A warrior doesn't swing a sword on an empty stomach."

Mother Anya held out a wooden bowl. More than eighty years had bent her body, but her gaze could still make a person clear a place for her.

Togan took the bowl. The heat stung his fingers. Anya sat on the log beside him and made no hurry to speak.

"I saw your father last night," she said at last. "He was riding across the steppe. He called to you. 'My son has forgotten to look at the sky.'"

Togan drank a mouthful of broth. "It was a dream."

"It was." Anya turned her hands before the fire. "That doesn't make it empty. A Windlistener who fixes his eyes on the ground loses his way. For a year, you've looked nowhere but the place where Melira fell."

The name killed the warmth in his stomach. The rim of the bowl creaked between his fingers.

"How could you know what I saw?"

Anya kept her hands before the flames. "I lost my husband in a raid. My first son died of winter fever in my arms. No one in this camp walks without a grave inside them." She turned to Togan. "I can't take your pain from you. But I won't stay silent while you feed it and let it rule you. Ask yourself what is left to separate you from the Ember-Fires."

On the far side of the clan fire, two children played quietly with a charred stick for a horse. When the smaller child's fur slipped from one shoulder, the older child pulled it back into place without thinking. Togan remembered chasing Kaya around this same fire. Anya had seized them both by the ears and sent them to their tent; the next morning Kaya had taken all the blame. The day they tied their first eagle nests to the left side of the crooked willow by the stream, Kaya had caught him by the belt. Togan had hung upside down beneath the branch while Kaya laughed too hard to loosen the knot, until at last they both tumbled into the mud. Years later, Togan could still have picked that laugh out from all others.

"Did my father say anything else in your dream?"

Anya pushed a branch into the fire. "He did."

Togan waited.

"He wasn't angry with you."

The answer weighed more than a rebuke.

Togan finished the meal and set the bowl beside Anya. He tried to thank her, but the words would not leave his throat.

\* \* \*

"Togan!"

The sentry was calling from outside Börü's tent. "The Khan wants you. The council has gathered."

Togan looked toward the path that descended into the forest. A few steps down it and the trees would hide the tents. He would not find a better hour to leave unseen.

He remembered the way Kaya had looked at him. Then the warm bowl Anya had held out.

He wiped the mud from his face with his sleeve and walked to the Khan's tent.



Inside, the smells of sooty torch smoke and melting bison fat mingled in the air. A map of the Pale Steppes covered the table, with Azgut forces marked by stone bison.

Sky-Eye Börü stood at its head. Nearly twenty years of rule had carved fine lines around his eyes. His face seemed to soften when Togan entered. A moment later, the Khan's expression returned.

"Come. I need your judgment."

Togan approached the table.

Ozan, an old warrior scarred by battle, pointed his bone rod west of the river. "Korgan has moved his main force to this side of the Sarmaşan. The Bison Riders are gathering at the Weeping Rock pass."

"He may be drawing us west so he can strike from the east," one of the elders said.

Börü indicated the stones before Togan. "What would you do in Korgan's place?"

Togan stared at the stone bison. Flames rose between them and blackened the leather surface of the map. The roof of a house collapsed. A woman was trapped inside.

"Togan?"

He looked up. "What?"

Ozan brought his bone rod down on the table. "The Khan is speaking to you. Where is your mind?"

"In the fire from a year ago." Togan's jaw tightened. "While you arrange stones in here, the Ember-Fires are out there. Burning villages. Killing people."

Anya was also present at the council. "The Ember-Fires are a wound scattered across the land. The Azgut army is a knife at our door. We have to choose which one to stop first."

"I've chosen."

Börü planted both hands on the table. "Your first duty is to this camp. To this oath. My father never set you apart from his own son. Is this what you leave him in return?"

Togan's anger suddenly lost its direction. He could not look at anyone around the table.

As the silence lengthened, the arrangement of stones settled into place in his mind. Korgan's display of force was too obvious. Weeping Rock was where he wanted his enemy looking.

"The pass is bait," Togan said. "Korgan will come through the river shallows at dawn. He'll make it seem as though he's pulled his main force west, then strike from the eastern bank."

Ozan separated the stone bison on the east bank with two fingers. "The spring flood changed the shallows. Half their horses will sink in the mud."

"The first half," Togan said. "The rest will find a road over their backs. Korgan isn't afraid to lose men."

Börü drew three eagle markers closer to the edge of the map. "Kaya will take two Windlisteners to the eastern line before sunrise. Ozan, put out the fires at Weeping Rock. We won't let him know we've seen the bait."

"We can stop a hundred riders at the eastern shallows," one elder said. "What if a thousand come?"

Börü's finger came down inside Eaglehold's inner ring. "Then every tent goes to war."

Togan thought of the place his own tent occupied on the leather map. A few lines and a nameless patch of empty space. Korgan's attack was real. Even so, his need to hunt the Ember-Fires had not diminished. He merely saw more clearly now what he would be leaving behind.

Ozan bent over the map. Börü was about to speak, but Togan had already reached the tent flap.

\* \* \*

Dawn was baring the teeth of the mountains. Togan entered his tent, buckled on his sword, and took up his bow and quiver. His hand trembled as he fastened the bone clasp in his palm to his belt. He wiped his cheek with the back of a finger. Realizing the wetness was not sweat only made him angrier.

He looked out at the camp through the gap in the tent. Börü's orders were passing from fire to fire. Kaya was gathering the raiders, while Anya sent the children and elders into the inner ring. Everyone was hurrying to take their place before the attack.

Togan's place should have been beside them.

He gripped the hilt of his sword. As it had for a year, Melira's scream reached him before his decision did.

"Forgive me," he said. "I can't."

The saddlebag he had prepared lay beneath his bed. Four days of dried meat, two waterskins, a spare bowstring, enough silver to pay a healer if he needed one, and the bone clasp Melira had left behind. Each piece of the preparation proved that this was not a decision made that morning, but a betrayal he had been nurturing for weeks.

He slung the bag over his shoulder and stepped outside. A boy training for sentry duty ran up to him with a loose saddle strap in his hands.

"Togan, will it hold if I tie it like this?"

Togan knelt. He took the strap from the boy, threaded it twice through the buckle, then tucked the end beneath it so it would not slip.

"When the horse panics, it will put all its strength against this. Don't mount until you've pulled it tight once more."

The boy tested the strap. "Are you going to the eastern line?"

Togan had one heartbeat in which to tell the truth. "Listen to Kaya," was all he said.

The boy ran off. Togan did not correct what he had misunderstood.

Burkut settled on his shoulder. Togan followed the deserted path behind the tents to the enclosure where the horses were kept.

Bozkır raised his head at the sight of him. The horse, the color of pale grass, pressed his muzzle to Togan's chest when he approached.

"We're leaving, my friend."

He fixed the saddle and took the reins. In the brief confusion of the changing watch, he slipped out behind the enclosure. Once he had passed the final tent, he stopped and looked back.

The fires of Eaglehold were fading in the ash-gray light of morning. Togan turned the reins. Bozkır walked at first, then broke into a run when he found open ground.

When the last fire behind him disappeared beyond the hill, Burkut lifted from his shoulder and found the wind opening north.

## Chapter 2 — The Young Wolf and Dying Fires

*(TEMUJIN)*

The wind carried cooking smoke and half a war song from the encampment below to the crest of the hill.

Temujin could distinguish each of the hundreds of fires. The largest ring belonged to Korgan. Toygun's tents stood to its west; Batur's lay beyond the dry streambed. From a distance, they were all fires of the same army. Up close, he knew, each circle heeded a different promise and a different fear.

Korgan saw only the multitude of flames. Temujin counted the darkness between them as well.

"You may be the only man alive who studies the stars to plan a war."

He did not turn. He knew those heavy, measured steps. One-Eye Orkhon saw more with his remaining eye than most men did with two.

"I'm not looking at the stars."

"What are you looking at?"

"How many fires need to be put out." Temujin indicated the ring around Korgan's camp. "His burns brightest. Toygun's is burning, and so is Batur's. They bend in the same wind and mistake themselves for a single fire."

Orkhon stopped beside him and folded his arms across his chest. "The smoke from calculations like that reaches the Khan's tent."

"I'm not calculating a rebellion."

"What are you calculating?"

Temujin did not answer. He was twenty-four. He had laughed the first time he heard the name Young Wolf, then seen what it did to people. Now he neither praised nor rejected it. A useful name was no different from a well-honed knife.

He would not challenge Korgan. By the time the Khan died, it should already be clear which fire the clans would turn toward.

"Your father used to speak that way before he learned silence," Orkhon said.

Temujin's molars pressed together. No one had given Orkhon the right to speak of his father, and Temujin had never managed to take it from him.

"My father paid the price for his ambition. I won't make the same mistake."

"Was the mistake wanting too much, or moving too soon?"

Temujin watched one of the fires below go out. Darkness immediately filled the space between the tents.

"Moving too soon," he said. As he spoke, he was not certain it was the right answer.

A line of young warriors was returning from the training ground, all marching at the same pace with their shields on their left shoulders.

"There are fifty of them now," Orkhon said. "A large number for a personal guard."

"My clan is growing."

"Is that what you told Korgan?"

"Before he asked."

One corner of Orkhon's mouth moved. On paper, the Young Wolves were Temujin's guards. In truth, they were men he had chosen and taught to fight together, men who knew one another's names before they knew how the spoils would be divided. Fifty men could not overthrow a Khan. Fifty could become the core of five hundred.

"Doesn't Bison-Heart Batu see this core?"

"He does. He thinks I'm strengthening the army."

"Is he wrong?"

"Not today."

By the time they reached the training ground, the young men had formed two ranks. Sube held a formation drawn on a scrap of hide and was trying to switch two warriors in the third row. Both men were older than he was. When one grumbled, Sube folded the hide and tucked it into his belt.

"The command isn't mine," he said. "The formation is Temujin's."

The warrior fell silent when Temujin approached.

"Continue," Temujin said.

Sube corrected the third row, then divided the fifty men into teams of five. He confused two names; Temujin did not correct him. When the drill began, the warrior called by the wrong name reacted half a beat late and left the shield of the man beside him exposed.

Temujin thrust his wooden sword between them and stopped the blow.

"If you don't know a man's name, you won't notice the gap he leaves," he told Sube.

Sube's face reddened. He repeated both names correctly.

"Again."

The teams formed up once more. This time, no shield stood alone in the first clash. Temujin removed a large warrior from the front rank after he made the same mistake for the third time. He replaced him with a weaker man who listened for his neighbor's breathing.

Orkhon watched the entire drill in silence. "You arrange men by one another, not by their swords."

"A sword only kills the man in front of it. A formation decides who lives beside you."

"Teaching that to Korgan's commanders would make your work harder."

"I won't teach them."

Temujin did not underestimate Batu. Ignoring a man who could cleave a shield with one swing of his axe was a calculation that began with the wrong number.

Orkhon spat on the ground. "Korgan's throne is too small for you."

Temujin turned to him for the first time.

"Korgan wants to unite the steppe. I want to see the day Metheris's walls fall. The steppe is only the beginning of the road."

Orkhon's good eye narrowed. This time he was not weighing the son of an old friend, but the man he might one day serve—or stop with his own hands.

"Then make a list of everyone who can kill you before your first step," he said. "Korgan isn't the whole of it."

"The list is ready."

"Ready lists age quickly."

Bison-Heart Batu appeared at the entrance to the training ground. A broad-bladed axe rested on his shoulder. He did not carry its haft like an object, but like an extension of his arm. For a time, he watched the Young Wolves hold their formation.

"Ranks of five break apart in a narrow pass," he said.

Temujin turned to him. "They hold on an open plain."

"War doesn't let you choose the ground."

"A good commander forces war to give him the choice."

The two men beside Batu laughed. Batu did not. He took one of the training shields, drove into the warrior in the front rank, and forced him back two steps.

"What will you use to force this?"

Temujin looked at Sube. Without waiting for an order, the young warrior sent two men to Batu's flanks. One pinned the axe haft with his shield. The other pressed a wooden sword behind Batu's knee. A third man braced the first warrior by the shoulder.

Batu could have torn the axe free and thrown all three aside. He did not. He dropped the shield.

"Not bad," he said. The praise was for Temujin, not Sube. "Korgan will ask what you're preparing them for."

"He knows my answer."

"When a Khan hears the same answer twice, he looks for a third." Batu settled his axe on his shoulder. "So do I."

As he left, he studied the faces of the Young Wolves one by one. Temujin could not calculate how many of them Batu knew. For the first time, he put a question mark beside Batu's name instead of a firm number.

Below them, laughter replaced the ring of swords. As the fifty young men gathered around the fire, Temujin counted the empty places.

Orkhon rested a hand on Temujin's shoulder. There was no fatherly comfort in the touch. One commander was reminding another of his weight.

"Be patient. The steppe feeds those who hurry, but it asks for their corpses first."

"I am being patient."

"I know. That's what frightens me."

Orkhon descended the hill. For a while, only the breadth of his back was visible in the dark. Then he, too, disappeared among the tents.

\* \* \*

The wind turned north.

Temujin tried to separate the scents it brought him. Wet stone. Old iron. They did not belong to the steppe. Anything foreign was counted as a danger first and judged useful only afterward.

On his way down to the encampment, he stopped outside Earth-Mother Yeva's tent. The felt flap stood half open. Inside, the old woman sat before a meager fire, holding a bison bone over the flames.

The bone cracked.

Yeva turned it, examined the fracture, and held it out to the fire again. A second sound came from the same place. Her fingers went still.

"Earth-Mother?"

Yeva raised her head. Her gaze failed to settle on Temujin's face and drifted beyond his shoulder. She opened her mouth, but could find no words for what she meant to say. She dropped the bone onto the earth and pressed a palm to her chest.

Temujin had watched seers fall into trances since childhood. Another riddle for the morning, he thought. For now, he had fifty living men to concern himself with.

He continued on. His eyes remained on the fires, the sentries, and the darkness between the tents. The northern horizon reddened above him, but he did not lift his gaze from the ground.

The smell of wet iron followed him all the way to his camp.

## Chapter 3 — Iron of the Fjords

(KARIA)

The fog did not lift after dawn. It made no difference to Karia. She did not need sunlight to tell whether a harbor was working.

The Northern Fleet's flagship, *Oath of the Drowning Mother*, lay moored at the quay. From its deck she could see every descent of the cargo cranes, every jam at the warehouse doors, and which pier had workers standing idle. Barrels of salted fish went one way, ingots of forged tide-steel another. The North Beacon was nothing but a pale yellow circle in the fog.

Karia was forty-five and had spent most of her life in the winds of the fjords. She kept her hair in a tight braid at the nape of her neck and wore old



tide-steel armor on deck instead of court dress. The split in its left shoulder had been repaired three times. Three times, she had refused the offer of a replacement. Steel whose fracture she knew was safer than steel whose temperament she did not.

"Admiral."

The young officer was trying to shield the inventory scroll in both hands from the wind.

"The Third and Seventh Fleet inspections are complete. No rot in the hulls. The Current Dust stores, however..."

Karia did not let him stop. "How much are we short?"

"Thirty percent compared with this time last year."

"Will it last until the Harvest?"

"The stewards say it will."

"The stewards aren't the ones sailing." Karia pulled the top sheet from the scroll. She needed only one pass through the numbers. "Set aside two months of wartime allotments for every ship. Divide the rest by days on patrol, not rank. Send word to Lord Drennar as well. I want two more fjord ships before Crimson Week."

"If the shipyard moves to night shifts, the workers—"

"Charge the night wages to the campaign budget. If the foreman tries to speed the work with a whip, throw him out of the yard."

The officer saluted and left, trying not to show his relief.

Karia called after him. "What's your name?"

The young man stopped. "Lieutenant Marr, Admiral."

"Don't bring me the stewards' calculation as though it were yours again, Lieutenant Marr. If you're going to be wrong, do it yourself."

"Yes, Admiral."

Karia turned back to the quay. The Mist Workers moved with their loads on their backs and their heads bowed. Every barrel bore two tax seals: the king's tithe and the lords' tithe. The palace called it the double tithe. On the docks, it was called hunger.

"Your thoughts look expensive this morning."

The voice came from the stern. Karia did not turn.

"Faelan. So the rat traps still aren't working."

The man who ran Metherris's underworld network joined her. He dressed neither as a soldier nor as a noble. His dark merchant's coat looked plain, though anyone who knew the cloth would recognize a dockworker's yearly wage hanging from his shoulders.

Faelan leaned against the rail. "Traps aren't much use when the rat is the one setting them, my lady."

"Tell me what you brought."

"One of Lord Severin's convoys left the Northern Campaign Road last night and turned toward the foothills of the White Rampart. The manifest says frontier patrol supplies. The wagons were too heavy for that cargo. The escorts weren't Severin's soldiers, either. Hired blades. New faces, full purses."

Karia folded the sheet in her hand. Rumors of weapons moving to the steppe had circulated for months. For the first time, the rumor had left wheel tracks.

"Azgut or Sungur?"

"That answer costs more."

"Name the price."

Faelan smiled. "Let's see where the goods go first." He turned his head as though following a cargo boat through the harbor. "Severin has trusted neither the king nor the Council since he lost his son in the Harvest. He believes that if the steppe bleeds long enough, the Hegemony will come and claim whatever land remains. He doesn't care whose blood it is."

"This goes to the Council. The king should know as well."

"The king already carries one lost son in his mind." Faelan lowered his voice. "I'm not certain he can carry a lost convoy, too."

Karia turned to him. From another man, the words would have been an insult. If Faelan meant to insult someone, he did not bother with implication.

Prince Aldric had vanished on the northern campaign twelve years ago. Because no body had ever been found, King Theodoric still believed there were mornings when the door might open. As those mornings multiplied, the Council had begun making more decisions in his place.

"What does Vorlag know?" Karia asked.

Faelan traced a line through the water on the wet rail. "For three days, he's been closing the Council chamber for private meetings. I couldn't identify his visitor. But after every meeting, the same servant leaves the west wing and goes to Valerius's rooms."

Vorlag and Valerius hated each other. If they were sitting at the same table, something they both feared more than each other lay upon it.

Theodoric's old succession clause had become a palace whisper. More people were beginning to guess who might be chosen.

"They're weighing me," she said.

"They're preparing for the day when weighing won't be enough." Faelan split the line of water with one finger. "I can't always watch your back. I sell my loyalty for the highest price. Today you're paying it. Tomorrow they may open the market again."

Karia trusted Faelan's candor more than the oaths sworn in the Council.

"If the market opens, bring me the first offer. For now, follow Severin's convoy. And learn the servant's name."

Faelan inclined his head. He descended the gangway and disappeared among the porters. Despite the costly coat, he was difficult to pick out after only a few steps.

Karia left the ship as well. The line for the scales stretched outside the Current Dust warehouse. A steward pointed out the seal on each barrel while dockworkers carried them inside. Karia stopped in the middle of the line and chose a barrel at random.

"Open it."

The steward's hand slowed on its way to the keys at his belt. "The seal count is complete, Admiral."

"Is the Dust count complete?"

They pried off the lid. The dark crimson grains inside sat two handspans below the rim. The ledger showed the barrel as full.

The steward spoke at once. "It settled on the road. Current Dust settles with time."

Karia plunged her hand into the barrel and poured a measure of Dust onto the scale. Then she ordered the sealed barrel beside it opened. The level in the second stood higher.

"When one load settles and another doesn't, sailors call it theft."

The workers lowered the barrels they carried. Someone coughed at the end of the line. No one spoke.

"The entire warehouse will be weighed again," Karia said. "Whoever is responsible for the missing share will pay from his property, not his wages. If anyone touches a worker's daily pay, come directly to me."

The steward went pale. "The Council appointed me."

"The Council doesn't pull an oar in the Fleet's warehouse."

Karia wiped the crimson grains from her hands with a cloth. Theft did not account for the entire thirty-percent shortfall, but a single underfilled barrel was enough to show which hands the numbers had passed through.

\* \* \*

One edge of the fog thinned. When the northern sky opened briefly, the Crimson Host showed through the morning light like a pale wound.

Karia had seen that redness as a child. Sailors said it had grown over the years, while seers found a different meaning in it every season. Karia disliked passing judgment on what she could not measure. Even so, it took her longer than she expected to look away that morning.

A rope came loose on deck. A young hand reached out as the pulley began to spin.

"Move your hand!" Karia shouted.

The deckhand jumped back. The rope struck the deck like a whip. Karia went to him and tied the knot herself, then summoned the officer of the watch.

Rope burns had reddened the young sailor's palms. Karia took one hand and made him bend each finger in turn.

"I can move them," the boy said.

"Go to the healer. You won't return to the deck today."

"But my watch—"

"Every pulley will be inspected again today. Bring the Current Dust ledgers to my cabin as well."

"What if the Council summons you?"

Karia pulled the knot tight one last time. "They know where to find me."

## Chapter 4 — The Sea Ghost

(ZALEENA — SEVENTEEN DAYS LATER)

The fog along the Whisper Road had erased the line between water and sky.

At the helm of the *Sea Ghost*, Zaleena read the slight changes in the whiteness. Darker fog meant rock; a wrinkle in the water meant a contrary current. She had spent most of her thirty-five years in these waters. She could not reach shore with her eyes closed, but she could leave this passage alive more readily than a captain who shouted his orders.

"Starboard twenty."

The sailor at the helm turned the wheel without a word. The ship heeled right.

No one shouted orders aboard the *Sea Ghost*. The drunken roars on Roric's ships might sound like courage from a distance. In the Razor Reefs, noise revealed the position of an approaching hull.

The first reef tooth appeared off the starboard bow. A wet black spur slid past an oar's length from the hull. Then came the second tooth. Zaleena knew the name of every rock and the temper each current took on over the course of a day.

Sorin approached with a small lantern cupped beneath his palm.

"Captain. The Delta cargo is in the hold. They sent a question from the Reed Throne as well."

"Ask it."

"Has anyone seen a strange creature on the Orphan Shores this past month? Armored. Moves on land and in the water, hunts in packs."

Zaleena's right hand tightened on the tiller. Sorin would not have seen it without the lantern.

"The fishermen in the southern cove mentioned rust-colored tracks," she said. "They've named it the Rust Tide."

"We laughed at them then."

"If the Delta isn't laughing, neither are we." Zaleena turned the bow into a paler vein of fog. "Send word to every pair of eyes I have along the coast. Whatever they see, they tell me first. Not the tavern, and not Roric."

Sorin inclined his head and withdrew.



When the last rock of the passage fell behind them, the fog tore like a curtain. The lights of Patchwork Harbor appeared through the final dark of night, seeping between half-sunken hulls and houses built from wreckage leaning one against another.

Zaleena had returned to this harbor thousands of times. On every approach, she looked first for which lights had gone missing. Two lanterns were out on the western pier. A new red lamp hung outside the Cracked Skull. Roric's banner sagged from its mast in the windless air.

The city was not as lawless as everyone believed. Its laws simply were not written down.

The *Sea Ghost* came alongside the outer quay. Lines went around the bollards, and the gangplank settled into place with a single creak. When Zaleena stepped ashore, the smells of salt, tar, and cheap liquor mingled around her.

The dock clerk came forward as soon as he saw the Delta mark on the cargo. Roric's copper token hung around his neck, and he carried a ledger board blackened with grease.

"Foreign goods," he said. "The harbor takes one-third."

Sorin began to object. Zaleena raised one arm slightly.

"It was one-fifth last month."

"Roric's campaign tax."

"No campaign tax without a Council ruling."

The clerk shrugged. "Tell it to his hook."

Zaleena ordered the first chest from the hold opened. Inside were not strips of dried deep kelp, but three small medicine vials wrapped in reed paper.

"Choose your third."

The clerk looked at the vials. "What are they?"

"Fever medicine. If you take one, write down which child on the inner quay will go without it."

The crew waiting behind the cargo went silent. The clerk tucked the copper token inside his shirt.

"One-fifth," he said. "The old rate."

Zaleena closed the chest. "Put that in the ledger."

As they walked on, Sorin leaned close to her ear. "Is there really medicine in those vials?"

"Two of them."

"And the third?"

"Salt water."

Sorin turned his head to hide a laugh. Zaleena did not laugh.

"Zaleena."

The voice came from the shadow of a post farther down the quay. Zaleena stopped, composed her face, and turned.

Faelan emerged from the dark. A man who had traveled from Metheris to Patchwork Harbor in seventeen days should have borne some mark of the road. Even his boots were clean.

"I didn't know you'd be here," Zaleena said.

"I didn't know when you'd return." Faelan drew a short breath through his nose. "You've been dealing with the Delta. The scent of the last cargo you stole from Lady Karia's ship is still on you."

"Don't come any closer to smell it."

Faelan stopped. His smile remained; his feet obeyed the command.

"Roric is trying to gather every captain for a major campaign. Word is the target is Metheris. Your ship isn't on the list."

"Roric's lists don't bind me."

"Because you're waiting." Faelan lowered his voice. "If he wins, you'll know which captains will follow him. If he loses, you'll take the place he leaves empty. Standing ready for both endings is a quiet game."

"I know you like quiet games."

"The good ones."

"My brother thought you were good, too." Zaleena did not look away from him. "Until the day you decided he was expendable."

Faelan's smile died. It lasted only a heartbeat; for Zaleena, that was enough.

"That was a different time," Faelan said. "A different account."

"Every one of your dead is the result of a different account."

Beyond the quay, a drunk laughed. Faelan did not turn toward the sound.

Zaleena passed him without brushing his shoulder. "Tell Roric the *Sea Ghost* won't join his campaign. I keep my own accounts."

"Everyone says that," Faelan called after her. "Until someone else pays the balance with his life."

Zaleena kept walking. Faelan did not call a second time.



Rusty Finn's workshop occupied the harbor's farthest corner. The room had been built into the stern of a half-sunken ship and held upright by crooked braces. The sound of a chisel came from it day and night.

Zaleena knocked twice and went in.

Finn was shaping a curved plank at his bench. An unfinished boat model sat on the table. When he saw Zaleena, the chisel stopped in midair. The old man's gaze searched her face, then the doorway behind her shoulders.

"You took the Whisper Road again."

"A road other captains don't use is safer."

"It took me that way, too." Finn set the chisel on the table. "Twenty-eight years, and I can still hear the water beneath that rock."

Zaleena did not turn to the window with him. She knew the names of the crew Finn had lost. She also knew that counting them again would bring no one ashore.

She pointed to the model with her chin. "You've kept the keel narrow."

Finn reached for it. "For shallow passages. Light and fast. With the right sail, it'll find wind where larger ships can't go."

"Who commissioned it?"

"No one." Finn brushed shavings from the wood with his thumb. "No one asks me for ships anymore. I build because my hands don't know how to stop."

Zaleena lifted the model. She studied the line of the keel, the position of the mast, the angle of the section that would sit below the water. It was light. It looked built to flee; in the right hands, it could also approach in silence.

She put the model down. "Finish it."

Finn looked at her with suspicion.

"If it floats well, you'll build the real thing," Zaleena said. "I'll pay for it."



Finn held the model's keel between two fingers. "It needs light timber. The wood here is cracked, and the Delta sells theirs on debt."

"There are three old fjord boats in the western wreckfield."

"Their keels are dry."

Finn narrowed his one eye. "Stripping them will take six men and two weeks."

"I'll give you four men. You can have them for three weeks. In return, only you, I, and the men doing the work will know the measurements."

"What if Roric asks?"

"Tell him it's a fishing boat."

"That would be a lie."

"It will carry fishermen, too."

The toothless gap in Finn's mouth showed for a moment. "Is that how pirate queens give their word?"

"I'm not a queen."

"No one has asked you what you are yet."

Zaleena took her hand from the model. "Finish the boat, Finn."

The old man did not answer. He picked up the chisel again. The first strike was uncertain. The second found its place.

When Zaleena left the workshop, Sorin was waiting against the rail.

"What do we tell Roric?"

"Nothing yet." Zaleena listened to the dark water beyond the harbor. The waves struck the reefs at their usual intervals. "Wake the messengers along the coast. Rust-colored tracks, torn nets, missing animals... Whatever they find, I want it on my table before dawn."

Sorin ran off. The sound of Finn's chisel joined the waves at measured intervals.

## Section 2 — Whispers and Thrones

### Chapter 5 — Whispers of the Shadowveil

*(TOGAN)*

At dawn on the third day, the grass ended.

The last plains below the White Rampart gave way first to damp hills, then to trees crowded close together. For two days, Togan had followed abandoned game trails. With every league, the sky narrowed a little more. On the steppe, the wind told a man where he was. Here, no sound offered direction but water dripping from leaves.

He stopped his horse at the edge of Shadowveil Forest.

Ironbark trees met overhead and cut off the daylight. Mistvines hung between moss-covered trunks, and layers of rotting leaves swallowed the horse's hooves. Scattered king's candles glimmered like pale spots in the dark.

Bozkır whinnied and tried to back away.

"I don't want to, either," Togan said. "We have no other road."

Burkut could find no room to spread his wings among the low branches. Twice he tried to take flight; both times he returned to Togan's shoulder. His talons gripped the leather harder than usual.

Togan dismounted and took the reins. Riding among the roots would be loud as well as dangerous. On the steppe, dust gave away an approaching rider. In this forest, something could remain hidden until its breath touched his face.

Rain began toward evening. At first it tapped against the leaves, then became a ceaseless roar in the canopy. Togan sheltered in the hollow of an old ironbark. He did not light a fire. He tore off a piece of dried meat for himself and set before Burkut the forest mouse the eagle had caught that day.

As darkness fell, the rain confused every direction. Togan sat with his sword across his knees and his back against the damp bark. Whenever his eyes closed, he forced them open again.

Burkut suddenly abandoned the mouse. He leaped onto Togan's shoulder and gave a low growl.

Togan straightened.

Another sound moved beneath the rain. A dry clicking like stones rubbing together in a sack. A branch broke to his right. Then another to his left.

Rustjaws.

They were not supposed to range this far south. He could not see how many there were, only hear the clicking change position within the forest.

He released Bozkır's lead and leaned close to the horse's ear. "Run."

He slapped the animal's hindquarters. Bozkır took two steps back, then found a gap between the trees and plunged into the dark. Togan did not ask himself whether he would see the horse again as the hoofbeats receded. If he did, he would follow.

The first creature emerged from the brush. Then two more.

Rain streamed over the hard plates in their patchy hides. Each time their jaws opened and closed, rust-colored crusts at the roots of their teeth struck together. The three separated and formed a half circle around Togan.

Togan put his back to the tree and drew his sword. Left foot forward. He slowed his breathing.

The largest lunged for his legs. Togan moved aside at the last instant. The creature's jaws closed on the tree bark. Togan brought his sword down in both hands and split the joint where its foreleg met its body. As the rustjaw tried to turn, his second blow took it in the neck and sent it crashing among the leaves.

The other two did not wait.

He met the one from the right with his blade. The impact numbed his arms. The creature on the left came in low at the same moment and raked open Togan's calf.

His knee struck the ground.

Burkut plunged from above with a scream. He spread his wings over the creature's face and drove his talons into its eye sockets. As the rustjaw

thrashed its head, Togan rose and thrust his sword into the soft space beneath its jaw. Hot blood ran as far as his hand.

The third creature struck his shoulder. Togan fell onto his back, and his sword slipped from his hand and caught against a root. The rustjaw's teeth snapped shut above his face. Togan braced his left forearm against its throat and tried to hold the jaws away. Beneath the weight, his wounded leg was giving way.

His fingers found the sword hilt.

There was no room to lift the steel from the ground. He set its point against the creature's belly and pushed with both hands. The rustjaw convulsed and collapsed more heavily on top of him. Togan stabbed again. Then again.

The creature's jaws went still.

Togan rolled the carcass off and propped himself against the tree. Blood from the cut in his leg mingled with the rain and filled his boot. Burkut stood over the creature he had killed, wings spread, screaming into the forest dark.

The largest rustjaw moved again. It dragged its severed foreleg beneath its body and tried to crawl. Togan raised his sword; his arm began to shake halfway up. He found the breathing slit between the creature's plates, placed the point there, and pressed. The clicking stopped.

Burkut tried to leap onto the second carcass. Togan caught the eagle by the leg. A thin cut lay beneath his left talon, blood running through his feathers in the rain.

"Enough."

The eagle struck the sword hilt with his beak. Togan held Burkut against his chest and felt for the depth of the wound. The eagle struggled, then went still. Togan had made the only living thing to remain beside him since Melira's death pay the price of his anger, too.

"Burkut."

The eagle settled close. Togan tore a strip from the hem of his shirt and wrapped his calf. His vision darkened when he pulled the knot tight.

He could not stay. The smell of blood would draw other packs.

Using his sword as a staff, he began to walk. He did not know which way he was going. He could only hope that rising ground meant north. Once, he

thought he heard hoofbeats in the distance. He wanted to call Bozkır's name, but kept his teeth closed rather than tell the forest where he was.

When the rain eased, he saw a straight line between the trees—a stone wall too even to be natural, too old to keep the vines from swallowing it.

It was an Ancients' watchtower.

He drove his shoulder into the door. The rotted wood broke inward. Togan fell onto the stone floor and could not rise.

\* \* \*

When consciousness returned, his cheek was pressed to cold stone. The storm howled in the arrow slits, and now and then claws scraped beyond the door.

He planted one hand on the floor to push himself up.

A thin, taut cord lay beneath his fingers.

The cord snapped. Animal bones hanging from the ceiling clattered against the stone wall.

A rusted sword came to his throat.

"Don't move."

The face of a lean man appeared in the dark. He wore the weathered leathers of a Hegemony soldier. His beard had grown long, and sleeplessness had reddened his eyes. The hand holding the sword did not tremble.

"Or I'll open your throat like a goat's."

Togan raised his head against the pressure of the metal. "Move it."

The man pressed the blade harder. "What did you say, steppe rat?"

"If you mean to cut me, then cut." Togan glanced toward the door. Outside, claws tested the wood again. "They'll come to the smell of blood. They'll eat you first, then me. Or you lower the sword, and we remain two living men until dawn."

The man listened at the door. "How do I know you're not a bounty hunter?"

"A bounty hunter wouldn't lead three rustjaws to your door and break it down."

"Three?"

"Not anymore."

The sword withdrew from his throat. The man took two steps back without lowering the weapon.

"Until dawn," he said. "Then you leave. This place is mine."

Togan dragged himself to the wall. "Until dawn."

Gareth saw the trail of blood on the floor. He took a small flask from his belt and rolled it toward Togan.

"Don't drink it. Wash the wound."

Togan smelled the stopper. Strong liquor. When he poured it over the cut, the muscles in his leg clenched on their own. He locked his jaw against a cry.

"Leave rustjaw blood in a wound and you'll be feverish by morning," Gareth said.

"How do you know?"

"I buried three men."

Togan could have kept half the flask for himself. Instead he poured what remained over Burkut's talon. The eagle struck his face with one wing, then climbed onto Togan's knee and tucked the wounded foot beneath his feathers.

Gareth watched. "A Sungur doesn't give his eagle a share before taking his own."

"He gave me one."

"What?"

Togan thought of the carcasses outside. "Time."

He rolled the flask back. Gareth closed it and returned it to his pocket. The distance between them did not change, but the point of his sword no longer faced Togan's chest.

They settled into opposite corners of the tower. They did not light a fire. Sometimes the creatures circling outside scraped their claws against the stone; then the sound vanished into the rain.

Long afterward, the man spoke from the dark.

"What's your name?"

"Togan."

"Gareth." A short silence. "What are you doing here in this condition?"

Togan rested his head against the wall. He did not speak Melira's name.

"Looking for the north."

"The north is large."

"The Wall of Light."

Gareth's dry laugh echoed through the tower. "Kings have searched for it. Beggars and madmen, too. Those who found it never came back."

"I will find it."

Gareth did not laugh again.

While the claws tested the door outside, neither man let go of his sword. Dawn was still a long way off.

## Chapter 6 — The Unbowed Flame

*(TEMUJIN)*

The Karaçul camp held fifty-three tents, twelve horse pens, and three sentries.

Temujin waited on horseback in the shadow of the hill, reviewing the layout below one final time. Dawn was an hour away. The first sentry walked the northern fence. The second sat beside a dying fire. The third circled Toygun's tent.

The fifty Young Wolves behind him waited without speaking. Soft leather had been tied around the horses' muzzles to keep them from neighing.

"We're ready," Sube whispered.

The seventeen-year-old's gaze never stopped moving. Temujin had taken him close not because he was quick, but because he did not forget what he saw.

"Repeat the order."

"Take Toygun. Bind the sentries. Enter no other tent and touch no property."

"Blood?"

"Only if necessary."

Temujin nodded. "This isn't a raid. We take Toygun. We leave the camp untouched."

The Karaçul had come under Korgan's banner three months earlier. They had not joined willingly. They submitted after their winter stores were

burned. Toygun had concealed half of the latest tribute. If word reached Korgan, all fifty-three tents would go up in flames.

Word had not reached Korgan. Temujin had made certain of that.

He lowered his hand. Fifty riders left the hill without a sound.

Sube reached the northern sentry. He covered the man's mouth and struck behind his knee; two Young Wolves bound him when he fell. The man beside the fire was asleep. When the third sensed movement, Temujin was already behind him. The sword pommel struck his temple. As Temujin lowered him to the ground, he checked the man's pulse.

All three were alive.

Toygun's tent was larger than the others. Silver rings had been fastened to the leather strips at its entrance. The wealth hidden from his starving people began at the door.

Temujin went in alone.

Toygun sat upright in his bed, a knife in one hand and his fur in the other. When he saw Temujin, he did not lower the knife, only turned its point toward the ground.

"Where is the half of the tribute you hid?"

Toygun's gaze shifted to the entrance. No shouts came from outside. The silence frightened him more than a crowded assault would have.

"Korgan is bleeding us dry," he said. "If he takes the seed grain too, what will the children eat this winter?"

"You didn't hide only seed. There's silver as well."

Toygun's knife lowered a little farther. "I was going to buy grain with it."

"From whom?"

No answer came.

Temujin dragged the low chest from beneath the bed with his foot. It was not locked. Beside a purse of silver lay two new saddles, a child-sized fur, and dried provisions enough for only five people.

"You meant to buy grain for fifty-three tents," Temujin said. "With provisions for five."

Toygun raised the knife again. "Korgan won't let this camp live. I won't leave my wife and children here."

"And the others' children?"



"Let their fathers find their own way."

A muffled cough came from outside. Someone had woken in the small section adjoining Toygun's tent. Temujin saw a child's bare foot beneath the leather curtain. Toygun saw it too. This time he held the knife not to attack, but to put himself between Temujin and that curtain.

"Take me to Korgan," he said. "Don't do it in front of the children."

Temujin's calculation did not change. Only the face of its cost became clear.

"Go outside."

Toygun settled the fur around his shoulders. Without looking toward the adjoining section, he walked to the entrance. Temujin followed and gave Sube a single signal. Two Young Wolves took Toygun behind his own tent.

"I know Korgan is wrong," Temujin said. "The seed you hid belonged to the children."

Toygun looked directly at him for the first time.

"Then—"

"The silver did not."

The hope that appeared on Toygun's face vanished before the knife hit the ground.

The sword fell once.

\* \* \*

At sunrise, the Karaçul gathered in the center of the encampment. Toygun's body lay before his tent beneath a felt covering. The three sentries were bound but alive. Sacks of hidden grain had been arranged where everyone could see them. The purse of silver hung from Temujin's saddle.

From horseback, Temujin studied the crowd. Toygun's wife knelt at the head of the felt, her two children pulled close beside her. She was not crying.

She stood before Temujin could speak. "You'll tell us you left the seed."

Temujin did not answer.

"Then, when my son is grown, you'll expect him to speak of the mercy shown by the man who killed his father." She rested a hand on the younger child's shoulder. "Don't."

The Young Wolves stirred. Sube lowered his eyes. Temujin did not order her silent.

"What is your name?" he asked.

"Sarnai."

Temujin wrote the name into his memory. "The seed grain is yours. It won't be sent to Korgan."

"I won't thank you for it."

"I didn't ask you to."

Sarnai knelt beside the felt again. One day, when Temujin calculated which fire the Karaçul would turn toward, he would have to count this scene as well.

"Toygun hid the tribute and lied," he said. He did not need to raise his voice. "He paid the price himself. No one will enter your homes. Your animals will not be taken. The seed grain stays with you."

The crowd shifted.

"Korgan would make the whole clan pay for one man's crime. I will not. I ask you to remain loyal not to me, but to the word you gave. I will keep mine as well."

No one answered.

He turned his horse. The Young Wolves left the camp in a single file. They had arrived as fifty men, and they departed as fifty. Behind them they left three living sentries, fifty-three standing tents, and one dead man.

Orkhon waited on the hilltop.

"You killed a man," he said when Temujin reached him. "Then you called it mercy."

"I didn't call it mercy."

"The Karaçul will."

"That's what I want them to say."

Orkhon studied him with his good eye. "Toygun's silver?"

"It goes to Korgan. The tribute will appear to have been delivered in full."

"The grain?"

"Stays in the village."

Orkhon released a short breath. "You killed one man, left an entire clan in your debt, and you'll have Korgan's thanks besides."

"They owe me nothing."

"Ask them."

They turned their horses toward the Great Camp. To the south, a grazing herd of bison suddenly drew together. Though no wolf or hunter was in sight, the lead animal ran north and hundreds followed. The earth rose beneath their hooves like a dark cloud.

Sube pointed at the herd in wonder. "They don't go north in this season."

Temujin studied the direction of their flight, then the empty land they left behind. A movement that had no place in his calculations.

"Keep your eyes open," he told Sube.

They did not follow the herd.

## Chapter 7 — Shadow of the Salt Throne

*(KARIA)*

The chamber of the Salt Throne smelled more like a cellar than the sea.

Over the centuries, salt had crusted the walls in layers, multiplying the torchlight into dull stains across the crystals. Karia always noticed the weight of the air first. With this much damp in a ship's hold, she would have dismissed the steward. In the palace, the same damp was called tradition.

King Theodoric III sat upon his throne. His silk robe hung from narrow shoulders, and his right hand kept turning his ring. His gaze gathered itself when Karia approached.

"Come closer. My ears aren't what they were."

Karia stopped three steps away and bowed her head. "Your Majesty."

"The stores." The king turned the ring once more. "Give me the true number."

So he had seen the stewards' optimistic calculation.

"Current Dust is thirty percent below last year. The Fleet has set aside its wartime allotment. If the Harvest comes on time, the shortfall will close."

"And if it doesn't?"

"We reduce patrols and keep the oldest ships in harbor. We take losses, but the navy remains operational."

Theodoric's fingers stopped. "Even bad news sounds like a repair list when you give it."

"If you can make a repair list, the ship hasn't sunk yet."

The king gave something like a brief laugh. Then his gaze wandered over the salt-coated walls.

"Twenty-eight years," he said. "Another Harvest is coming. My father never learned what lies beyond the Gate. Neither did his father. I was going to be the king who did."

It was not the first time Karia had seen Theodoric look this old. It was the first time she had seen him unwilling to hide it.

"The Gate can wait, Your Majesty. A starving city cannot."

The king's eyes sharpened again. "You want to save today. Vorlag tells me about yesterday." This time he turned the ring in the opposite direction. "Valerius promises tomorrow. Such a brilliant tomorrow that he thinks we won't have to count today's dead."

"Which promise of his do you mean, Your Majesty?"

Before answering, Theodoric looked at the guards flanking the throne. At his raised hand, both men stepped outside. The heavy doors closed, leaving only the crackle of salt in the chamber.

"Aldric has been missing for twelve years." The king's mouth struggled with his son's name. "If he were coming back, he would have returned by now."

Karia kept silent. For the first time, Theodoric had finished the sentence of his own will.

The king tried to remove his ring. When it caught on the swollen joint, he tugged at it in anger. Karia stepped closer and offered her hand. Theodoric drew back at first, then surrendered his fingers to her. Rather than twist the ring, Karia dipped his hand into the nearby bowl of water. The cold brought the swelling down enough for the ring to come free.

Theodoric held it in his palm. For years, the seven waves carved into the seal had been pressed into documents, orders of war, and notices of death.

"When Aldric was a boy, he used to steal this and stamp fish into the sealing wax," he said. "I scolded him every time. Now I'd give half the treasury to find one of those ruined seals."

Karia returned the bowl to its place. She could have found something comforting to say. The king did not need comfort, she thought. He needed the lie he had been telling himself to end.

"Have you stopped searching for him?"

"If a king announces the end of a search, he kills his son a second time." Theodoric did not put the ring back on. "If a father cannot stop, he turns his country into a waiting room."

"Who will sit on the throne when I die?" the king asked. "Some distant cousin Vorlag finds? Valerius's sword?"

"The Conqueror's will provides a third path."

"The Tide-Heir."

The word grew heavier once spoken in the salt chamber.

"What do you think, Karia?"

Karia thought of the warehouse ledger. Two rotting ships, missing Current Dust, shipyard workers facing a night shift. The crown would make none of them disappear. It would only pile them all onto her table.

"First, we survive the Harvest," she said. "Then you choose the person capable of carrying the Hegemony. Before the crown, we should consider the country that will lie beneath it."

Theodoric studied her for a long time. "You didn't say yes."

"I didn't say no."

The king rested his head against the throne. "You gave the safest answer. That's why I trust you." As he closed his eyes, he added, "And why they fear you."

\* \* \*

Karia drew a deep breath when she left the chamber. Even the dry stone smell of the corridor felt fresh.

At the junction leading to the western wing, Lord Vorlag stood speaking with Sir Valerius. Vorlag's hunched body kept close to the wall; Valerius occupied the center of the passage. Both men fell silent when Karia's armor sounded against the stone floor.

"Lady Karia." Vorlag hid his hands inside his wide sleeves. "Was your audience with His Majesty productive?"

"Every audience with the king is productive."

Valerius searched Karia's face for an answer. "I hope you impressed upon him the need for decisive action against the steppe. The people at the frontier pay the price of softness."

"I've seen the supply calculation for your campaign," Karia said. "The frontier people will be the first to starve."

Valerius's jaw tightened. "Victory has a cost."

"Your calculation includes no lost ships."

"You know the accounts of dockworkers well," Valerius said. "You may need to learn the accounts of palace bloodlines with equal care."

Vorlag glanced at the young knight. There was satisfaction in the look as well as warning. Valerius's threat had exposed what Vorlag preferred not to say.

Karia stepped closer. "I won't learn that reckoning from your ledger."

Valerius did not put his hand on his sword hilt. The slight rise of his right shoulder revealed that he had considered it.

"Will you speak this way before the Council?"

"Summon me and see."

Vorlag struck the stone floor with the tip of his cane. "Sir Valerius sometimes speaks in haste."

Karia remembered Faelan's report. Vorlag was not restraining Valerius. He was choosing the direction in which the younger man attacked.

"Sometimes?" Karia said.

She walked past them. Their conversation resumed behind her, more muted now.

At the stairs, Karia chose the road down to the harbor. Measurable problems awaited her on deck: how many barrels, how many ships, how many days.

## Chapter 8 — Council of Captains

*(ZALEENA)*

There was no room left to drink in the main hall of the Cracked Skull. Even so, the tavern was unusually quiet.

The captains had gathered around the long table in the back room, their crews waiting outside the door. In Patchwork Harbor, a crew waiting for its captain was preparing for either a new war or a new debt. Tonight, either was possible.

The Council met only once a year at most. Without a fleet threatening every ship, a common quarry, or a great wreck to divide, it was difficult to put twenty captains at the same table.

Roric had gathered them with a promise.

"The greatest prize in history."

One-Armed Roric stood at the head of the table. Empty cups jumped every time his hook struck the wood.

"When Crimson Week begins, the Hegemony fleet will sail north. While its ships guard the kelp harvest, the warehouses, guilds, and treasury of Metheris will remain ashore. We'll never find the city this exposed again."

Some of the captains leaned forward. Others folded their arms across their chests. Zaleena sat in the farthest corner, watching who looked at Roric and who measured a neighbor's reaction. She had not touched the cup before her.

Kessel scratched his scarred jaw. "The city walls don't disappear when the fleet sails. The guards remain, too. How many ships do you want?"

"All of them." Roric drove his hook into the table. "For the first time, Patchwork Harbor will be one fleet. One target and one route for a single night. Then we divide the spoils and go our separate ways again. We'll leave behind a campaign even the Crimson Siren couldn't have told."

Low conversation spread through the room. Roric spoke of gold, but what he sold them was legend. Zaleena understood that his true desire was not a share. He had grown old. He wanted his name to outlive him.

"What if we fail?" she asked.

The voices stopped. Roric turned his head.

"Silent Zaleena speaks. A blessed night."

"You didn't answer."

"We won't fail."

Roric said it to himself, not to the men around the table. It took him a second attempt to pull his hook from the wood.

"If every ship sails north, Metheris will learn of it before we arrive," Zaleena said. "A king doesn't leave his capital empty. He might make it appear empty."

Kessel nodded slowly. Two captains looked away. Roric saw their hesitation.

"You always choose the worst possibility."

"It's often the one that survives."

A brief laugh rose from one side of the table. Roric swallowed his anger and unfolded the map before him.

"Those who want fear can have it. Those who want victory can look at the route."

Captain Draven tapped two fingers on the table. "There is no calculation for the shares. We don't even know what the Metheris warehouses hold."

Roric threw three gold coins onto the edge of the map. "One share for every ship. A second for every captain. The first over the wall takes a third."

"The share of a dead crewman?" Zaleena asked.

Roric did not look at her. "Goes to his ship."

"And if his ship sinks?"

No one answered this time.

Kessel pulled the map toward him. "The return current reverses on the second night of Crimson Week. If we leave laden, we'll be rowing against it through the Razor Reefs."

"Then row faster," Roric said.

Zaleena watched the faces around the table. The promise of spoils had pulled the captains forward. Widows' shares and the returning water pressed them back into their chairs. Roric saw it too. He leaned over the map and softened his voice.

"We've carried the Hegemony's leavings for years. We drink their wine, pay for their steel, and hide among the reefs when we see their ships. Don't you want them to hide from us for one night?"

It was better bait than gold. Draven drew his knife. Before placing it on the table, he looked at Kessel. Kessel still waited.

They discussed the passage out of the Razor Reefs, the southern current, the approach by night, and the division of spoils. Zaleena listened without



saying a word. She remembered the names assigned to the vanguard ships, the piers that would be left behind, and the fact that no one asked for a supply calculation.

By the end of the meeting, twelve captains had placed their knives beneath Roric's mark. Three asked for until the following day. Kessel did not draw the knife from his belt.

Neither did Zaleena.

\* \* \*

Sorin waited outside the tavern. Night damp had made the planks of the quay slick; together they walked toward the *Sea Ghost*.

"How many?" Sorin asked.

"Twelve for certain. Two more will join if the share grows. Kessel's price isn't money. He wants to see a way home."

"And you?"

"I'm not going."

"Will you tell Roric?"

Zaleena stepped aside for a cargo cart. The barrels bore Hegemony seals. A harbor planning a war was drinking wine from the city it meant to plunder.

"No. He'll leave without my ship. If I stand against him, he'll fight me first."

"What if he wins?"

"He comes back stronger. Patchwork Harbor remains under his noise a while longer."

"And if he loses?"

Zaleena did not slow. "We see how many ships return. We calculate which families must be paid and which piers have lost their protection."

Sorin heard what she had not said. "Roric's place will be empty."

"A harbor isn't governed merely because one man's place is empty."

"You want to govern it."

Zaleena stopped. Light spilling from the Cracked Skull illuminated half of Sorin's face. The young man was curious, not mocking.

"I don't want Roric's crown," she said. "Or his legend for a night. I want this city to exist the next morning. A harbor where ships are entered in a

ledger, shares are divided by rule instead of by the sword, and we don't starve when the Delta withholds its money."

"A kingdom?"

"No." Zaleena looked at the crooked houses along the quay. "A place that stands by its own right."

One corner of Sorin's mouth moved. "Places like that have flags."

The word caught Zaleena unprepared. The thought she had carried for years sounded too real to hide once it came from someone else's mouth.

"Perhaps," she said. "But leave it here."

"Roric won't hear it."

"You will forget it before Roric does."

After a few steps, Sorin spoke again. "Why did you ask about the widows' shares?"

"Because no one else did."

"Do we have them on our ship?"

Zaleena's answer came late. A dead sailor's share aboard the *Sea Ghost* was divided among the surviving crew. For years, she had considered the arrangement fair; at least the captain did not take it all. The distinction meant nothing to a child waiting ashore.

"Tomorrow we'll make a record," she said. "First we'll learn who each person has left ashore. Then I'll put the shares before the Council."

Sorin nodded. "A widows' account before a flag."

"Knowing who waits before a flag."

When they reached the *Sea Ghost*, Zaleena raised her head and measured the bare mainmast. No banner flew from it that night.

For the first time, she had told someone else that it would not remain bare.

## Section 3 — Brand, Bone, Shield

### Chapter 9 — Whispers of the Branded

*(TOGAN)*

Dawn entered the tower as a pale bar of light through an arrow slit.

Togan had not slept during the night. In the opposite corner, Gareth had not lowered the sword from his knees. The scratching outside had stopped before the rain, leaving only the steady drip of water from the roof.

"Time's up," Gareth said.

Togan used the wall to pull himself upright. When he put weight on the wounded leg, the back of his knee clenched and the stone floor tilted for an instant. He caught his shoulder against the wall before he fell.

Gareth sheathed his sword. "You won't make a league on that leg."

"I will."

"Then they'll find you under a tree. Your sword will end up with a much better man."

Togan unwrapped the strip torn from his shirt. The cloth had stuck to the blood. His breath hissed between his teeth as he pulled it away.

Gareth crouched. "Give me that."

"I can tend my own wound."

"You did last night." Gareth pointed to the dirty cloth. "Not very well."

Togan did not object. Gareth took a cleaner strip from his bag and bound the wound again. His hands were a soldier's. He tightened the knot enough to hold the cloth, but not enough to cut off the blood.

The rain had stopped when they stepped outside. Togan put two fingers to his mouth and whistled for Bozkır. The forest took the sound and carried it away. No answer came.

He tried again.

Only Burkut glided down from a branch above and settled on his shoulder.

Gareth said nothing.

"There's a Branded village nearby," he said as they began to walk. "Three leagues south. A healer named Seren lives there. She may be able to save your leg."

"In return for what?"

"Not every kindness has to have a price."

Togan looked at him.

Gareth shrugged. "Most do. This one doesn't."

\* \* \*

With Togan's wound, three leagues took half the day. Every root sent a different pain through his leg. Gareth walked ahead and showed him where the ground was firm, but never offered a hand. Togan was grateful for that.

The sky appeared again as the forest thinned. Burkut rose above the branches and began tracing broad circles.

"Were you in the Tide Legions?" Togan asked.

The worn leather across Gareth's back still bore the scar of a removed insignia.

"Seven years."

"Then what?"

"I was ordered to burn a village."

"You didn't."

"I did." Gareth kept walking. "At the second village, I refused. A man in a hurry to think himself good soon forgets the first evil he committed."

Togan's foot caught on a root. He leaned on his sword until he found his balance.

"I was born a Mist Worker," Gareth continued. "I thought the army was a way out. The officer's command replaced the whip on the quay. It took me seven years to understand the difference."

They reached the clearing near midday.

The huts stood far apart. Above every door, small pieces of metal and bone hung from thin cords. They chimed whenever someone approached. People working in the gardens did not put down their tools when they saw Togan, only moved them within reach.

Dark crimson stains marked their faces and necks. On some, the marks descended to the fingertips. On others, they covered the skin around one eye.

A woman pulled her child behind the door. The child peered around her skirt to look not at Togan, but at Burkut.

Gareth went to the stone-footed hut at the center of the village. The chimes above it trembled before the door opened.

A middle-aged woman stepped outside. Crimson marks covered the left side of her face. She looked first at Gareth, then at Togan's leg.

"Inside."

Togan stopped at the threshold.

"I won't ask your clan," the woman said. "Or your god. Coming in before you bleed on the floor will be enough."

"Seren," Gareth said, "still hospitable."

"And you still leave wounded men on my doorstep."

\* \* \*

Seren softened the bandage with warm water before removing it. When she pressed the skin around the wound, Togan gripped the edge of the cot.

"Claw, not tooth," Seren said. "Good. If it had bitten you, the fever would already have started."

She took a dark greenish salve from a shelf. The scents of kelp and thyme filled the hut.

Togan frowned. "It smells of the Current."

"I made it from the residue." Seren worked the salve into the wound. The burning grew worse at first, then the throbbing inside his leg eased. "If we call everything that touches us cursed, we'll have no medicine left. Poison and remedy sometimes grow from the same root."

She tied on a clean bandage. "You'll stay in bed for three days."

"I don't have three days."

Seren pulled the basin in which she had washed her hands closer. "Then you may not have two legs. Your choice."

"I have to go north."

"The north isn't running away."

"I'm the one falling behind."

Seren dried her hands. "Where are you going?"

Togan considered how much he could tell a stranger. Gareth had learned in the dark tower. Once the words had escaped, they came more easily a second time.

"The Wall of Light."

Seren's hands stopped. "Others have passed through here saying the same thing."

"How many came back?"

"None."

Togan released the edge of the cot. "I will."

"They all said that." Seren studied his face. "But they told me what they expected to find at the Wall: gold, ancient weapons, immortality. You don't speak of what you'll find."

Togan glanced toward the door.

"You're looking for someone," Seren said.

His silence was answer enough.

Seren turned to the shelf and took down a small jar of salve. "You can take this when you leave. And this news as well: the Ember-Fires burned a frontier town three days from here. This time they didn't withdraw. They have settled around the ruins and are gathering anyone who comes."

Togan sat straighter. "Gathering people?"

"The dispossessed. The grieving. Anyone looking for a place to put their anger. They know how to turn a broken person into fire." Seren set the jar on the table. "There's plenty of kindling inside you for them to use."

When Togan stepped outside, Gareth was waiting against the wall.

"Three days," Togan said.

"Whatever Seren says."

"Then I'm going north."

Gareth scraped mud from the toe of his boot. "I won't go as far as the Wall. But I know the old patrol paths that join the Northern Campaign Road. I'll take you there."

"Why?"

"Because this time I won't leave someone in the forest." Gareth raised his head. "Don't ask for more than that."

Togan nodded.

They ate supper not in Seren's hut, but in the village's common yard. A place had been made for Togan along one side of the long table. The three people opposite him waited for him to remove his sword before taking up their spoons.

Togan unfastened his belt and leaned the weapon against the wall. At the sight of this, the child hiding behind the door emerged. A crimson mark covered half his face, splitting his right eyebrow as far as the hairline.

"Does the eagle bite?" he asked.

"If he wants to."

The child offered Burkut a piece of meat. The eagle looked at Togan first, then took it with the tip of his beak. The child laughed. For the first time, one of the adults at the table let his shoulders loosen.

An old villager stirred his soup. "Do the Sungur call us cursed, too?"

"We saw the Crimson Fever," Togan said. "Not the people who survived it."

"The Hegemony says the same. On tax day."

Togan had no answer. He thought of how people spoke of the Branded in his own camp: ill-omened, tainted, people the Current had left unfinished. Before sitting at this table, he had never objected.

Seren set a second bowl before him. "Cruelty a man claims not to believe in still does its work as long as he stays silent."

Togan picked up the spoon. "If I return, I'll tell them this."

The old man looked up. "If you return, first make certain you haven't forgotten what you saw."

He stayed in the village that night. When he lay down, the wound still burned, and the chimes above the doors sounded fitfully in the wind. Once more, he thought of whistling for Bozkır.

He buried the sound inside himself.

## Chapter 10 — What the Bones Say

*(TEMUJIN)*

Korgan's Great War Tent was large enough to seat sixty men in comfort. Even so, the Khan always gathered his warlords in a circle tight enough for their shoulders to touch. Men standing close listened better, and were caught more quickly if they tried to flee.

A single great torch burned amid the black bison hides. Korgan sat at the head of the table, Batu to his right and Orkhon to his left. When Temujin took his appointed place, the stones on the map had already been arranged.

Black bison encircled the Sungur lands.

"When the Harvest comes, we'll strike the final blow," Korgan said. His deep voice trembled through the tent hide. "They've hidden in the foothills for twenty-seven years. This time I will leave them no hole to crawl into."

Voices of approval rose around the table. Batu struck a fist against his chest.

Orkhon did not look up from the map. "As long as their eagle network stands, they'll see the army coming days in advance."

Korgan's single eye narrowed. "Let them."

"They saw us last time."

The tent fell silent. Korgan disliked men who reminded him of defeat. Orkhon knew it and did not alter his words.

"This time we crush them with numbers," the Khan said. "Every clan advances on the same day. I'll put a column in every pass they might use to escape."

Temujin calculated the distances on the map. Tens of thousands of horses would enter the same narrow front, the supply lines would lengthen, and the Sungur would withdraw into ground they had prepared. Victory was possible. What use the army would be afterward was less certain.

Opposing Korgan's plan directly was more dangerous than the plan itself.

"My Khan," he said. "If we take away the army's eyes, we'll spend fewer of our numbers."

Korgan turned to him. "Speak."



"The strength of the Sungur isn't the number of their warriors. Windlisteners fly eagles from every pass and hill. If we break their observation points before the main army advances, Börü won't know where you mean to strike."

Batu laughed. "You're going to chase eagles?"

"If the eagles have no nests to return to, we won't need to chase them." Temujin marked three heights on the map. "There are roughly four hundred Windlisteners. We don't attack them all. We sever the joints in the message chain. A small column moves in quickly, disables the towers, and vanishes before the main army marches."

Orkhon rearranged the stones around the new formation. "If Eagle Rock falls, the western line will be blind for a day. The second position gains us two more."

Korgan pushed the stone atop Eagle Rock with one thick finger. Temujin's reputation served him. The same reputation determined how far the Khan was willing to send him.

"You will command the column."

"Yes, my Khan."

"Fifty men. Not one more." Korgan leaned forward. The old scar deepened his empty socket in the torchlight. "If you fail, you are all I lose. If you succeed, the victory remains mine."

Temujin bowed his head. "The victory belongs to the Khan."

Korgan placed a white feather on Eagle Rock. "Kaya commands the Windlisteners there."

Orkhon's hand stopped at the edge of the map. Batu leaned closer.

"Börü's milk-sister," Batu said. "Taking her won't blind the Sungur. It will drive them mad."

"A maddened enemy makes mistakes," Korgan said.

Temujin turned the feather. On the steppe, Kaya's name belonged to more than a scout. Stories said she emptied villages before raids, exchanged wounded Azgut prisoners without allowing them to be tortured, and used her eagles to carry three days of news in one. Killing her would sever one joint in the network. Taking her alive could draw the entire net toward him.

"Are the towers the target, or Kaya?" he asked.

Korgan's single eye shone. "Burn the towers. Bring me the woman. If you cannot do both, decide which will serve your Khan better."

It was not a measure of success but a trap. If Kaya died, the Sungur would unite for vengeance. If she escaped, Temujin would be judged inept. If she arrived as a prisoner, Korgan would use her to put pressure on Börü. Every outcome could serve the Khan.

Temujin left the feather on the map. "Understood."

As he left the tent, he ordered Sube to prepare food and rope separately for five teams. "No fire arrows. Wet felt, spare bowstrings, and two carrying litters."

Sube hesitated at the last item. "For our wounded?"

"We don't know who will be wounded."

\* \* \*

When the meeting ended, Yeva was waiting outside. The small bones around her neck knocked together in the wind, and her white eyes held none of the firelight.

Temujin stopped. "Earth-Mother."

Yeva opened her palm. Four pieces of fire-blackened bone, each the length of a thumb, lay within it.

"I burned it three times," she said. "Each time, it split in four directions."

Temujin examined the pieces. "What does it mean?"

"I don't know."

He rarely heard that answer from Yeva.

"You saw the bison," the woman said.

"I did."

"They fled north."

"There may be a predator ahead of them that we don't know."

"A herd fleeing a predator runs away from it. They ran north." Yeva placed one of the bones in Temujin's palm. Its fracture divided into four branches. "During this Harvest, don't search for danger beneath one banner. The earth isn't speaking from one direction."

"Did you see a Sungur plan?"

"Bones know nothing of plans."

"Then what do you want me to do?"

Yeva turned her face toward him. "For once, don't ignore what you cannot calculate."

She walked away and vanished into the dark.

Temujin took the piece of bone to his tent. He placed it on the map beside the stone that marked Eagle Rock. He divided fifty men into five teams and drew a separate return route for each. Then, along the northern line, he made an empty mark that corresponded to no order.

Sube looked at the map when he entered. "What is that?"

"What we don't know."

"How many men do we assign to it?"

Temujin turned Yeva's cracked bone. "For now, only our attention."

## Chapter 11 — Counsel of the Broken Shield

*(KARIA)*

Sir Kaelan's house stood closer to the docks than to the noble quarters. No family crest hung on its wall, and the wooden awning above the door had collapsed on one side.

The door opened before Karia could knock a third time.

"Karia." Kaelan set aside the poker in his hand. His right shoulder had sunk lower with age. "The tea is brewed. It seems I can still sense your arrival."

"Me, or the problem?"

"You come with the problem."

They went inside. The house smelled of burning wood, dried herbs, and old leather. Every object in the palace had been chosen to impress someone. Kaelan's belongings were there because they were used. When Karia sat beside the fire, she felt the weight of her armor for the first time that day.

Kaelan poured herbal tea into two cups and sat opposite her without asking a question.

Karia took the first sip. "The king asked about the Tide-Heir."

Kaelan set his cup on the table. "Did he ask about you, or the clause?"

"He didn't say my name."

"Then he asked about you."

A log split in the fire. Karia closed both hands around her cup.

"I didn't say yes. I didn't say no."

"Theodoric will count that as yes."

"I know."

Kaelan leaned back in his chair. Firelight deepened the old cut along the left side of his face.

"I held Valerius Pass with thirty men," he said. "By morning, I was the only one who walked out. Afterward, I searched for them in every training yard."

"What did you choose?"

"To put new men in their places." Kaelan wiped the rim of his cup with one thumb. "That's why I trained both you and Valerius."

Karia raised her head. "Him too."

"Yes." Kaelan did not evade the words. "I saw that you were both gifted. In you, someone who knew what losing looked like. In him, someone who wanted only to win."

"You could have made that distinction sooner."

When Karia was seventeen, Kaelan had put them in the same training yard. Valerius attacked in every duel; Karia withdrew until she found his opening. One day, Valerius had left the tip of his practice spear uncovered by leather. Karia saw it and said nothing. She wanted everyone to see that he was trying to win by cheating.

At the end of the duel, the spear pierced a young groom's shoulder. Valerius was punished for three days, and the groom never again lifted his arm above his head. For years, Karia had carried it as her rival's fault. Now she knew silence was a choice as well.

"I saw it too," she said. "I didn't warn you."

Kaelan turned his head. "The spear."

"You remember."

"That groom now runs the northern stables."

Karia realized she did not know his name.

"You wanted to prove what Valerius was," Kaelan said. "You let Bren pay the price. If you sit on the throne, you'll commit greater versions of the same sin. The difference is that this time you'll have to learn the names."

"I failed." The old knight did not look away from the fire. "Valerius no longer listens to me."

"What happens if he takes the throne?"

"He starts a war. He may win the first. Victory convinces him he has the right to a second. In the end, he feeds the Hegemony to his own legend."

Karia set down her tea. "And if I take it?"

Kaelan did not answer for a time. "You'll be afraid. Then I don't know who you'll make pay for your fear."

"Are you certain this is advice?"

"Don't forget how many homes will receive news of death because of a single order. Then, if the order is still necessary, give it." Kaelan leaned forward. "Valerius won't count those homes. You will. I don't know where that will take you."

Karia thought of her answer before the king. First, the Hegemony had to endure. Easy to say; every decision that kept it standing would cut into someone else's share.

"I don't want the crown," she said.

"Not wanting it doesn't mean you cannot carry it."

"Being able to carry it doesn't mean I must accept it."

Kaelan lifted his cup. "Tell the king that."

\* \* \*

The third bell was sounding when Karia left the house. Dockworkers lowered the last loads into the warehouses, and gulls cried after the fishing boats.

A rider in a guard's uniform turned into the narrow street and stopped before her. The horse's mouth was foaming; mud covered the rider's cloak.

"Admiral." As the man dismounted, he drew out a sealed scroll. "Urgent report from the northern frontier."

Karia broke the seal in the street.

Four wagons had been found in the foothills of the White Rampart. Severin's mark remained on their axles and cargo cloths. The wagons were empty. Hoofprints around them led east, into Azgut territory.

"How far did the patrol follow the tracks?"

"Two leagues. They turned back rather than cross the border."

"Any remains of weapons?"

"One chest was broken. They found Hegemony-made arrowheads inside."

This was no longer a rumor Faelan had bought. Severin's seal, Hegemony steel, and tracks leading east now occupied the same page.

"Who else has seen this report?"

"The patrol commander, me, and the clerk at the northern fort."

The rider lowered his gaze as he listed the names. Karia understood that he had not given her all the news.

"There's something else."

"A farmer was found beside the wagons. Alive. The patrol took him to the fort."

"Why isn't he in the report?"

"He can't speak. His tongue was cut out."

The paper rustled in Karia's hand. Severin was not only moving weapons. He was silencing anyone who saw the road.

"Send a healer and two independent clerks. If he cannot write, let him tell it with stones and cord. Severin's soldiers are not to see his statement."

The guard hesitated. "Shouldn't we inform the Council?"

Karia folded the scroll. If she accused Severin at once, the Council would split before the Harvest. If she waited, she did not know how many more chests would reach the Azgut.

"Not yet. First I learn who the buyer is."

## Section 4 — Four Thresholds

### Chapter 12 — Rust Tide

(ZALEENA)

Three days after the Council, Sorin came running aboard the *Sea Ghost*.

Zaleena was reviewing the logs on the stern deck. Sorin took the steps two at a time, revealing the price of his news before he opened his mouth.

"A family is missing from the northern cove," he said. "Four people. Their boat was smashed on the shore."

"Storm?"

"There was no wind that night. They found blood, but it doesn't look human."

Zaleena closed the log. "Choose six people. Have them bring long spears."

\* \* \*

They reached the northern cove before noon. Three huts, a narrow pier, and two fishing boats lay overturned along the shore. The doors of the occupied homes were closed. No smoke rose from the chimneys.

Zaleena did not run the small boat onto the beach. She stepped out in knee-deep water and walked the remaining distance. If they needed to retreat, she did not want the hull trapped in the sand.

Crescent-shaped hollows marked the side of the shattered fishing boat. The wood had not broken; it had been crushed layer by layer. The imprint of a jaw.

Sorin pointed to a dried stain, almost black. "That's what they called blood."

Zaleena scraped off a small piece with the tip of her knife. The substance stretched like tar before snapping. Beneath the salt, its scent held the sharpness of old iron.

"It was wounded," she said.

"The family may have fought back."

"Then at least one of them left here alive."

They searched the sand for tracks. Human footprints tangled near the pier, then ended abruptly. Broader prints ran from the waterline to the huts: four claws, a heavy body, and a tail that did not drag in the sand.

Sorin crouched and pointed to two separate trails. "Not one."

Zaleena counted. "At least four."

A sound like metal striking stone came from the sea.

The crew turned their spears. Zaleena raised a hand and signaled them to remain in place.

Fifty paces from shore, a dark back broke the water. When the creature raised its head, armored plates opened over one another from its neck to its jaw. Its mouth was wider than a fjordmaw's. Two small eyes turned directly toward the people on the shore.

A moment later, it sank.

"To the boat," Zaleena said. "Walk. Don't run."

The crew withdrew without breaking formation. Zaleena remained at the rear. When they reached the shallows, the first shadow appeared to their left. A second passed between the boat and open water.

They're pinning us against the shore, she thought.

As a young deckhand at the rear turned the bow, his foot landed on a wet rope. A loop caught his ankle. The next wave pulled the boat, tightening the rope and dragging him beneath the hull.

Sorin reached for his knife.

"Don't cut it," Zaleena said. "That's the sail line."

She slipped her own knife between the rope and the deckhand's boot. She cut through the leather without touching his foot. When the young man surfaced, he swallowed salt as he fought for breath.

"Two of you, put him in the middle. Keep the oar count."

One of the creatures struck the hull. The boat heeled, taking on water to their knees. Zaleena saw the empty boot remain tied to the line. The dark shape turned beneath the water and followed it.

"They track us by movement, not heat," she said.



Sorin pulled off the deckhand's other boot. He put a stone inside, tied it to a second line, and threw it away from the boat. Two shadows turned toward the splash.

Zaleena gave him a brief look. "If that works, you owe him a new pair of boots."

"If it doesn't, no one will ask about the debt."

"Don't get in yet. Turn the bow toward open water first."

Six people turned the boat. When one shadow approached, Zaleena drove her spear into the water. The point struck a hard plate and glanced aside. The creature beat the water with its tail. A black line appeared amid the spray.

"Now get in!"

The oars entered the water together. The boat came free of the sand on the first pull. The creatures followed, but did not close the distance as the water deepened. They seemed less interested in pursuing their prey than in learning where it went.

Zaleena did not turn her back until they reached the *Sea Ghost*. She checked the number of shadows between oar strokes. All four remained at the mouth of the cove.

\* \* \*

As soon as she reached the deck, she had the black residue sealed in a glass vial.

Sorin joined her while drying his hands. "This is what the Delta was asking about."

"Yes."

"Do we send them word?"

"They knew something before they asked. Now it's their turn to tell us what."

Zaleena opened the coastal map on the chart table. She marked the northern cove in charcoal, then added the two places where fishermen had reported rust-colored tracks. The three marks formed an arc approaching Patchwork Harbor.

"I'll send word to Roric as well," she said.

Sorin looked surprised. "He'll think you're trying to stop his campaign."

"He'll think that because I am."

"What if he ignores the warning?"

"At least the captains will hear it." Zaleena set down the charcoal. "I don't want Roric to sink his ships for Methesis. If I have to fight him, I want him alive."

Sorin looked at the marks on the map. "What do we call them?"

The fishermen's words had passed beyond rumor. Zaleena held the vial of black blood to the light.

"The Rust Tide."

She gave the helmsman a course for Patchwork Harbor. As she sent Sorin away, she added a second order.

"Stop at Finn's. I want the new boat able to turn in shallow water. The sooner he finishes, the more fishermen come back from the shore."

## Chapter 13 — Beyond the Border

*(TOGAN)*

Seren's salve closed the wound in three days. By the fourth morning, Togan could bend his leg and bear his own weight, though he still limped.

Seren changed the bandage one last time before he left. "If the fever starts, come back."

"I can't."

"Then try not to die. Sometimes a healer's advice is that simple."

She put the jar of salve in Togan's bag. Gareth waited at the door. With the village chimes behind them, the two men turned northwest onto narrow paths the Hegemony patrols did not use.

The forest's crowded trunks gave way to wet meadows. They passed stone-walled villages at a distance. Gareth stopped before every hill to listen to the birds and examine the tracks on the road. At one point they waited half a day in the brush, not moving until a patrol in blue cloaks had passed along the main road and disappeared.

On the third day, they climbed a low ridge. Two roads divided before them. The broad one descended west toward Metheris; the narrow one, lined with stone markers, ran north.

Gareth planted his walking staff in the earth. "The Northern Campaign Road. From here on, you'll see more monuments than soldiers."

"You're not coming?"

"I walked this road once in uniform. I don't want to return the second time in chains."

Togan nodded. He knew which direction to take. He did not know how to say farewell.

Gareth was silent for a time as well. "I learned something wrong about hope in the army," he said. "I thought it kept a man on his feet. Sometimes it only shows him how far he can crawl."

"Were you better without it?"

Gareth considered. "No. Just ask yourself now and then what you're following. If the answer has changed, notice."

Togan spoke Melira's name inside his mind. The answer had not changed. Perhaps he was afraid that it would.

"I owe you," he said.

"Not a debt." Gareth offered his right hand. Togan gripped his wrist as Hegemony soldiers did. "We survived the same night. The account closed there."

"What if we meet again?"

"Then we open a new one."

Gareth turned onto the path descending west. Within minutes, the fog swallowed first his body, then the sound of his steps.

Burkut ruffled his feathers on Togan's shoulder.

"The two of us again," Togan said.

The eagle tapped its beak against his shoulder guard.

\* \* \*

That afternoon, he smelled burning.

He loosened his sword and left the main road. The smell came from a small frontier town to the east. Half the stone walls still stood; the wooden

roofs had collapsed, and ash filled the well in the square. The fire was no more than a week old. Thin smoke still moved inside some of the beams.

Togan passed slowly among the houses. There were no bodies. He could not tell whether the dead had been buried or taken away. If the Ember-Fires had remained here as Seren said, they had already carried their trail somewhere else.

He found wheel tracks behind the well. Rain had softened their edges, but two wagons had clearly left the town heading east. Bare feet and heavy boots mingled beside the ruts. One of the bare prints was small. A dark spot of blood marked every place where its heel had landed.

Togan followed the tracks for half a league. The road divided before a thicket gray with ash. The wagons continued east, while three pairs of boots turned north. The small footprints had not left the wagons.

Burkut descended over the trail turning north. Togan raised an arm and called him back. If he caught the three Ember-Fires, he might learn where the townspeople had been taken. He was wounded and alone. The trail was at least five days old, and the captives were already far away. Following them would mean abandoning the road to the Wall of Light.

Even the right choice was not clean.

He cut a short strip of leather from his belt and tied it to a branch at the fork. He memorized the arrangement of stones so he could find it on his return. Then he walked back to the town.

He found a mark on a wall overlooking the square: a cracked hand rising through flames. It had been carved into the wood with a knife, then blackened with charcoal.

He fixed the mark in his memory.

A small cradle lay overturned beside the well. One side had burned; a scrap of blue cloth remained on the other. Togan lifted the cradle and set it against the wall. Soot blackened his fingers.

The air had smelled this way on the night Melira died. For a year, he had carried that fire as though it contained only one death. He did not know the names of these houses or the faces of those who had lived in them. Still, the ash lodged in his throat in the same way.

He pressed his palm over the cracked hand on the wall. The mark was larger than his fingers.

"I will find you," he said.

He filled a small pouch with ash from the foot of the wall. If someone denied this mark one day, he wanted more than memory in his hands. He tied the pouch with a thin thread torn from the blue cloth and left the rest of the cradle untouched.

When he left the town, he returned to the Northern Campaign Road. Ash followed on his boots until he passed the first stone marker.

## Chapter 14 — Four Thresholds

*(CLOSING: TOGAN / TEMUJIN / KARIA / ZALEENA)*

**On the Northern Campaign Road**, Togan entered a shallow cave near the stone markers. He did not light a fire. He arranged dry branches across the entrance.

He removed Seren's bandage. The redness had not spread. After applying the salve and tying on clean cloth, he divided the last thick piece of dried meat in two and left the larger share for Burkut.

He took the bone clasp from his belt and held it in his palm. He could not warm the cold piece Melira had left behind, only keep it between his fingers.

A branch broke at the entrance. Togan drew his sword halfway and stepped outside. A gaunt fox fled when it saw him among the stones. His hand was still trembling as he sheathed the blade. He had left the forest, but the forest had not left his body.

He wrapped himself in his fur and watched the Crimson Host from the mouth of the cave. When he slept, he dreamed not of fire, but of a cold light burning in the north, too far away for him to touch.

\* \* \*

**At the Great Camp**, Temujin pulled the final saddle strap tight. Sube counted the provision bags and tied two folded litters to the horse at the rear.

Of the fifty men riding west at dawn, seven had fought the Sungur and two had left brothers in those mountains. Temujin counted every face once more.

Orkhon picked up the cracked bone from the table. "Bones can be wrong."

"So can men. We still take them to war."

"Are you ready?"

"The plan is ready."

"I asked about you."

"We'll learn at dawn."

Sube tightened the last knot on the litter. "Korgan wants the woman alive."

"We won't burn tents. We won't kill anyone who surrenders. If we can take Kaya, we take her alive."

"And if we can't?"

Temujin slipped the cracked bone inside his armor. "The mission continues."

\* \* \*

**In Metheris**, two documents lay on Karia's desk. One concerned Severin's empty wagons. The other concerned the palace servant moving between Vorlag and Valerius.

Karia did not put them in the same file. She locked the Severin report in an iron chest and wrote the servant's name inside the back cover of the ship's log. If one was found, the other would remain silent.

Crimson Dust from the warehouse weighing lay on a cloth at the edge of the desk. Three of the eleven missing barrels had passed through Severin's stores. It was not an answer, only a second road leading to the same hand.

Three questions stood on a separate sheet: *Where is the missing Dust? Who loaded the wagons? What did the farmer with the severed tongue see?*

She summoned the guard at the door. "A second message for Faelan. Watch Severin, but don't touch him."

"Tonight, Admiral?"

The red glow in the window mingled with the yellow of the North Beacon. Karia closed the curtain.

"Tonight especially."

\* \* \*

**In Patchwork Harbor**, Roric's reply was three lines:

*There have always been monsters. Metheris won't wait. If you're afraid, stay in the harbor.*

Zaleena held the paper to the lamp and emptied the ashes beside the locked box on the chart table. Five crewmen had left shares in the shore fund that day. No family trusted the box yet; five people had been willing to try.

Sorin dropped a sixth iron token through the slot. "Will he stop the campaign?"

"No."

"What do we do?"

Zaleena marked the three coves where the Rust Tide had been seen. "If Roric takes the ships, we'll defend the harbor with whoever remains."

Two coves would have night watches, and no fisherman would sail alone. A cauldron of pitch would stand ready at the outer quay. For the first time, Sorin did not interrupt while Zaleena gave the orders.

She wrote the watch hours along the edge of the map, then took the paper and headed for the door.

Sorin lowered his head. "He'll call you a coward."

"If the name brings a few families back to shore, I'll carry that too."

At midnight, the Dark Month ended and the Year of Waiting began. As the flagless mast of Patchwork Harbor creaked in the wind, six iron tokens struck one another inside the box.

## 2. Part — The Fall of Wings

\* \* \*



## Section 5 — Fallen Wings

### Chapter 1 — Eagle Hunt

*(TEMUJIN)*

They had been advancing for five nights and hiding in dry streambeds by day. The fifty horses traveled in a single file to avoid leaving a broad trail.

At the end of each night, Temujin had the hoof wraps counted under his own eye. Three had torn on the first day. On the second, a wrap came loose from one horse and left half a print on a stone. Sube said only the eagles could see a mark that small.

"If an eagle sees it, the person above it will start looking," Temujin said.

They had brought provisions for six days. On the seventh, only salt and two sacks of barley would remain. If they could not open the corridor by then, they would have to turn back. Korgan had given him fifty horses. He had not given him an extra day.

Temujin pressed the hide map against his knee. The Windlisteners were not commanded from one center. Each observation post held one or two people, an eagle, and provisions for several days. Fifty men could not break the entire network. They could open a blind corridor in the west for Korgan's army, lasting two days.

Sube pointed to the first height on the map. "Eagle Rock. One master, one apprentice. Their birds fly at dawn and in the late afternoon."

"Change of watch?"

"Every seven days. The last change was four days ago."

Temujin completed the calculation. "We climb after midnight. We take the observers before the eagles wake."

At the end of the fifth night, they reached the foot of the rock. Temujin divided his men into two columns. Sube would hold the rear slope with twenty men while Temujin climbed from the front.

The One Eye had only just begun to grow beyond a crescent. The Crimson Host on the northern horizon was easy to distinguish among the stars.

Temujin raised his hand. The archers drew their bows.

The eagle in front of the stone shelter turned its head.

It had heard something no human could. It spread its wings and screamed.

"Now."

The first arrow struck the senior observer's shoulder. The man did not fall. He put the bone whistle around his neck to his lips and blew one long note. By the time Temujin's men reached him, the alarm had already traveled east.

The apprentice burst from the shelter. Sube's column blocked the escape route, and they seized the boy before he could draw his sword.

The eagle circled above the rock, crying out. Temujin tried to calculate how far the whistle had carried. The wind blew east. The next post was half a day away.

"Did they hear it?" Sube asked.

"We can't assume they didn't." Temujin crouched beside the wounded observer. The arrow had lodged in bone; the man might live. "If we go to the second post, they'll be waiting."

"Are we turning back?"

"We're changing the target."

He had the wounded man moved to the lee side of the rock and left him water, food, and his knife. Killing him served no purpose. If he lived, the Sungur would know the choice Temujin had made.

Sube asked for the arrow to be removed. The Young Wolf healer felt around the wound and shook his head. The head had struck bone; if they removed it here, the bleeding might not stop.

"If we leave him like this, he'll die," Sube said.

"If we pull it out, he'll die here."

Temujin had them find the signal paints inside the shelter. He drew the white line for wounded on the visible face of the rock. If the eastern post answered the alarm, they would find the man. If no one answered, the network was not as tight as they believed. Either result carried information.

They took the apprentice with them.

When they mounted, the boy sat before Sube with his hands bound. He could not hide his fear and turned at every distant cry from the eagle.

Temujin rode alongside him. "What's your name?"

The boy did not answer.

"I won't kill you. But you decide how long your hands remain tied."

The boy tightened his jaw.

"Who heard the whistle?"

"Everyone."

"Everyone isn't an answer."

"The eastern post must have heard. Maybe the southern ones too."

Temujin redrew the route in his mind. If three observation posts had been warned, the corridor he had prepared was closed.

"Who is inspecting the posts this week?"

The boy remained silent. Temujin waited without slowing the horses.

"I can leave you with your wounded master," he said. "Or I can untie your hands, give you a horse and two days of provisions."

"You give your word?"

"If you tell the truth."

The boy bit his lip. "Chief Windlistener Kaya. She comes to the western line tomorrow."

Temujin remembered the name from the reports. Kaya had built the Sungur eagle network and chosen every post herself. Taking its maker instead of cutting the network one joint at a time would change the entire calculation.

"Her route?"

The boy described two narrow valleys and a dry spring.

Temujin turned to Sube. "Leave the second post. We intercept Kaya."

"The boy?"

"Do as we promised."

Sube untied the boy's hands and gave him one of the spare horses. As the apprentice rode away into the dark, Temujin turned the fifty men south.

Once the boy had passed from sight, Sube said, "He can warn his own post while leading us to Kaya."

"He will."

"Then why release him?"

Temujin thought of the two narrow valleys to the south. The first route the apprentice described was fast, the other rockier. Someone afraid of pursuit would take the fast road. A Sungur scout following him would see the same tracks.

"If Kaya changes her line to retrieve the wounded master, she'll come through the first valley. If she comes to question the boy, she'll use the second. If she doesn't come at all, we'll know she places her mission before the men she assigned to it."

"What if the boy lied about the route from the beginning?"

"Then we've lost a horse and two days of provisions. Not our word."

Before sunrise, two outriders returned. They had found old hoofprints in the first valley and an eagle feeding platform opened during the night in the second. Temujin did not pack all fifty men into one gorge. He put thirty on the slopes of the second valley, ten along the retreat, and left the other ten to build a visible camp and light a fire in the first.

Sube listened to the plan. "If Kaya comes with five people, thirty warriors are too many."

"If Kaya heads the network, she doesn't travel alone. Posts we cannot see move with her."

Temujin did not allow Korgan's black bison to be hung in the bait camp. He did not use the Young Wolf mark either. If Kaya learned whom she faced before entering the ambush, her decision would follow her anger rather than their calculation.

The first plan had failed. Temujin recalculated the provisions, the two valleys, and the hours in which the freed apprentice could arrive. A more valuable target had appeared before them. To turn it into an opportunity, he first had to accept that it was a trap.

## **Chapter 2 — Land of Mist**

*(TOGAN)*

The Northern Campaign Road was busier than Togan had expected.

Since dawn, three grain caravans and two columns of soldiers had passed, along with a convoy of porters returning south with empty wagons. The road was narrow, so the wheels entered the same ruts and threw mud as far as the forest's edge. On the steppe, an approaching crowd appeared on the horizon. Here, people emerged suddenly between the trees and vanished into the fog again.

Togan did not descend to the road. He used the paths Gareth had shown him and walked parallel to the caravans. Burkut flew above the treetops, giving a short cry whenever soldiers approached.

Near midday, Togan heard a conversation between two wagons.

"They say the king's stores are empty."

"If they're empty, where are our sacks going?"

"The lords' stores."

A tired laugh followed. "Then the lords can eat kelp during Crimson Week."

The conversation stopped when the guard at the front shouted back at them.

Togan looked at the grain on the wagons. Their wheels cut deeper into the mud than those returning empty.

\* \* \*

The road passed a small town that afternoon. Togan stopped beneath the cover of the trees.

The upper floors of the stone-footed houses were built of wood. Spearmen stood before the granary in the square, while a smith sharpened axes without pause. A herald read the king's mobilization decree. Togan could not make out every word, but "Crimson Week," "northern patrol," and "mandatory share" reached him through the crowd.

No one applauded. When the decree ended, the people returned to the next task before them.

Across the square, children played with wooden swords. Two had tied old sacks over their shoulders as cloaks. The larger group surrounded them.

"The Azgut are coming!" one child shouted.

They knocked the sack-cloaked children to the ground and cheered their victory.

Togan did not enter the town. He could hide the Sungur mark on his armor beneath a cloak. He could not hide Burkut.

As he was about to leave the town behind, an axle broke on a wagon beside the road. Two sacks spilled into the mud. A driver and the young woman beside him tried to gather the grain while the column of soldiers behind them continued without stopping. The lead rider shouted at them for blocking the way.

"If you don't deliver the mandatory share to the outpost by sunset, two more sacks will be added."

The driver pointed to the broken axle. "I can't move it until I find a craftsman."

"Then your debt grows."

The rider went on. Togan waited for the soldiers to disappear into the forest, crossed his cloak over the front of his armor, and approached the wagon. At the sight of him, the woman gripped the grain shovel in both hands.

"I don't want money," Togan said. "Find a log to lift it."

The driver looked at the edge of the Sungur line visible beneath Togan's cloak. He did not run. They pulled a post from the nearby fence. Togan lifted the rear of the wagon with his shoulder while the older man slid the post beneath the axle. The woman bound the broken piece with linen cord and two iron rings.

"It will reach the outpost," she said. "It won't make the return."

"The wagon will be empty on the return," her father said.

Togan gathered the grain from the mud by hand and put it back into the sack. Stones and wet earth had mixed through it. The woman began to separate them, but a horn sounded in the distance.

"Leave it," the man said. "They'll count that against us at the scales too."

Burkut descended from the tree and landed on the wagon bed. The woman's hands stopped.

"Are you Sungur?"

Togan did not lie. "I'm passing through."

The man looked around. "If the men at the outpost see you, they'll take us all."

"Why me?"

"Didn't you hear the herald? Anyone carrying a steppe mark will be questioned."

After Togan set the wagon on the road, he withdrew into the forest. The woman threw a small cloth bag after him. It held a handful of barley and two hard apples.

"For the eagle," she said.

Before Togan could thank her, the wagon passed around the bend. He had seen the Hegemony's greatness in its walls and number of soldiers. Now he knew how that greatness settled its weight upon a broken axle.

He continued north.

\* \* \*

That evening, he stopped beside a shallow stream far from the road. He ate dried meat without lighting a fire. After Burkut took his share, the eagle climbed onto a low branch to groom his feathers.

Togan poured the barley from the cloth bag into his palm. Burkut did not touch the grains, but tested one of the apples with his beak. Togan washed both in the stream and ate half of one. He saved the rest for morning. He could not stop seeing the grain in the mud.

Togan removed the bandage from his wound. The cut was closing, but its edges had reddened again after the long walk. He applied Seren's salve and tied the cloth.

When darkness fell, the Crimson Host appeared on the northern horizon. It was one of the first nights of the Year of Waiting. Crimson Week lay months ahead. Togan did not know how many days separated him from the Wall of Light.

He had no map. He had the road Gareth had described and Burkut's sense of direction. It was less than he had imagined when leaving Eaglehold.

"We'll leave earlier tomorrow," he said.

He dreamed of Kaya. His milk-sister stood in a narrow place bounded by stone, opening her mouth without producing a sound. A storm turned above her but could not descend to the ground.

Togan woke with his hand on the hilt of his sword.

The stream flowed with the same sound, and Burkut remained on his branch. The unease left by the dream did not pass. Togan gathered his belongings and returned to the road before sunrise.

## Chapter 3 — Keeper of the North Gate

*(KARIA)*

Lord Aldous Severin's manor held more relics of loss than family portraits. A broken Harvest hook was displayed in the entry hall, salt-eaten helmets hung on the walls, and a half-burned standard stood at the foot of the stairs leading to the upper floor. Two maps divided the great wall of the receiving room. One marked the northern campaigns; the other, the units lost during past Harvests.

Karia recognized the lone silver pin on the second map. Severin's unnamed son had failed to return to his post on the fourth night of the Harvest. Folk tales had arisen that confused him with Prince Aldric, and the palace had been forced to correct the rumors several times. Aldric had vanished in the north twelve years ago. Severin's son had disappeared in another year, on another assignment, leaving another father to mourn.

Karia's unannounced arrival had caught Severin in his dressing gown. Even so, the lord dismissed the servants and shut the door himself.

"An unexpected visit, Admiral."

"It had to be."

Karia did not sit. First she placed the White Rampart report on the table, then the arrowhead taken from the broken chest. Last, she unfolded the charcoal rubbing of Severin's mark from the axle.

"Three weeks ago, four of your wagons left the Northern Campaign Road. They were found empty in the White Rampart foothills. Hegemony-made arrowheads were carried east. The hoofprints lead into Azgut territory."



Severin did not pick up the arrowhead. His gaze shifted once to the silver pin.

"Are you going to deny it?" Karia asked.

"No."

An answer that came so quickly was more suspicious than a rehearsed lie.

"Who did you give the weapons to?"

"Brokers don't use names."

"Who hired them?"

"My caravan clerk."

"Who provided the money?"

This time Severin looked at Karia. "I did."

Karia saw the bellpull at the edge of the table. The manor guards were two doors away. If Severin tried to flee, only two marines stood between him and freedom. But the lord did not pull the cord.

"Why?"

Severin walked to the Harvest map. Eleven black marks lay beneath the silver pin.

"My son's unit broke here. Nine bodies were found. Two men were not. The Council searched for three weeks, then judged the loss on the coast acceptable."

"You did not."

"Every year I sent out two privately funded parties. The last came back empty. I had no money left to send another."

Karia calculated the arrowheads' value. Four wagons of weapons were worth more than an ordinary house earned in a year.

"The steel you sold to the Azguts paid for your search parties."

"Some of it."

"And the rest?"

Severin walked to the window before answering. Two freight wagons were being unloaded in the courtyard below. "If the steppes consume themselves, the troops we keep on the eastern border will be free. When the Harvest begins, we can search the coastal roads and the old lines of loss again."

"What if your first assumption is wrong?"

"Which one?"

"That the weapons you sold will be pointed only at warriors."

Severin's jaw tightened. "There are no clean targets in war."

"That doesn't make starting one a lesser crime."

Karia pushed the arrowhead toward him. "The hand holding this won't ask which clan the child across from it belongs to. Losing your son doesn't make that child nameless."

Severin watched the silver pin for a time. "I thought about it every night."

"And still you sent the wagons."

"Yes."

The confession did not make the evidence easier to use. If Karia took the file to the Council that day, Severin would be arrested, his house would close the northern gates, and Vorlag would present the investigation as Karia usurping authority. With preparations for the Harvest under way, three granaries and two coastal units might be left without a lord. If she hid the file, Severin might dispatch another shipment.

"Send for your caravan clerk," she said.

Severin pulled the bell cord. When the clerk arrived, Karia put him face-to-face with Faelan, who had been waiting in the room. Faelan had entered the manor through the servants' door and spent the past half hour locating the trade ledgers. The clerk's hands began to tremble when he saw the two men in the same room.

"Who wrote the release order for the four wagons?" Faelan asked.

"I did, sir."

"Who sealed the cargo?"

The clerk looked at Severin. The lord offered no help.

"I did."

"The broker's name?"

"He didn't use one. Two fingers were missing from his left hand. He paid with Delta credit."

Faelan entered this last piece of information into the record. Karia ordered the clerk to repeat the same statement before a palace scribe and a harbor judge. The man would be relieved of his duties that night, but held in a guest room from which he could not disappear.

"Will you turn me over to the Council?" Severin asked.

"I won't put your file before the seven lords today. That doesn't mean you're free."

Karia opened Severin's trade ledgers to independent audit. If one more chest left the northern storehouses, the file would go to the Council that same day.

Severin's shoulders sagged. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me. The reason you aren't being arrested today isn't your innocence. It's that the people who depend on your gates must not starve during the coming Harvest. If you mistake this time for forgiveness, I will be the first witness against you."

At the door, Severin called after her.

"What would you have done?"

Karia stopped. She did not try to decide whether the question was honest or a trap seeking shared guilt.

"I would have looked for my son," she said. "Without pointing a weapon at someone else's."

\* \* \*

On her way down from the manor to the harbor, she found a crowd at the quay entrance. Sailors from a merchant ship out of the east were telling how armored creatures had attacked fishing boats along the Orphan Shores.

"In packs," one of the sailors said. "They say they're coming ashore too."

Karia asked the ship's name, its route, and the port where the report had been heard. Then she asked the man to describe the creature. Its forelegs curved like hooks, crimson weed collected between the plates of its shell, and the creatures struck the bottoms of boats one after another.

She turned to the officer beside her. "Enter it in the North Beacon records. No coastal ban until we have a second account. Send an illustrated warning to the fishing crews. Tell them not to approach if they see one."

Faelan caught up with her on the slope from the manor. He slipped the small notebook in his hand inside his coat.

"The clerk said Delta credit," he reminded her.

"He said it. He didn't prove it."

"We could have taken Severin today."

"We could. And then Vorlag would give his granaries to his own men."

"They'll say you're protecting him," Faelan said.

"Let them."

The sound of hammers rose from the shipyard. Karia walked toward the harbor.

## Chapter 4 — Fractured Loyalties

(ZALEENA)

Kessel's ship was missing from the morning count.

The quay clerk said no departure had been recorded during the night. The two members of Kessel's crew who remained ashore did not know where their captain had gone either. It was not forbidden for a captain to leave Patchwork Harbor in silence. Leaving this much talk behind was noteworthy.

Sorin brought the news to the deck of the *Sea Ghost*. "He said in the tavern that Roric was preparing for his own funeral."

"Kessel did?"

"One of his crew."

"Was he drunk?"

"Quite."

Zaleena closed the chest of arms. "Drink sometimes makes a man tell what he hid while sober as if it were someone else's words."

Kessel's departure cost them one vote. More importantly, it showed the other captains that withdrawing was possible.

Zaleena stepped down onto the empty berth. Kessel's ropes had been neatly coiled, and the water barrels left onshore were sealed. A captain fleeing in haste did not leave like this. A small account slip tucked into the mooring post showed that three days' wages had been paid to those of the crew who stayed behind.

"Three days," Sorin said.

"What?"

"He left three days' pay for the men ashore. Either he'll be back by then, or he'll make his decision by then."

Zaleena folded the slip. Kessel had not abandoned the harbor out of fear of Roric. By withdrawing his ship, he had drawn a line. It was not a mutiny. It was a costly objection, proof that Roric's orders no longer carried themselves out.

"Don't list him as a deserter," Zaleena said. "Record that he withdrew from Council service. If he returns, he can explain why himself."

A shout rose from the outer end of the quay.

A small fishing boat was entering the harbor under a single oar. Its starboard side was shattered and its sail wrapped around the mast. Of the three men on deck, one clutched his arm beneath a bloody cloth while another shouted for those ashore to throw them a line.

Zaleena went down to the pier.

"Where?" she asked the boat's captain.

"Beyond the Razor Reefs. There were four of them. Maybe more." The man's lips were purple with cold. "They struck the bottom of the boat and knocked us into the water. We couldn't get two men back."

"Armored?"

The man nodded. "Like rusted stone."

The crowd parted. Roric came down the pier with heavy steps, three armed men behind him.

Zaleena turned to him. "How many boats will it take now?"

Roric looked at the wounded fisherman, then at the faces around him. "There are monsters in the sea."

"These are coming ashore and hunting in packs."

"I won't give up on Metheris because we lost one boat."

"You lost two men."

Roric's hook struck his belt. He raised his voice enough for the crowd to hear. "The expedition goes ahead. Anyone afraid can leave now. His share will go to those with the courage to stay."

Several crewmen shouted their support. Most were silent. Zaleena saw where each man looked: three captains were watching the damaged boat, not Roric.

"The dead don't spend shares," Zaleena said. "That should make your accounts easier."

Roric's face reddened. "I was running this harbor before you were born."

"Then you should have been the first to notice when it changed."

Roric did not answer. He ordered the wounded carried away and turned his back. He had not stopped the expedition, but as he left, the crowd no longer made way for him as it once had.

Zaleena climbed aboard the fishing boat. The broken side did not bear one great impact, but four separate depressions at intervals. The creatures had not bitten the boat at random. They had struck the same line in sequence. A thin rust-colored scale had lodged in one of the bottom planks. She pried it free with the point of her knife and wrapped it in oiled cloth.

Before he was taken to the infirmary, the wounded captain caught her arm. "I left two men in the water."

"Their names?"

"Eren and Pol. They were brothers."

"Is their family here?"

"Their mother mends nets. On the eastern quay."

Zaleena told Sorin to open two missing-person shares. Under Roric's old rule, no death share was paid until a body was found. If she enforced it on the same morning Kessel disappeared, both families would have to wait for weeks.

"The Council will object," Sorin said.

"Call it a missing-person share. Not a death share. Half now, half when their fate is certain."

"That's a new rule too."

"Then we'll put it to a vote tonight. Their mother shouldn't go hungry until morning."

At the evening meeting, Roric did not oppose the missing shares. Instead, he demanded that the money come from the coastal-defense fund rather than the expedition chest. Three captains objected; they considered losses caused by the creatures a defense expense. Zaleena asked for both accounts to be brought before them.

The expedition chest held enough to provision eight ships for a month. The coastal-defense fund was nearly empty after the purchase of two new pitch cauldrons.

"Which purse pays the money shows what you've chosen to protect," Zaleena said.

Roric agreed to pay the missing shares from the expedition fund. In return, he entered into the record that the departure date would not change. The vote passed nine to four. The four dissenting votes were not against the expedition, but against setting money aside for the two men. Zaleena had that detail recorded as well.

\* \* \*

Sorin walked beside Zaleena as she returned to her ship.

"Will others follow Kessel?"

"Three captains will count their crews again tonight."

"You want the fleet to shrink."

"If fewer ships leave, fewer ships sink."

"If Roric grows weaker, you grow stronger."

Zaleena stopped. Sorin did not take back the criticism.

"Yes," she said. "Both are true."

"The ease with which you say that frightens me sometimes."

"I'm not at ease." Zaleena pointed to the damaged fishing boat. "I didn't want those two men to die. I don't want Roric to die either. But if I see where his stubbornness is taking us and do nothing, it stops mattering what I wanted."

When she boarded her ship, she opened the coastal chart. She marked the site of the attack and put the date beside it.

"Send a second boat to the northern lookouts," she told Sorin. "From now on, every attack will be recorded with its location, hour, tide, and number of losses. If Roric won't listen, we'll give him more evidence than he can deny."

Sorin placed the rusty scale wrapped in oiled cloth on the table. "Who will know what this is?"

"Finn knows boat timber. The healers can tell us whether it's living tissue. If neither knows, we'll send it to Metherris."

"To Karia?"

"To the North Beacon. Let the records speak first. Queens afterward."

Zaleena wrote Eren's and Pol's names beside the mark on the map. That way it would not remain merely the site of an attack. When Roric's eight ships sailed, the record would also show the two men whose unpaid debt carried them out.



## Section 6 — The Broken Wind

### Chapter 5 — When the Wind Breaks

*(TEMUJIN)*

The apprentice's route proved true.

At dawn, five riders entered the narrow valley. The woman in front checked the slopes more often than the four Windlisteners around her, and the eagle on her shoulder turned its head with every turn of hers.

The fire at the bait camp was smoking a league to the west. Kaya had not approached it. She had found the wounded senior watcher's mark and abandoned the eagle network's usual route. Her choice of the stony path from the two the apprentice had described told Temujin two things: the boy had not lied, and Kaya had allowed for the possibility that the road was being watched.

From his position on the slope, Sube raised two fingers twice. He had seen no other riders behind them. Temujin kept the withdrawal party in place all the same. Kaya appeared with five people. The eagle network was not limited to the number of people in sight.

Temujin studied the group from behind the rock.

"Kaya," Sube said.

The spies' descriptions had been incomplete. They had described Kaya's broad shoulders and her balance in the saddle. They had not described the way her men changed pace without looking to her. That kind of accord came not from orders, but from long years.

Temujin raised two fingers. The archers would target only the warriors on the flanks. Kaya was to be taken alive.

He lowered his hand.

The first volley came from both sides of the valley. One Windlistener fell from his horse. A second arrow entered another's chest. Kaya slid sideways in the saddle and raised her shield.

The instant Temujin saw the first man fall, he signaled for the archers to lower their bows. The young soldier on the right slope saw the signal too late and loosed a third arrow. It struck Kaya's shield. Taking it for continued fire, Kaya pulled her wounded warrior behind a rock.

"The order was one volley!" Sube shouted.

The young archer froze. Temujin did not look at him. Punishing the mistake now would unravel the line for another moment. He would ask the man's name when they returned.

"Ambush!" Kaya shouted. "Fall back!"

Storm launched from her shoulder. An arrow grazed the eagle's wing as it descended on the first archer's face, scattering feathers in the air. Even so, it wheeled and attacked a second time.

Kaya withdrew between the rocks with her two remaining warriors. At the mouth of the valley they found Sube's party blocking the way.

Temujin brought his men down from the slope. Kaya had nowhere left to run, yet she held her sword in both hands.

"Young Wolf," she said. She had recognized him. "Do Korgan's dogs hunt at night now?"

"We waited for the five of you today."

"You killed two."

"I want to finish without killing the other three."

Kaya looked at her wounded men. One held his arm; the other could not put weight on the leg pierced by an arrow. Storm flew an unsteady circle above the valley.

"Did you leave the white line on the rock?" Kaya asked.

"Yes."

"Is my master alive?"

"He was when we left. The arrow hadn't been removed. If anyone reached the eastern post, they found him."

Kaya's sword lowered by the width of a finger. It was not surrender. Temujin saw that the water he had left with a wounded man was buying him time in the valley now.

"Why do you want us alive?"

"To learn the eagle network."

"We won't tell you."

"Then you become less valuable as prisoners. Not less entitled to live."

Kaya's mouth twisted with contempt. "Is that what you told Toygun?"

Temujin noted how quickly the name had reached her. "Toygun made a different choice."

"The dead always make different choices."

Temujin did not draw his sword. The men descending into the valley were enough. "Lay down your weapon and your wounded will be treated. Storm won't be harmed either."

At the sound of its name, the eagle cried again.

"Will your word survive as far as Korgan's tent?" Kaya asked.

"It will survive among my men. I'm taking you to my own camp first."

Kaya counted the archers on both slopes, the sealed exit, and the warriors lying on the ground. If she died, the intelligence network would be left leaderless, and the two people beside her would die with her.

"We take the dead too," Kaya said.

"Carrying bodies will slow us down," Sube replied.

"Leave them here and I won't drop the sword."

Temujin calculated the rising sun and the distance to camp. The two bodies would require a packhorse and cost them half an hour. Disarming Kaya by force might cost more men and more blood.

"We'll take them," he said. "Drop your weapon."

She let the sword fall.

"Bind their wounds first."

Temujin signaled Sube. The Young Wolves approached the two wounded men. Kaya put her hands behind her back of her own accord.

"Tie it tightly," she told the soldier binding her. "If I escape, he'll kill you."

The soldier looked at Temujin. Temujin nodded.

\* \* \*

As they left the valley, they lashed one body to either side of a packhorse. The wounded Sungurs were put on spare mounts. Kaya rode her own horse with her hands bound in front of her. Storm's wing had stopped bleeding. The

eagle sometimes perched behind the saddle, sometimes followed the herd at a low glide.

They left the name tokens on each dead man's belt. As Temujin's scribe marked the site of the clash on the map, Kaya gave him the two names herself: Sarban and Ilte. When the scribe misspelled the first, she made him correct it.

"You don't trust the enemy's records," Temujin said.

"I say it so his death remains in my tongue. It does no harm for it to stand correctly on your paper too."

"Where are we going?" Kaya asked.

"The temporary camp to the west."

"And then to Korgan."

"Korgan thinks that is his decision to make."

Kaya looked closely at him for the first time. Temujin did not explain any more of what he had said.

At the midday halt, the wounded Sungur's bandage filled with blood. The Young Wolf healer asked two men to help him remove the arrow. They did not untie Kaya's hands, but she told them which herb to make the man chew and where to bind his leg. As he writhed in pain, Kaya rested his head on her knee and counted his breaths.

Temujin watched from a distance. Kaya's value extended beyond the eagle routes. The people beside her followed her rhythm even with her hands bound. If Korgan saw it, he might want to kill her not for information, but to break that bond.

Sube brought his horse alongside Temujin's. "The Khan wasn't expecting a prisoner this important."

"He was expecting a result."

"He may want Kaya dead."

Temujin looked at the prisoner ahead. Kaya was memorizing the stones in the road, the watch rotation, and the men's faces. Even bound, she was gathering information.

"A dead Windlistener produces nothing but vengeance," he said. "A living one produces intelligence, leverage, and time."

"What if Korgan won't accept that?"

"We'll show him the account he will accept."

Temujin sent a messenger to the Great Camp. He did not write that two watch posts had been warned. He wrote that Kaya had been taken alive and the western eagle network had been left without its commander.

After the messenger departed, Sube asked about the missing part. "Do we know the network has been left without a commander?"

"Kaya is here."

"She may have left someone in her place."

"She may have."

Sube read Temujin's message again. "Then you sent the Khan half a truth."

"The Khan asked for a blind corridor fifty men wide. I'm bringing him a more valuable prisoner. If I explain why the first objective wasn't completed when I return, he'll hear only failure. Now he'll hear about the prisoner."

"And then?"

"Then he'll be calm enough to ask about what was left out."

Temujin was not certain of that. He did not change the message.

How a victory was told sometimes outlived how it was won.

## Chapter 6 — Half-Told News

*(TOGAN)*

The fire at the caravan stop shone between the trees.

Togan did not approach the road. He crouched in the brush behind the well and sent Burkut to a darker branch. Six merchants sat around the fire, their mules tethered to stakes nearby. They stretched their wet socks toward the flames and passed the same wineskin from hand to hand.

"The ones from the steppes came through this morning," one of the men said. "Their horses were covered in foam."

"An Azgut raid?"

"Sungurs, they said. Kept shouting in their own tongue. An eagle commander was missing, or captured. I couldn't tell."

Togan's fingers snapped a twig on the bush.

One of the merchants turned toward the sound. Togan did not move. Beyond the fire, a dog rose and sniffed the air twice. Without opening his wings, Burkut stepped from his branch to the next tree. The rustle of leaves drew the dog's attention upward.

"What was the name?" another merchant asked.

"Wind, storm, something like that. Half the steppes are birds and the other half weather anyway."

The men laughed and moved on to the price of grain.

Eagle commander. Wind. Storm.

All three led to Kaya.

Togan wanted to walk into the firelight. He could ask which way the Sungur messengers had gone, how many there were, and whether they had seen blood. He could hide the armor beneath his cloak, but not Burkut. A foreign warrior approaching a caravan with a Sungur eagle could bring word to the nearest outpost before he learned anything himself.

He waited. One by one, the merchants withdrew to sleep. When only the youngest remained by the fire, Togan came out of the brush. He kept his sword beneath his cloak and both hands visible.

The young man sprang to his feet. "We have no money."

"I don't want money. I'm going to ask about the riders who passed this morning."

"The Sungurs?"

"How many?"

The man looked at the empty space above Togan's shoulder. Burkut remained in the dark. "Three. One was wounded. There was blood on his horse."

"His own?"

"I don't know. They didn't stop us. Changed horses at the well and went south."

"What did they say?"

"I didn't understand all of it. One of them spoke the Hegemony tongue. He said they had to reach Metheris and find the Admiral. I heard the name Kaya too."

Togan's throat tightened. "Is she dead?"

"They didn't say. They said Korgan. They said Young Wolf. They might have said prisoner too."

The young man's gaze caught this time on the strip of braided leather beneath Togan's cloak. He had seen the Sungur mark.

"Are you one of them?"

Before Togan could answer, a horse whinnied. On the other side of the fire, someone turned over and coughed.

"You didn't see me," he said.

The young man nodded. "I didn't see you. But I didn't erase the tracks this morning."

Whether the words were help or a threat was unclear. Togan did not test him with another question. Details given in fear changed shape the more they were pressed.

\* \* \*

After the caravan woke, Togan found the tracks south of the well. Three horses had indeed been ridden hard. The right rear shoe of one was broken, and another had an uneven gait. The trail descended toward the road to Metheris.

If he followed, he could close the distance by noon. If the message had come directly from Kaya, there might still be a path back to her. Reaching Eaglehold would take at least seven days; reaching Korgan's army longer still. By then the prisoner might have been moved elsewhere or killed.

North lay in the opposite direction. The road to the Wall of Light extended between monuments passed by fewer caravans every day. It was the only trail he had been able to measure since Melira vanished. If he turned back, he might not have the supplies to reach the Wall again.

Togan crouched beside the imprint of the horseshoe. He remembered the morning he had last seen Kaya. Rain had loosened the tent ropes. His milk-sister had not tried to stop him from leaving. She had only checked the knot on his sword twice.

"Don't let your anger choose your road," she had said.

At the time, Togan had thought she meant Korgan. Now he saw that it applied to his own fear as well.

Burkut landed on his shoulder. The eagle's talons gently tightened against the thick leather.

"Should we turn back?" Togan asked.

The eagle looked not toward the tracks leading south, but toward the northern tree line. Togan did not take the movement for an answer. Burkut chose the wind, not human debts.

He began walking south. After twenty paces, he stopped. The old wound in his leg ached and his breath came quickly. He had not been running.

Trying to reach Kaya did not mean he would save her. Continuing north did not mean he would find Melira. Failure might lie at the end of either road. What he had to choose was which promise he had made first.

He had left the clan to find Melira. Kaya had sent him away knowing that.

Togan turned back and took the northern road. He cut a small Sungur mark into the bark of the birch at the fork. Beneath it he added three lines: three messengers, southbound, bloodied horse. Any Sungur scout who passed would know Togan had received the news.

"Live, sister," he said.

The words did not vanish into the wind. They stayed in Togan's mouth. He carried them not as a wish, but as a new task given to Kaya.

He walked quickly that night. His wounded leg hurt with every step. At sunrise he did not reconsider whether to turn back. He was not certain he had chosen the right road. He knew only that the choice was his.

## Chapter 7 — A Royal Crisis

*(KARIA)*

News of the King's illness came after midnight.

Karia did not put on her armor. As she buttoned her uniform jacket, she asked the servant when the chief physician had been summoned, whether the palace gates had been closed, and which members of the Council were inside.

"Lord Vorlag has been there for half an hour," the woman said. "Sir Valerius just arrived."

That was news as bad as the illness itself.



Vorlag was waiting alone in the corridor outside the King's chamber. The servants kept their distance from him, and the guards fixed their eyes on the door.

"Admiral." Vorlag inclined his head. "Who sent word to you?"

"The King's condition?"

"His heart. The physicians won't speak with certainty." Vorlag folded his hands inside his sleeves. "If he doesn't live until morning, the Council must be ready."

Valerius came around the corner at a run. "How serious is it?"

"The King is alive," Karia said. "That is all you need to know for now."

The door opened. Sweat covered the chief physician's brow when he stepped outside.

"The seizure has passed. His Majesty is sleeping. He won't receive anyone for several days."

"Is his life in danger?" Karia asked.

"He may not survive another seizure."

Vorlag spoke at once. "Then we should convene the Council in the morning."

"With what agenda?"

"Preparations for transition."

Karia turned to him. "You will not place Theodoric's death on the agenda while waiting outside his chamber."

"The Hegemony cannot stop with one man's heart."

"Correct. That is why the current orders remain in force. The throne is not empty."

Valerius spoke for the first time. "If it becomes empty, we'll be unprepared."

"You appear to have made your preparations."

The young knight's face reddened. Vorlag silenced him with a light touch to the arm. That one gesture spoke more clearly than Faelan's reports.

\* \* \*

An hour later, Karia met Lord Drennar and Lady Calder in the small map room. Neither was close to Vorlag; each had a vote, ships, and men of their own.

"He'll call an emergency Council session in the morning," Karia said. "We will prevent any discussion of an heir."

Calder raised an eyebrow. "By what authority?"

"The chief physician's report says the King needs rest, not that he is incapable of deciding. There can be no succession vote before the throne is empty. First we'll reject the agenda."

"And if that isn't enough?" Drennar asked.

"The harbor guard won't enter the palace. The ships won't move either." Karia studied each of their faces in turn. "I'm not staging a coup. I'm preventing Vorlag from turning a seizure into one."

Calder tapped the table once. "I'll vote against the agenda. I make no promise about what comes after."

"That's all I'm asking."

Drennar nodded. "The shipyards will continue under existing orders."

When the meeting ended, Karia returned to the King's chamber. Theodoric was asleep, his chest rising unevenly beneath the thin coverlet. The ring he was forever turning lay on the table beside the bed.

Karia pulled a chair to the door and sat. She would go to the Council in the morning. Until then, none of Vorlag's men would enter the King's chamber alone.

The palace guards kept the first watch in the corridor. On the second, Karia posted two marines across from the door. Vorlag saw them and returned.

"Do you not trust the palace guard?" he asked.

"I'm sharing the watch."

"Bringing naval soldiers to the King's chamber may look like preparation to some."

"It is. For one physician, two guards, and a watch ledger. Anyone who sees more can tell the Council what he saw."

Vorlag did not approach the door. Valerius, however, passed through the corridor twice. The second time, he carried an old order bearing the King's

seal. He said he wanted confirmation of the southern units' deployment. Karia took the document, checked its date, and had it recorded that the order in force would not change until the chief physician allowed the King to wake.

"You don't have the authority to make that decision," Valerius said.

"I'm not changing the order. I'm not allowing you to change it."

Valerius snatched the paper back. He walked away without looking at Vorlag at the end of the corridor. Karia saw how hard he tried not to look.

\* \* \*

Six of the seven chairs in the Council chamber were occupied that morning. The King's place was left empty. Vorlag had set a draft regency before the vacant seat.

"For as long as His Majesty is unable to decide, executive orders must come from a single authority," he said. "I propose a temporary regency of three months."

Calder turned the first page of the draft. "The regent isn't named."

"The Council will elect one."

"The troops are receiving two different orders," Valerius said. "At the border, delay is paid for in lives."

Karia laid the chief physician's report on the table. "The report does not say the King is dead or has lost his reason. It says he needs rest."

"He may not survive the next seizure," Vorlag replied.

"Then we will not divide the crown before the next seizure happens."

Lord Drennar read the powers set out in the regency draft. The regent could move the navy, release treasury payments with a single signature, and fill vacant commands. The three-month term included the opening days of Crimson Week.

"This isn't preparation," Drennar said. "It's a trial version of the throne."

Vorlag's expression did not change. "Your alternative?"

Karia opened her own draft. The current orders would remain in force, and any emergency change would require two responsible officers' signatures. Until the King woke or his death was declared, no one could use the arrangement to decide the succession.

"A government with three heads," Vorlag said.

"A lock with six signatures," Calder said. "It looks less like one man's hand."

Valerius leaned over the edge of the draft. "In a sudden attack, we can't wait for two signatures."

"The current defensive orders aren't waiting," Karia said. "A new campaign opened under the excuse of attack will have to."

Vorlag cited Azgut movement on the northern border. Karia did not reveal the Severin weapons file. She said only that the army would not march on an unconfirmed report. Putting the file on the table might have won her the vote. It would also have broken both the audit period she had given Severin and the chain of evidence for her own advantage.

The vote ended three to three. The King's empty chair cast no vote. Under the charter, a tie created no new authority and the old order remained. Vorlag's regency was deemed rejected. Karia's six-signature lock did not take effect either.

"You did nothing," Valerius said.

Karia looked at the empty chair. "Today we prevented what must not be done."

After the meeting, Calder added a second signature to the treasury payments, while Drennar resent the existing orders to the units. Karia sent word to the harbor that the ships were to remain in place.

When she returned to the King's chamber, Theodoric was still asleep. The chief physician said his pulse was uneven but stronger than the night before.

Karia entered the names of everyone who approached the door, the documents they brought, and the Council votes into the watch ledger. The tip of her pen caught on the paper at Valerius's name. Theodoric coughed inside, and the ink darkened in the same place.

## Chapter 8 — Pride Sets Sail

*(ZALEENA)*

Roric's fleet left with eight ships.

Three days earlier, thirteen had been preparing to sail. When Kessel returned from the outer bay, he anchored beside Roric's flagship without

furling his sails. The two captains spoke from deck to deck, loud enough for the entire quay to hear.

"You ran," Roric said.

"I thought," Kessel said. "You're sailing with eight ships because you can't tell the difference."

Roric did not challenge him to a duel. He knew that doing so in front of Kessel's one eye would cost the fleet another ship. Instead, he announced that Kessel's share of the expedition was forfeit.

Kessel turned to his own crew. "Anyone fail to hear that?"

No one raised a hand.

Three more captains withdrew after him. The last cut his anchor cable and fled at midnight. Six members of that ship's crew had been left ashore; the captain departed without informing their families. Zaleena entered the ship on the deserters' roll and had the stranded crew's wages deducted from the captain's harbor share.

Roric's flagship fired its guns as it passed the harbor mouth. The sound echoed several times among the Razor Reefs.

"And there go the surprises with them," Zaleena said.

Sorin counted the eight ships again. "Is it enough for Metheris?"

"Enough to pillage if the defenses are weak. Perhaps not enough to return."

Roric's ships disappeared into the mist one by one. Zaleena felt no relief. A smaller fleet meant fewer losses. It also meant Roric might take greater risks out of fear of defeat.

Before the eighth ship vanished, a woman began running along the pier. She was trying to hand something to her son on deck. The ship was already under way. The wool cap in her hand fell into the sea.

Zaleena fished the cap from the water with a hook. The woman did not thank her.

"You could have stopped him," she said.

"I voted in the Council. It wasn't enough."

"My son didn't vote."

It was true. The captain had entered his ship in the expedition, and a collective contract bound the crew to him. No clause required the crew's

renewed consent when the objective of a campaign changed. Zaleena gave the wet cap back to the woman.

"If they return, I'll change that rule."

The woman pressed the cap to her chest. "Who will it help if they don't?" Zaleena had no answer. The woman disappeared into the crowd.

Kessel was waiting on the outer quay. The old captain's sails were furled, his guns turned toward shore.

"You stayed, like me," he said.

"I was staying from the beginning."

"That's why it's hard to like you." Kessel watched the last sail recede. "Are you worried for them?"

"Yes."

The speed of the answer surprised Kessel.

"What happens if Roric doesn't return?" he asked.

"First we repair the ships that do. We set aside shares for the families of the dead. We rebuild the coastal defenses."

"Then you'll take his seat."

Zaleena did not look away from Kessel's eye. "If someone must take it, I want it to be someone thinking about the harbor's next day."

"Is that you?"

"I won't debate it before Roric's body arrives."

Kessel nodded. "The right answer."

"The safe answer."

"Sometimes they're the same thing."

Kessel took a folded paper from his pocket. During his three days in the outer bay, he had marked Roric's possible return routes over the sites of the Rust Tide attacks. Two lines crossed north of the Razor Reefs.

"If the creatures stay in the same place, the returning fleet will pass through them," he said.

"Does Roric know?"

"I gave him the map. He tore it up and threw it overboard."

Zaleena took the copy. She decided to send the fastest boat to the northern lookout. Even if Roric ignored the warning, other captains returning with him might see it.

\* \* \*

That afternoon, Zaleena walked the emptied piers. Eight ships had taken hundreds of sailors, twelve guns, and most of the harbor's best sailmakers with them. The Rust Tide attacks kept moving closer to shore.

She assigned Kessel to the northern patrol and two small ships to the southern entrance. She chose three crewmen to test Finn's new boat before it was launched.

Finn was brushing the last coat of resin onto the new boat's keel. He stood when he heard the patrol order.

"This boat has never seen open water."

"It won't enter open water. It will make turning trials at the harbor mouth."

"Three crewmen is too many."

"One will bail if she takes water. One will watch the rudder. One will write down the mistake you made."

Finn dropped the resinous brush into the bucket. "I didn't make a mistake."

"Then the third man can rest."

The boat pulled to starboard in the first trial and trapped an oar during a hard turn in the second. Zaleena did not add it to the patrol. She gave Finn two days.

"Roric took eight ships," Finn said. "Does one missing little boat matter?"

"It matters because he took eight ships."

Sorin took the order list. "Weren't we waiting?"

"We're waiting for Roric. Not the monsters."

Before evening, the pitch cauldrons were set up on the outer quay. Roric's eight sails had vanished from the horizon.

Zaleena added the objection of the woman with the wet cap to the Council agenda: if an expedition's objective changed, the crew had the right to withdraw. The clause would not be put to a vote before Roric returned. A blue wool fiber torn from the woman's cap remained on the tip of the hook.

## Section 7 — Captives and the Empty Throne

### Chapter 9 — The Worth of a Prisoner

*(TEMUJIN)*

Korgan had ordered the message read twice by the time Temujin entered the Great War Tent.

"The chief Windlistener," the Khan said. "Alive."

"Yes, my Khan."

Korgan's satisfaction narrowed when he looked at Temujin. The success was useful. The name of the man who achieved it was troubling.

Batu laughed from the side of the tent. "Will the Young Wolf hold a feast for his prisoner?"

"She'll be killed before the people," Korgan said. "Let the Sungurs see that even their strongest warrior bows."

Temujin waited. Challenging the Khan's decision at once would make it seem that he placed himself above it.

"Her death will be talked of for a day," he said. "Her life can serve us for months."

Korgan turned his one eye on him. "How?"

"Börü will want her back. He may bargain with land, prisoners, or passage. If he doesn't, Kaya's presence will force the Sungurs into a rescue attempt. We'll see how many people they send and which road they use."

Orkhon turned the stone on the table. "She also knows the eagle network."

"She won't speak," Batu said.

"Speaking isn't her only value." Temujin looked at Korgan. "Kill her and we give the Sungurs a martyr. Keep her alive and every day reminds them of their failure."

Korgan liked that reasoning. His thick fingers went still on the table.



"Let her live," he said. "If she escapes, you pay with your head."

"She won't escape."

"You'll see to that as well."

Thinking the decision settled, Batu raised his wine cup. Korgan lifted a hand and the cup stopped in the air.

"The western units will parade in three days," the Khan said. "March the prisoner before them. Let them see the Sungurs' eagle-head in chains."

Everything Temujin had calculated became something else in a single sentence. Humiliating Kaya would not reduce the Sungurs' bargaining position. It would intensify the pressure to rescue her. To Korgan, that was precisely where the prisoner's value lay.

"If we show her face, we show the watch routine too," Temujin said. "Everyone will learn which tent holds her, how many guards it has, and when she is brought outside."

Korgan smiled. "Is the Young Wolf afraid?"

"Yes. I'm afraid we'll lose our most valuable prisoner in a display of our own making."

Two commanders in the tent laughed. Korgan did not. Because Temujin had not denied fear, he could not be cornered with cowardice.

"We can have her likeness made," Orkhon said. "Two Azguts who know Kaya's face and one Sungur prisoner can attest to it. A proclamation can be read to the army. The prisoner need not be moved."

This time Korgan thought for a long while. "If the likeness is poor, I'll have the artist's hand cut off."

Temujin understood that the proposal had been accepted. Kaya would live three more days. What followed would require another calculation.

Temujin bowed his head. As he left the tent, he felt Korgan's gaze on his back.

Orkhon followed him. When they reached the rings of campfires, he spoke quietly.

"He felt no pride as he listened to your victory."

"I know."

"He was afraid."

"He's measuring me."

Orkhon stepped in front of him. "You don't choose the day fear begins."

Temujin looked at the tents around them. The Young Wolves' fire was smaller than the others, the gathering around it more orderly. Korgan saw the same thing.

"You want me to slow down."

"I want you to be less visible."

"I couldn't hide Kaya."

"You had to bring her to Korgan. You didn't have to persuade him to keep her alive."

Temujin did not answer. Orkhon was right. This time he had won more than a prisoner. He had shown everyone whose words the Khan heeded.

"Batu will use this," Orkhon said.

"He already is."

"He's offered two of the Young Wolves places in the main army's guard. They'll leave your command and answer directly to the Khan."

Temujin did not ask which two. Asking would turn the news Orkhon brought into a test of loyalty. The offer itself was cleverer than punishment. Instead of extinguishing Temujin's fire, Korgan was pulling away the wood around it one piece at a time.

"Anyone who wants to go can go," he said.

Orkhon frowned. "Is that all?"

"If I forbid them to leave, I confirm what Korgan fears. If they stay, I'll learn why they stayed."

"Sometimes a man leaves simply because he's offered more meat."

"Then I failed to see his hunger."

\* \* \*

Kaya was held in a tent between two rings of sentries. Her hands were bound in front of her. Storm watched Temujin from a wooden perch beside her, its wing bandaged.

One of the inner-ring guards had kept the eagle's tether short. Every time Storm opened its wings, the cord drew tight and jarred the injured wing again. Temujin lengthened the tether by an arm's span.

"What if it tears my hand off?" the guard asked.

"Don't reach toward the perch."

"The prisoner's animal is to be treated better than us?"

Temujin asked the soldier's name. The man gave it. "You'll be on the outer ring tonight. Find someone who isn't afraid of an eagle to replace you."

Kaya did not interfere. When the guard left, she nudged the water bowl closer to the perch with her foot.

"Has the decision been made?" Kaya asked.

"You'll live."

"Korgan has learned mercy."

"Korgan has learned to calculate value."

Temujin checked the water bowl beside the perch. The healer had cleaned the wing.

"Why are you caring for the eagle?"

"It was wounded on my order."

"My men died on your order too."

Temujin did not leave the statement unanswered. "Yes."

Some of the mockery left Kaya's face. "Do you think you're different from the other Azguts?"

"I know I'm different. I didn't say I was better."

"Good. That may be the first true thing you've told yourself."

Temujin called the interrogation clerk inside. The first questions concerned her name, duty, and place of capture. Kaya gave her name and position and described the valley. When asked how many eagle posts there were, she fell silent.

"Assume we already know," Temujin said.

"If you knew, you wouldn't ask."

"I ask to discover what we know incorrectly."

"Then I won't do you the kindness of correcting your error."

The clerk wrote no answer beside the empty line. Temujin had him mark every question on which Kaya remained silent. An interrogation did more than extract information. It showed which information she considered worth protecting.

When food arrived, two bowls were served from the same pot. Kaya first asked about the shares of her two wounded men. Temujin had the healer's

records brought in. One had a fever; the arrow had been removed from the other's leg. Kaya could not read the paper, but had the clerk translate it line by line.

"Why are you showing me this?"

"So you know I did what I promised."

"So I'll feel indebted and talk."

"If whether you talk changes my promise, it wasn't a promise."

Kaya took the bowl. After one mouthful, she set aside meat for Storm.

Temujin turned toward the door.

"Young Wolf."

He stopped.

"Börü won't bargain for me," Kaya said. "He won't weaken the clan for one person. Add that to your account."

Temujin opened the tent flap. "People make their soundest decisions when someone else pays the cost. We'll see."

Outside, he changed the watch rotation. He feared Korgan changing his mind again more than Kaya escaping.

He wrote into the night roster that Korgan's guards were not to enter the prisoner's tent alone, then pressed his own seal beneath the order. If Kaya escaped, he would pay with his head. If Korgan's men killed her, the record would now show whose order they had defied.

## Chapter 10 — City of Stone and Mist

*(TOGAN)*

Metheris did not emerge from the mist all at once. First came the North Beacon. Then the upper city carved into the cliffs, the walls, and the masts filling the harbor appeared.

Togan stopped behind the hill. Every tent in Eaglehold stacked one atop another would not have filled a single row of houses at the harbor. Smoke formed a low ceiling above the tiered streets. Burkut shifted uneasily on his shoulder.

"We won't go inside," Togan said.

He would make a wide arc east of the city and reach the beginning of the Northern Campaign Road. The detour that looked easy on the map was closed off in the land itself by patrols and stone walls.

Near midday, he heard six riders approaching. He sent Burkut into the air and slipped behind a half-collapsed farm wall. He lay in the wet earth and pulled the edge of his cloak over his armor.

The riders passed a few paces away.

"Is it true about the King's illness?" one said.

"The palace gates were closed last night."

"Who takes the throne if he dies?"

"There is no heir. The lords will devour one another."

"They'll devour us first."

The hoofbeats receded along the stone road.

Togan waited a while longer. The Hegemony's king might be dying. That meant more patrols blocking his road, perhaps civil war. Even a city's great troubles eventually reached the lone traveler on the road in the form of soldiers.

When he returned to the road behind the riders, he saw that the iron portcullis at the northern passage had been lowered. A dozen travelers waited before the wall as guards searched the wagons one by one. A new notice above the gate said that anyone bearing a mark of the steppes would be questioned. Togan could not read every word. The drawn Sungur wing was clear enough.

He sent Burkut to the crags above the city. As the eagle climbed, a guard noticed its shadow.

"Northern eagle!" he shouted.

Four men at the gate reached for their bows. Burkut did not cross the wall. It dipped one wing and glided east. Two riders left the line to follow it.

Togan emerged from behind the farm wall and ran toward the old quarry to the west. Earlier, he had seen a channel cut for rainwater passing beneath the city road. It was filled knee-deep with mud, and two bars in its iron grating were bent.

He drew his sword. The iron was rusted but ordinary metal beaten by human hands; it bore none of the Current's alteration. He wedged the end of

the pommel between the bars and leaned on it with all his weight. The grate opened the width of a finger. On the second push, the old wound in his shoulder pulled and his hand went numb.

The riders' hoofbeats passed over the quarry. Togan held his breath and heaved a third time. When the bar came free, the gap was wide enough for his shoulders. He pushed his pack through first and forced himself into the muddy channel.

The stones dropped lower in the middle of the tunnel. He had to crawl. Every scrape of his armor against the ceiling swelled in the narrow passage. A dog barked behind him. One of the guards had found the grating.

Togan felt cool air in the darkness ahead. He crawled the final three paces and emerged into a dry streambed on the northern slope. Burkut called once from a distant pine. Togan did not run to him. First he braced the loosened grating from within using a stone. Even if the dog could pass, armored men would not be able to come quickly through the same gap.

Half an hour later, the quarry had disappeared from sight. Togan walked in the stream to give his tracks to the water. His shoulder burned with every step. Passing around the city without drawing a sword had demanded more patience than a fight on the open steppes.

By evening, he had left Metheris behind. The road north broadened here and was paved with even stones. Nameless monuments planted at intervals began to line both sides.

He stopped before the first stone. There was no writing on its uncut face.

An old man was clearing dry grass from its foot. He did not straighten until Togan drew near. The small hoe in his hand looked more like a grave tender's tool than a weapon.

"If you're looking for its name, you won't find it," the man said.

"Whose name?"

"The stone's. There are thirty-two people inside it. They said there wasn't room for all their names."

The man explained that he cleared the grass around every monument along the road, each raised for an expedition party. The palace paid him nothing. He did not know which stone belonged to his brother, so he cut the grass around them all.

"Are you going north?"

"I'm passing along the road."

The old man shook the soil from the end of his hoe. "Most who go north tell the same lie. As if there were somewhere else on the far side of the road."

Togan took the last apple from his pack and offered the man half. The man would not take it. He told Togan to save it for Burkut.

"Eagles don't eat apples."

"Then bring it to me on your way back."

Togan left half the apple at the foot of the stone. "What if I don't return?"

"My brother will eat it."

The man did not say it as a joke.

Gareth had said these had been raised for the parties that went north and never came back. Togan placed his hand against the stone. Cold traveled through his palm and up his arm.

How many people had still had the chance to turn back at this point? How many had failed to use it?

The half-told news about Kaya returned to his mind. He knew that if he went south now, he would no longer find the trail. If he went north, the possibility that he had abandoned her would follow him.

"I'll come back," he told the stone. "For both of us."

He did not distinguish whether he meant Melira or Kaya.

He took his hand from the stone and continued along the road. Burkut flew ahead. Togan did not look back until the North Beacon's light disappeared behind the mist.

When the pain in his shoulder surged that night, he replaced the bandage. The wound had opened again while he forced the grating. There was little blood, but his fingers trembled when he raised his arm above his head. He counted his provisions, his cloth, and the monuments ahead. The road had escaped the walls of Metheris. Togan's body continued to carry the portion it had taken from that wall.

## Chapter 11 — Sails on the Horizon

(KARIA)

The King's condition did not change for three days. On the fourth morning, the eastern lookout reported eight warships.

Karia received the news in her study. On her desk lay Theodoric's watch schedule, Severin's sealed file, and two accounts of the coastal creatures. She would not wait for a third report now.

"Flags?" she asked.

"None. The hulls don't match. The lead galleon has a metal hook on its prow."

Patchwork Harbor.

Karia pulled the cord beside the window. "First and Third Fleets will put to sea. Second Fleet will remain at the harbor mouth. Don't raise the chain. Bring the merchant craft to the inner quay."

The officer repeated the orders, then paused. "All the ships are ready, Admiral."

"I don't want the pirates to see that too."

Half an hour later, the *Oath of the Drowning Mother* entered the mist. Karia left only two fjord ships visible north of Metherris. Six ships entered the southern cove and lowered their sails before the dark rocks along the shore. The chain across the harbor mouth was kept just below the surface.

When the mist parted, eight pirate ships came into view. A one-armed man stood at the bow of the leading galleon. His brass hook caught the morning light.

"Roric," the signal officer said.

Karia did not lower the spyglass. The pirate fleet's formation was uneven. Two small ships lagged behind, and the vessel on the right overworked its rudder at every turn. Instead of placing the weakest ships in the center, Roric had left them at the rear of the line. He wanted to strike Metherris quickly. He was not thinking about his return.

"No fire until they're within cannon range," Karia said.

"They'll think we have only two ships."

"That's why they came."



Roric's ships spread out and turned toward the harbor entrance. The first pirate cannon fired early. Its ball fell two ship-lengths off Karia's starboard side. A cheer rose from the pirate line. A second shot struck the rock beneath the North Beacon, spilling shattered stone into the water.

Karia waited.

When Roric's right wing drew close to the harbor chain, the signal flag went up. The soldiers inside worked the capstans and brought the chain above the water. Unable to stop, the leading pirate craft rode into the metal line. Its bow swung sideways and blocked the ship behind it.

"Now."

Karia's two northern ships turned their broadsides and opened fire. At the same instant, six sails rose in the southern cove. The fjord ships headed not for Roric's line of retreat, but for the gap between the two slow ships at the rear. The pirate fleet was not caught inside a single trap. It was being split into three pieces.

Roric saw it. He ordered his galleon's foresail lowered and a hard turn east. When the ship beside it tried to turn at the same time, their rigging entangled.

"Don't sink the flagship," Karia said. "Take its rudder."

The first volley shattered Roric's stern. The second ball passed over the rudder blade and tore apart the aft rail. The galleon kept turning. They were using the emergency steering lines.

An explosion shook Karia's starboard ship. A pirate ball had punched through the upper deck and felled two sailors carrying powder. When the smoke thinned, she saw fire at the foot of the mainmast.

"Send the water crew alongside the starboard ship."

"That will open Roric's retreat," the officer said.

"Then it opens. If that ship burns, forty people die."

The light boat held in reserve entered the battle line. A third pirate ship took aim at it. Karia ordered the northern wing to turn broadside. Two volleys silenced the firing ship's gun deck.

The pirate craft caught on the chain tore open its lower planking as it tried to free itself. When it began taking water, its captain raised a white cloth. Rather than slacken the chain and tow the ship inside, the Methers

sailors sent two rescue boats. The armed crew would remain on deck; the wounded would be taken first.

"Why aren't we bringing the surrendered ship into the harbor?" the signal officer asked.

"We don't know how much water is beneath her. If she sinks inside the chain, she closes our own gate."

The battle lasted less than an hour. Two pirate ships sank. One surrendered outside the chain. The remaining five fled into the mist in separate directions. When Roric's damaged galleon turned toward the Razor Reefs, two of Karia's fast ships followed.

"Recall them," Karia said.

The captain lowered his spyglass. "Her rudder is damaged. We're one volley behind."

"You're entering the reefs using his chart. Turn back."

The signal was repeated three times. The first ship turned. The second continued for a few breaths more, then swung its bow around. Roric vanished into the mist.

Karia knew that refusing pursuit would be called cowardice. If she pursued and left two ships on the reefs, she would have to explain the cost of courage to the families of the dead.

The captain of the captured ship was brought onto the deck. Blood ran from a wound on his forehead. Karia did not have his bonds removed, but ordered the wound dressed.

"How many ships does Roric have left?"

"As many as you saw."

"Is the flagship taking water?"

The man laughed bitterly. "We're all taking water, Admiral."

"Are there any coastal defenses left at Patchwork Harbor?"

The captain fell silent for the first time. Karia had the silence entered into the record. Roric's campaign was not only an attack on Metherris. It was a wager that had left his own harbor exposed.

\* \* \*

The count began on the battlefield. Thirteen Hegemony sailors were dead and twenty-seven wounded. The starboard ship reached by the water crew had been saved; its mainmast would be cut down and the vessel towed into the harbor. The wounded pirates were sent to the same infirmary. When two people from the harbor objected, Karia had to explain that treatment did not erase judgment.

On the way back to Metheris, a boat from the palace came alongside. The arriving officer saluted as soon as he reached the deck.

"His Majesty has woken. The physicians say the seizure has passed."

The rope loosened in Karia's hand. "Can he speak?"

"For short periods."

"Has Vorlag seen him?"

"No. The watch ledger is being enforced."

Karia looked at the wounded ships entering the harbor. The King had lived, and the attack had been repelled. Both pieces of news would be proclaimed as victories. Yet thirteen names lay beneath one, and behind the other were six votes that had spent three days measuring an empty throne.

"Bring me the list of losses first," she said. "Then we'll go to the King."

## Chapter 12 — The Empty Throne

*(ZALEENA)*

The first ship returned before dawn on the third day.

It had broken away from the fleet of eight and lost its mainmast. Fewer people remained standing on its deck than lay wounded there. They tried to signal at the harbor mouth, but a severed halyard let the flag rise halfway before it fell again.

The northern lookout's bell woke Zaleena. By the time she reached the pier, Kessel's two small boats had come alongside the damaged ship. Their crews hauled the oars by hand while those onshore guided the vessel with ropes.

"Clear the casualty quay," Zaleena said. "Those who can't walk first. Then the flooded section. Cargo last."

The ship's captain collapsed to his knees as he came over the side. Blood seeped through the bandage on his arm. Zaleena did not lift him. She crouched beside him.

"The others?"

"Two ships sank. One surrendered. The rest scattered." The man flinched as he spoke, as if turning his head at every cannon shot. "Roric's stern was torn apart. We lost him in the mist. His ship was burning."

"Did you see his body?"

"No."

"Did you see him surrender?"

"No."

"Did you see his ship sink?"

"Not that either."

Zaleena had the quay clerk record all three answers separately. After sending the captain to the infirmary, she took the ship's muster book. Seventeen of forty-three people had returned. Five had been seen dead; the fate of twenty-one was unknown.

As the names were read, the families waiting onshore surged forward. One woman did not understand the word "missing" after she heard her son's name and made the clerk repeat it. Another seized the clerk by the collar because no one read out a name at all. The last two pages of the ledger were waterlogged, their ink dispersed.

Zaleena had the legible names entered on one list and the ruined lines on another. She did not move the uncertain into the register of the dead. It did nothing to shorten anyone's wait. It only kept her from hiding behind a false certainty.

By noon, two more small boats had arrived. One did not belong to the fleet; it had brought six castaways found at sea. Roric was not among them.

In the tavern, Roric was dead. At the fish market, he was a prisoner of the Hegemony. On the southern pier, he had sold his men and fled. Every rumor became a little more certain at the table where it was told.

Before evening, two captains laid claim to the Wreck Throne.

The first argument in the Cracked Skull began over which man held more shares in ships. Then it moved to age, battles fought, and kinship with Roric.

One captain drove his knife into the table. When the other drew his own blade, the crews around them rose.

Zaleena took the brass bell and struck it three times. The noise did not stop at once. When Kessel left the rear wall and stood before the door, it became harder for armed men outside to enter.

"We don't know that Roric is dead," Zaleena said.

"He didn't return," one captain shouted. "The throne is empty."

"If we buried every captain lost at sea on the third night, half of you wouldn't be sitting in this room."

"Will the harbor be left without a leader?"

Zaleena unfolded the paper before her. Until Roric returned, his death was confirmed, or the thirty-day missing period expired, defense and provisions would remain under the Captains' Council.

"Who will enforce it?" a captain asked.

"The Council will cut the harbor share of anyone who breaks the rule."

"A roster can't hold a sword."

"Neither can a share. Yet you're all here for one."

Kessel stepped forward. "What if Roric doesn't return?"

Zaleena gave the answer before everyone for the first time. "The Captains' Council will convene. A new leader will be chosen by vote, not duel."

The objections merged into one another. Some said Roric had won the throne by duel. Others said the old wreck law demanded blood. Zaleena did not ring the bell again. She waited until everyone had spoken and exhausted their breath.

"Roric's mistake was haste," she said when silence formed. "Anyone who wants to replace him should not make the same mistake his first act."

The captain who had drawn his knife was still standing. "If you oversee the vote, you'll be preparing the throne for yourself."

"The Wreck Throne's powers won't be used under the interim order. I won't be able to cut a ship's share on my own either."

Kessel raised his hand. "I vote for the interim order."

Another hand went up. Then three. The measure passed not unanimously, but with the required majority. The names of those who voted against were written in letters the same size as the rest.

\* \* \*

Sorin walked beside her on the way back to the ship. "One step from the throne."

"We don't know that the throne is empty."

"You're waiting for it to become empty."

Zaleena stopped. "I want Roric to return alive. I don't want his way of ruling to return. Learn the difference."

Sorin lowered his head. "What about the flag?"

"First we get the harbor to morning."

That night, a captain on the southern pier tried to move his own wounded to the front of the line. When the watchman refused, the man marched onto the quay with two armed crewmen. The interim panel was selected by lot. Kessel, a young fishing captain, and an old captain loyal to Roric reached the same decision. The man lost one day's harbor share. His wounded kept their place in line.

When the punishment was actually enforced, no second captain tried.

A watch roster was posted at every pier. For the first time, Patchwork Harbor slept not under the order of a king, but under a common rule bearing the names of those who opposed it too.

## Section 8 — Threshold of the Dead Lands

### Chapter 13 — Vengeance of the Eagles

*(TEMUJIN)*

The Sungur raiders struck the border outpost before dawn. Five Azguts died; the attackers withdrew without taking provisions.

By the time Temujin arrived, the bodies had been laid side by side in the outpost yard. Three had been struck while leaving their beds, one in the gate tower, and the last while trying to reach the horses. Every arrow had been recovered. Only two broken shafts remained.

Sube brought him the mark tied to the gatepost. An eagle feather had been wrapped around a broken arrow.

"A message about Kaya," he said.

Temujin took the token. The feather did not come from Storm's dark wings; it belonged to a small steppe eagle. The message concerned Kaya, but did not use her personal mark.

One surviving watchman placed the attackers' number at fifteen, another at thirty. A third admitted that in the darkness he had heard only horses. Temujin did not average the three figures. He had what they saw and what they heard written separately.

"Let's go after them," Sube said. "The trail is still warm."

"They split into two parties during the retreat."

"Then we split too."

Temujin pointed out the hoofprints beyond the wall. The party to the right had left a wide, obvious trail. The left-hand trail reached stony ground and vanished after ten paces. The obvious route had been left to be followed.

"Send one party and it walks into an ambush," he said. "Send two and both are weak."

Sube looked at the five shrouds in the yard. "Do we bury them without striking back?"

"Today we bury them. We won't look for an answer on the road anger chooses."

One of the dead men's brothers heard him. He walked up and shoved Temujin in the chest with both hands. When the Young Wolf guards moved to pull the man away, Temujin stopped them.

"You brought Kaya here," the man said. "They came for her."

"Yes."

"Then who owns the blood of those five?"

Temujin could not cleanse the question with a speech. "I gave the order. The account is mine."

The man did not strike him a third time. He went back and knelt beside one of the shrouds.

\* \* \*

Korgan was angered not by the dead, but by the defiance.

"I lost five men because of your prisoner."

"If Kaya were dead, the attack might have been larger."

"How do you know?"

Temujin saw the weakness in his own sentence before he answered. He did not know. He assumed the Sungurs would mount a larger attack for a dead commander.

"I don't," he said. "I think they were testing the border for a rescue."

Korgan's one eye narrowed. "Are we buying your thoughts now?"

"The tracks show they didn't come for provisions. They didn't remain at the outpost or take horses, and they left a Kaya mark on the gate."

"Take five heads and we won't need to know their purpose," Batu said.

"Then they take five more," Temujin said.

Korgan struck the table with his fist. "If I lose one more outpost, I'll kill Kaya myself."

"Then we won't lose another."

Temujin proposed drawing the two border posts back for one night and placing a false supply camp between them. If the Sungurs returned, they



would see an easy target, while hidden scouts around it recorded their numbers and route of retreat. No attack would be launched. If a second ambush was confirmed, the main force would move.

Korgan accepted the plan. This time, no one spoke of Temujin's success.

\* \* \*

The false camp used twenty tents, empty grain sacks, and six real horses. Temujin had the campfires laid out with the same disorder soldiers made every night. A lure too perfect looked like one even from a distance.

Sube walked among the tents to make the sentries' tracks look real. "What if they don't come?"

"We investigate what they saw that kept them away."

"What if the outpost raid was only vengeance?"

Temujin remembered the feathered arrow. "Then we've laid a trap for the wrong question."

He had not told Korgan about that possibility.

When he went to Kaya's tent, he did not conceal the news of the five deaths. He told her their number and described the mark left behind. Kaya pushed her food aside.

"Did Börü send them?" Temujin asked.

"I wouldn't tell you if I knew."

"The mark is for you."

"The mark might be there to make you think so."

Temujin laid the broken arrow before her. Kaya did not touch the feather.

"It isn't Storm's," she said.

"I saw that."

"Then what do you want to learn?"

"Would the Sungurs approach an exposed supply camp?"

For the first time, Kaya gave a short laugh. "If you're asking me that, you've already built the camp."

Temujin was silent.

"You attacked the eagle network," Kaya said. "Then you pitched tents on the plain as though the network had no eyes."

"I know we didn't blind every eye."

"Knowing and acting aren't the same thing."

Temujin took the arrow and left. Kaya's words might be right. If he dismantled the camp at once, he would show Korgan that a single sentence from his prisoner could change his plans. He decided to wait one night.

\* \* \*

That night Yeva blocked his path. Three lines converged at the same point on the cracked shoulder blade in her hand.

"What did you see this time?" Temujin asked.

"Kaya is one of the cords. One goes to her clan, one to you. The third reaches north."

"Who is in the north?"

"Bone doesn't speak names. You would use a guess as intelligence."

The scouts' report came in the morning. The Sungurs had not approached the false camp. Two eagles had been seen on the northern ridge, and both had turned west after midnight. From above, they had seen the location of the lure and the gaps in the watch.

Temujin ordered the camp dismantled. He did not burn the empty sacks; he had them counted back in. In the first line of his report to Korgan, he wrote what he did not know: Kaya's eagle network was not without a commander. He laid the feathered arrow on the paper.

## Chapter 14 — Threshold of the Dead Lands

*(TOGAN)*

The fields thinned within three days of Metheris. First the stone walls ended, then the fences. On the fifth day, Togan left the last tree behind him.

The earth turned from brown to gray. The grass did not vanish at once. With every league it grew shorter and tougher. Beyond the final root, only fine ash driven by the wind lay on either side of the road. The stone monuments multiplied as wagon tracks dwindled.

Burkut could find no prey. On the first day, he remained aloft for a long time and returned with empty talons. On the second, he opened his wings for

half an hour before settling again on Togan's shoulder. Togan divided his ration of dried meat in two and gave him the larger piece.

"Don't make a habit of this," he said.

Burkut swallowed the meat in one bite.

Water was the greater problem. Gareth had said that some of the monuments had rain basins. The first three were cracked. Following a groove on the fourth stone's northern face, Togan found a covered hollow beneath the ash. It held two bowls of cloudy water. He strained it through cloth and boiled it, using dry thistles gathered beside the road for his fire.

When the wind rose that night, he stretched his cloak between two monuments. He put his sword beneath his arm and his waterskin against his chest. Burkut slept not atop the stone, but in the narrow space beneath the cloak.

He dreamed he was in a white room.

There was no corner where the walls met. Light came from everywhere and warmed nothing. An empty chair stood in the center. Togan tried to approach it, but his feet would not leave the floor.

A hum began. The sound struck not his ears, but the inside of his rib cage. With each vibration, the light around the chair contracted.

He knew someone was meant to sit there.

He could not remember who.

Five shadows appeared behind the chair. They had no faces. One raised a hand and spoke the name Togan had used as a child. No one but Kaya and Anya still knew that name.

Togan tried to throw himself forward. The white floor held his feet.

When he woke, his hand was on his chest. His heart beat to the rhythm of the hum. Burkut's wings were half-open as the eagle watched his face. Togan said his own name, Kaya's, and Melira's aloud. All three were in place.

The dream did not dissolve with the sunrise.

\* \* \*

Near midday, he saw five people ahead on the road. They were old and carried long staffs and packs rather than weapons. The woman at the rear

did not put her full weight on her left foot. Togan stepped off the road and kept his distance.

The wind carried their conversation to him.

"The chair was closer this time," the woman said.

The man in front stopped. "I couldn't approach it."

"None of us can. Whoever the gate wants will sit there."

The hair rose on Togan's neck.

All five travelers turned at once. Togan did not hide. He returned to the road, leaving twenty paces between them.

"How long have you been seeing it?" he asked.

The man in front gripped his staff with both hands. "Seeing what?"

"The white room."

The woman forgot her injured foot and stepped forward. "Did you see the chair?"

"I did."

"Could you approach it?"

"No."

The man's face relaxed. He had begun to see Togan not as a threat, but as proof he had been waiting for. That unsettled Togan more than a drawn sword.

The travelers said they had shared the same dream for six nights. One believed a gate would open in the north. Another believed the empty chair waited for an ancient king. The woman offered no interpretation, only said the hum grew stronger every night.

"It's calling us," the man in front said. "If we go together, we'll learn which of us it wants."

"What if it wants none of you?"

The man's fingers tightened on the staff. "Then why is it showing us?"

Togan did not know the answer. His ignorance did not make the other man's answer true.

The cloth around the woman's foot had darkened. Togan closed the distance and asked permission to see the wound. A burst blister on her heel had become infected. He took out the last of Seren's salve and bound it with clean cloth.

"You should have kept that for yourself," the woman said.

"My foot isn't open."

The man in front saw the Sungur braid on Togan's wrist. "Were you called from the steppes?"

"I wasn't having this dream when I set out."

"Yet here you are."

"I'm looking for someone."

"The person in the chair?"

"Someone whose name I know."

The man wanted to ask more. Togan closed his waterskin and stood. If he walked with the five travelers, their provisions might last longer and they could share the night watch. But he would also be binding himself to the decisions of a group who treated every dream as an order.

"We'll use the same road until evening," he said. "Then I'll leave you."

The travelers agreed. During the hours they walked together, Togan asked where the dreams had first begun. All five named different places. The only common point was the night the Year of Waiting began. One said he had seen crimson water beneath the chair; another had heard wings against the ceiling. Togan did not borrow the details he had not seen.

At sunset, the travelers turned east of the monuments onto an old pilgrimage path running northeast. Togan remained on the main road. The woman with the bandaged foot gave him a handful of dried roots. The man in front asked once more that he join them.

"When the gate opens, you'll be alone."

"You don't know what you'll do even as a crowd," Togan said.

Five shadows dwindled across the plain of ash. Togan did not follow.

\* \* \*

The white room returned on the second night. The chair was one step closer. This time the shadows behind it were gone. A small dark stain marked the seat. Togan could not tell whether it was blood or rust.

When the hum began, he tried to remember Melira's face. He found her hair first, then her hands. Her eyes eluded him for several breaths. Togan shouted in the dream.

He woke with the taste of ash in his mouth. He remembered Melira's eyes. He took a sip from his waterskin and wrote three sentences in his notebook to draw a line between what the dream showed him and his own memory: White room. Empty chair. Dark stain.

He wrote no interpretation.

Before dawn, a pale golden line appeared on the northern horizon. The sun remained in the east; this light ran low and level along the ground, unbroken. Burkut climbed onto the stone and ruffled his feathers. The old ache beneath Togan's injured shoulder deepened as it did in the cold.

The Wall of Light.

He could not tell whether it lay hours or days away. The monuments along the road led directly toward the glow. Togan counted his provisions again: two days' meat, a handful of roots, half a waterskin.

"We found it," he said.

It did not mean the road was over. For the first time, he had seen something that proved he was not going the wrong way.

## Chapter 15 — Four Thresholds

*(CLOSING: TOGAN / TEMUJIN / KARIA / ZALEENA)*

Togan kept walking the first night he saw the glow of the Wall of Light.

The golden line looked near in the darkness and withdrew again with every rise in the road. He judged the distance between two monuments to be half a league. By the time he reached the next, the moon had moved. Burkut no longer flew ahead, but sat on his shoulder with his eyes closed.

Togan stopped after stumbling for the third time. The stone that caught his foot was not in the middle of the road. He had drifted to the edge without noticing. Seeing the light had made him think he knew his direction, so he had stopped watching the ground.

He spread his cloak at the foot of a monument. He gave Burkut the last large piece of dried meat and chewed the roots he had received from the travelers. If he slept, he might see the white room again. If he did not, he was tired enough to break his foot by morning.

He opened his notebook. He wrote the three fragments he had heard about Kaya: eagle commander, Korgan, prisoner. He did not write whether she was dead. Beneath them he added Melira's name and closed the book.

Before sleeping, he carved a small Sungur mark at the foot of the stone monument. Beneath it he added a line pointing north and the date. If he lost the way back, it would be the records he left behind, not Burkut, that guided him.

The dream did not come that night. Togan did not decide whether this was good or bad when the sun rose. He stood, divided his remaining water across two days, and walked toward the glow.

\* \* \*

At the Great Camp, the report on the false supply camp was read before Korgan.

Temujin did not leave the failure to the scribe. He said himself that Sungur eagles had seen the camp from the northern ridge, that no riders had approached, and that Kaya's captivity had not left the western network without a commander.

Korgan turned the feathered, broken arrow between two fingers as he listened.

"You wrote that you had cut off the head of the network."

"I took Kaya. The network continued. My first message was incomplete."

"Was it a lie?"

"It was an assumption written as a result."

Batu laughed. "The Young Wolf has long names for his mistakes now."

Temujin did not turn to him. Whatever punishment Korgan imposed was more tangible than Batu's mockery.

"Five soldiers died," Korgan said. "You'll explain the cost of your mistake to their families."

"I did."

"Explain it again. This time, pay compensation from your own unit's share."

The penalty would reduce the Young Wolves' winter provisions.

"I accept."

Korgan tore the feather from the arrow. "Kaya lives. For now. The next Sungur attack changes the decision."

Sube and Orkhon were waiting when Temujin left the tent. They did not speak until they reached the Young Wolf fire. All twenty-eight warriors were there. One of the two men Korgan had offered main-army guard duty was absent. The other sat at the very back of the circle.

Temujin remained standing. He explained the failed camp and the five deaths again with the same candor. He gave the amount of compensation that would be deducted from the unit's share. Then he read the word "leaderless" from his first message.

"I wrote it as intelligence. It wasn't."

"Did you say that before the Khan too?" the warrior in the back row asked.

"Yes."

"What's the punishment?"

Temujin repeated the compensation.

Another man stood. "We're losing our winter meat for five Azguts."

"We're losing it because of my plan. You have the right to leave my command if you want. Korgan's offer is open."

Sube disliked the statement, but did not interfere. No one spoke for a long while. The second warrior who had received the main army's offer stood.

"They give more meat," he said. "I'm transferring tomorrow."

Temujin nodded. He did not ask the man to surrender his weapon. Returning the Young Wolves' copies of the maps and his signal cord would be enough. Temujin did not call the transfer betrayal.

After the meeting, Sube said, "If you let him go so easily, others will follow."

"We'll see how many stay when the winter share is smaller."

The watch at Kaya's tent remained doubled. Temujin did not interrogate her that night. Passing the outer ring, he heard Storm cry once. The eagle network was still speaking. For the first time, Temujin did not assume every sound was a message written for him.

\* \* \*



In Metheris, King Theodoric rose from his bed on the fourth day. The chief physician had allowed him two steps. The King took a third and sat in the chair beside him before he could reach the Salt Throne.

Karia did not try to lift him. She had the chair drawn to the desk. First she placed the Council minutes before Theodoric, then the list of losses from the sea battle.

"How many votes did Vorlag have?" the King asked.

"Three. The regency failed. So did my counterproposal. The existing orders continued."

"You allowed the throne to remain empty."

"The throne wasn't empty. You were unable to use it. They aren't the same thing."

Theodoric searched for the strength to be angry at the answer. When he could not find it, he continued reading the minutes. At the line saying Valerius had twice brought an order to the chamber, he held his finger in place.

"You didn't let him inside."

"I didn't leave you alone with anyone."

"Not even you?"

"I entered while the watch ledger was being kept. The physician was in the room."

When the King realized Karia had granted herself no separate privilege, he rested his head against the chair. Then he opened the list of losses. He read all thirteen names one by one. At the third he stopped and asked which ship the sailor had served on. Karia answered. She did not know the ninth name; she ordered the clerk to bring the man's file.

"Roric?" Theodoric asked.

"Escaped. His ship was badly damaged. Two of ours pursued. I recalled them before they entered the reefs."

"Could you have caught him?"

"Perhaps."

"A good historian dislikes that word."

"So do the families of dead sailors. That's why I didn't wager two ships on it."

Theodoric closed the list. The order canceling the succession agenda was brought before him. His hand was not strong enough to press the seal, so Karia held the wax and the King pressed his own ring into it.

"This order won't conceal my illness," he said.

"We won't conceal it. We'll release the portion the chief physician permits."

"The Council will use my weakness."

"It already did. The record shows it."

Karia set before him an order restricting the King's work to two hours a day without the chief physician's written permission.

When Theodoric read the final order, he asked, "Are you placing me under supervision too?"

"It wouldn't be necessary if you could govern yourself first."

The King did not remove his ring. Karia did not apologize. The Salt Throne stood empty at the far end of the room. No one sat on it that day.

\* \* \*

The first night of the interim order passed without a fight in Patchwork Harbor. On the second night, the southern-pier captain's share was actually cut. By the third, every watchman had memorized the roster.

There was no word from Roric. Two of the scattered ships were confirmed to have sheltered in small coves. One had no rudder; the other had eleven wounded. Fishermen from the north said they had seen a burning galleon. No one had seen the ship sink.

Zaleena had the lists of missing people posted on the wall of the Cracked Skull. Three columns stood beside every name: seen, heard, confirmed. As families brought new reports, the clerk added only the source and did not change the conclusion.

Kessel read the list for a long time. Then he sat not in the empty head chair at the meeting table, but in the ordinary seat across from Zaleena.

"Will you stand when the thirty days are over?" he asked.

Sorin lifted his pen. He did not know whether this conversation belonged in the minutes.

"No candidacies will open before Roric returns," Zaleena said.

"I didn't ask about the deadline."

Zaleena had safe answers available. She could say she was thinking of the harbor's interest, that the decision belonged to the Council, or that she harbored no personal ambition. None would be wholly true.

"Yes," she said. "If he doesn't return, I'll stand."

Sorin wrote it into the minutes.

Kessel did not say, "That's what I wanted to hear." He said, "Then let's mark every power in the interim order you could use for your own benefit."

The three opened the text again. The watch roster Zaleena prepared would no longer take effect without the approval of two captains.

"You're making your own road harder," Sorin said.

"If it stays easy, someone will say I prepared it for myself. And he'll be right."

At the bottom, Zaleena wrote a single word:

*Vote.*

She posted the paper on the wall herself. When the wind lifted the lower corner, she drove in another nail.

# 3. Part — Army of Shadows

\* \* \*

## Section 9 — Wreckage and Seven Lords

### Chapter 1 — Pride Washed Ashore

(ZALEENA)

The fisherman boarded the *Sea Ghost* shortly before midnight. He had left his nets, his baskets, and a family who needed his help onshore. A man like that came empty-handed only when he feared the news he carried.

He looked behind him twice as soon as he stepped onto the deck. Zaleena took him not to the captain's cabin, but to the open worktable in the bow. Sorin remained at the table. She did not want the conversation to have only one witness.

"We found a boat south of the Whisper Road," the fisherman said. "Run onto the rocks. There were two men inside. One was dead. The other..."

The man closed his right hand into a fist above the wrist.

"I knew him by the hook. Roric."

Sorin's pen stopped over the paper. Two candidates in the harbor were waiting for Roric's death, eight captains wanted him to return, and hundreds of crewmen's families grieved without knowing his fate. A single name could set all of them in motion on the same night.

"Who saw the boat?" Zaleena asked.

"My two boys. And me."

"Any other boats?"

"Two netters were onshore. They didn't enter the cave."

Zaleena turned to Sorin. "Get the netters' names. Don't lie to them. Tell them a wounded sailor was found among the rocks and his identity hasn't been confirmed."

"We know who he is," the fisherman said.

"We do. The harbor doesn't."

She took three silver pieces from her belt and placed them in his palm. "One for your boat. One for the catch you lost tonight. The last for keeping his identity to yourself until the Council asks."

The fisherman looked not at the money, but at Zaleena. "I owe you nothing, Captain."

"Then don't call it a debt. Call it your share for getting the harbor to morning without everyone stabbing one another. You can refuse. If you do, I won't keep you here."

Before closing his fingers, the man looked at Sorin's record. "Will my name stay there?"

"Yes."

"Then I'll take it. No one can say afterward that I was silenced."

Sorin recorded the payment and its condition. The fisherman made his mark.

\* \* \*

The cave mouth looked like a narrow fissure from the sea. When Zaleena entered with Sorin and two crewmen, the fire was almost dead. Waves broke at the entrance, and each withdrawal left behind a sound like metal scraping between the stones.

Roric lay on sailcloth spread over the rock. Crusted burns covered the left side of his face. All that remained of his old hook were leather straps and a wrist wrapped in cloth. The sailor lying several paces away had been covered.

Zaleena went to the dead man first. She found the wooden identity token at his neck and gave it to Sorin. The name, ship, and share mark were legible. The record of Roric's defeat would not begin with Roric alone.

Roric opened his one eye. "You're late if you came to laugh."

"I didn't come to laugh."

"Then you came to kill me."

Zaleena crouched and smelled the bandage. Rot had begun, but had not reached the bone. The fisherman's sons had cleaned the wound with salt water and laid wet cloth on it to reduce the fever.

"If I wanted you dead, I would have asked where the cave was and gone home."

Roric tried to sit up. When his body refused, he clenched his teeth. "I sailed with eight ships. Two sank before my eye. I didn't see what happened after. The thing you call a king has no crown, Zaleena. It's staying strong while his men are watching."

"I tried to tell you that before you sailed."

"I know."

Those two words weighed on Roric more heavily than his wounds. For years Zaleena had wanted him to admit he was wrong. She took no pleasure in hearing it while he lay broken before her.

"What happened at Metherris?" she asked.

Roric closed his eye. He described how Karia had appeared weak with two ships before the fleet emerged from the southern mist. He told her how they had run into the harbor chain, how two ships had blocked each other's course, and how his rudder had been shattered by the first volley.

"They came after us," he said. "Turned back when we entered the reefs."

"When they could have sunk you?"

"Perhaps."

Saying that word was harder for Roric than admitting defeat. He did not believe Karia had spared him. He was enough of a sailor to understand that she had refused to sacrifice her own ships to the reefs.

"If you return to the harbor, the captains will tear you apart," Zaleena said. "If you don't, they'll tear one another apart using your name."

"Since when are my choices your concern?"

"Since they began affecting my harbor."

Roric gave a short laugh that became a cough. He wiped the blood from his mouth on the edge of the cloth.

"What do you want?"

"I'll announce that Roric is missing at sea. I won't say you're dead. I'll keep you in the lower cabin of the *Sea Ghost*. The surgeon, Sorin, and I will know who you are. If you recover, you'll put what you know on record: the captains' debts, hidden coves, supply stores, and the agreements you concealed while ruling the harbor."

"A cage."

"A cage with a door. You won't be held if you want to leave. The moment you come on deck, your identity and your statements will be disclosed to the Council."

"What if I make no statement?"

"You'll still be treated. When you can stand, you can go. I won't make you lie in exchange for your life."

Roric had not expected that part of the offer. "Then why are you hiding me?"

"I don't want the harbor choosing its method of leadership while staring at your wound. If you die in three days, your death will be announced. If you live, you'll have the right to speak as well. Until then, you won't burn everyone else's rights."

"Do you think you're forgiving me?"

"No. I'm protecting and using you. I'll put both in the same record."

The answer eased him. He could not bear pity. He still understood a bargain.

Roric laid his head back on the sailcloth. "Very well, Wreck Queen."

"That title isn't mine yet."

"It will be."

\* \* \*

Getting Roric out of the cave was harder than finding him. As the tidal fissure narrowed, they had to turn the stretcher sideways. When a wave broke inside, Roric's wounded wrist struck the rock. He did not scream. He lost consciousness.

They covered him with torn nets in the boat. They entered the harbor not at the fishermen's quay, but at the rear pier where salvaged metal was unloaded. Sorin wrote "wounded man, identity unconfirmed" on the cargo paper. Roric's name remained in a sealed appendix.

When the surgeon went down to the lower cabin, he objected to the locked door. "If there's a fire, this man dies."

Zaleena had the bolt that locked from outside removed. They made a door that opened from within and was sealed from without. If the seal broke, they would know he had escaped. Roric would not burn inside.



"How long will we carry the secret?" Sorin asked.

"We'll decide again every morning. Record his fever, the number of fights in the harbor, and the Council summons. If any of the three changes, the secrecy changes too."

The dead sailor's name was added to the missing list that same night. A death share was issued to his family. His body was buried in the dry ground above the cave, with its location and witnesses recorded.

By morning, Zaleena had found a surgeon, a locked cabin, and an announcement that was half true. Roric was not dead. Nor had he returned to the harbor. She was using the space between those two sentences for her own power. That was why she did not conceal the date or witnesses of the space.

## Chapter 2 — Broken Wings

*(TEMUJIN)*

Kaya chose the change of watch rather than the night for her escape. Temujin would appreciate that later.

The midday sun was in the sentries' eyes. Two units had begun arguing over the same share of meat at the cooking pot, and the men at the western stakes had turned toward the noise. Kaya cut her bond with a thin piece of metal she had spent days filing from a bandage clasp. She untied Storm's leg tether and ran from behind the tent.

The first sentry dropped the bowl in his hand when he saw her. Instead of shouting, he drew his sword. Storm stooped and took his cap, and the eagle's talons tore open his temple as he stumbled. On the second pass, the horses shied and one of the picket ropes broke.

The instant Temujin stepped from his tent, he saw the empty stake, the eagle in the air, and the prisoner running toward the northern slope.

"Don't shoot," he said. "Get the nets."

Two of Batu's men had already drawn their bows. One lowered his arrow. The other hesitated. Temujin had to step in front of him.

"The order to take her alive hasn't changed."

The delay let Kaya reach the outer ring. Her right shoulder dipped every time she put weight on the wounded side, yet she kept widening the distance. Temujin sent four riders to hold the two flanks of the slope. He ordered the men on foot to narrow the line of escape and told them not to raise spears against the eagle.

Kaya turned not toward the open valley, but into the stony gully to the north. It was the one road on which the riders would lose speed. Temujin knew that the gully's exit had collapsed in the last rain. Kaya did not.

"Close the right slope. Leave the middle open."

Sube carried the weighted net with another man. When Kaya saw the collapse, she did not turn back. She tried to climb the rock. Her injured shoulder gave way on the first pull. When the net tangled around her legs, she fell face-first.

Storm stooped again. Instead of meeting the eagle with a spear, Sube dropped flat. The talons scratched the leather armor across his back. When another soldier raised his sword, Temujin caught his wrist.

"Don't touch the eagle."

Kaya caught her breath beneath the net. The corner of her mouth had struck the rock and was bleeding.

"Almost," she said.

"No." Temujin pointed to the collapsed exit and the riders on either side. "You ran where we left the way open."

"I ran all the same."

He could not argue with that.

Temujin ordered the net untangled. As two soldiers lifted Kaya, they twisted her arms harder than necessary. Temujin pulled one of them back.

"She escaped," the soldier said. "She wounded one of our men."

"That isn't an order to break her arm. The wounded man's account will be handled separately."

Kaya heard him. She did not offer thanks.

\* \* \*

In the new tent, two sentries remained inside and two outside. Temujin inspected the bonds himself. They were loose enough not to cut her wrists

and short enough to keep her from working at another clasp. The bandaging materials would be counted after every use.

Some wanted Storm locked in another tent. Temujin had the eagle placed on an open perch that Kaya could see but not reach. Its tether was long enough to open its wings.

"You'd been hiding that metal for three days," he said. "If you'd waited for the fourth night, the northern sentry would have changed."

Kaya wiped the blood from the corner of her mouth. "I'll wait next time."

"Next time they'll count the clasps."

"Then I'll find something else."

Temujin set the carved bone Yeva had given him before her. He felt the three lines with one finger. "One is your clan. One is me. The third goes north. You chose north when you ran too. What's there?"

"Mountains."

"You weren't running to the mountains. You were running to someone."

Kaya was silent. Temujin did not fill the space. People often bore silence less easily than a question. Outside, Storm pecked at its perch. Kaya's gaze shifted to the door at every third sound.

"Togan," she said at last. "My milk-brother. He left the clan a year ago and went north."

Temujin showed no reaction. "Why?"

Kaya pulled against the bonds at her wrists. "You have the name. You won't have the rest."

Temujin looked at the bone's third line. He had a name, a direction, and wrists Kaya would reopen to protect it. He asked no more.

"What will Korgan do if he learns the name?"

"Use me against him. Or him against me. Whichever is cheaper."

Temujin took back the bone. "Korgan won't hear the name."

"Why?"

"Because I don't know what use it has. I won't give what I don't understand to the Khan and let him turn it into a weapon."

Kaya studied him. "Don't tell this as kindness."

"I won't."

"You failed to escape today. That's enough for me."

"Your man was wounded."

"That will be entered separately. Your escape doesn't make it right that the sentries turned toward an argument over food."

\* \* \*

When Temujin went outside, Sube was having the tear at his temple stitched. The cap taken by the eagle lay beside him.

"Killing them would have ended the escape," Sube said.

"Kaya, or Storm?"

"I didn't say either."

Temujin opened the watch roster. The four soldiers who abandoned their posts during the quarrel over food would be heard separately, but there would be no collective punishment. The inner sentries would count the bonds and bandage clasps at every change of watch. Storm's perch would remain away from the tent where Kaya could see it.

"A prisoner without hope is easier to control," Sube said.

"Today she ran along the road we left open because she had hope," Temujin said. "If she loses it, we can't see which road she'll choose."

It was not mercy. Nor did it give Kaya a chance to escape. It merely built a cage different from Korgan's method, which treated fear as its only tool.

## Chapter 3 — The Wall of Light

*(TOGAN)*

When Togan reached the top of the hill, the northern horizon disappeared.

In its place stood a pale light rising from earth to sky. It was not stone. It moved like mist but did not disperse in the wind. When he fixed his gaze on one point, golden veins traveled within it, then suddenly went dark. The Wall stretched beyond sight to left and right, its upper edge lost in the whiteness of the sky.

Burkut drove his talons into Togan's shoulder guard. His wing had healed, yet he chose not to fly. He did not hide his head among his feathers, but refused to look at the light. He closed one eye and turned aside.

"We're here," Togan said.

Speaking the words weakened his knees. The road he had carried for a year, the wounds on his feet, and the faces of the people he had buried returned to his body all at once. He crouched and placed both hands on the earth. The gray crust broke beneath his palms. The soil below was cold.

The Wall was real.

The thing that might bring Melira back could be real too.

Or this was the last lie the road would tell him.

Togan took his notebook from his pack. He wrote down the hour he saw the glow, its direction, and Burkut's response. His handwriting trembled on the first line. It steadied on the second. He divided what he had seen into words so he would not mistake feeling for proof.

\* \* \*

The world grew silent as he approached the light. First the insects stopped. Then the wind. Togan began to hear his own breath, the strap of his sword, and the gray crust breaking beneath his boots. The silence was not complete. In the distance was a thin hum that seemed to come from inside his teeth.

He stopped twice in the first half league. He drank water, set Burkut on the ground, and walked thirty paces south to test whether he could turn back. There was no invisible barrier. His feet could move away. That detail kept his advance a choice of his own.

He found the abandoned camp within the silence. Three tent poles leaned crookedly. Petrified fat lay at the bottom of the cauldron; a broken water vessel stood beside the hearth. Most of the tent cloth had been stripped away and taken. The remaining knots seemed cut not in haste, but by hands stiffened with cold.

Togan searched the surrounding ground for bodies. He tested each pile of stones and found no grave marker. Nor could he make out old tracks leading north. The camp showed that people had left, not that they had died. It did not say where they had gone or how.

Beneath a scrap of cloth, he found a wooden eagle. One wing was broken. The hand that made the toy had carved the beak too long.

Togan ran his thumb over the broken wing. As a child, he had placed his wooden horse beside his bedding every night. One morning, when the horse's leg broke, he had cried as if all the clan could search and never find another. Mother Anya had repaired the leg with glue and kept Togan busy beside the hearth until it dried.

There were two notches in the wood beneath the toy. They might have been a date or only the owner's mark. Togan did not take it. He stood it upright beside the hearth and supported it with three small stones. He did not know who had owned the camp. Refusing to leave the toy facedown did not make it his.

On the far side of the camp, he found a supply pit half full. The dried roots inside had molded. Three pieces of salt remained sound at the bottom of a sack. Togan did not take them all. He took one and left two in the pit, then drew its location in his notebook. If anyone returned, they would not find every trace of themselves plundered.



When half a league remained to the Wall, the Dawn Gate came into view. Two tall wings rose in the light, a denser whiteness within white. His eyes ached as the marks on its surface changed position. When he tried to follow one, dizziness came, and the shape shifted elsewhere at the edge of his vision.

Burkut left his shoulder and perched on a stone behind him. Togan did not call him. He allowed the eagle to choose its own distance.

He walked toward the gate. His hands went numb in the first hundred paces. The air was not cold. The numbness traveled from his fingertips to his wrists. In the second hundred paces, the old wound in his shoulder burned. In the third, the metal fittings of his sword began to press cold against his skin.

"Melira."

The name was small inside the silence.

Togan spoke it again. Nothing changed at the gate. He reached his palm toward the light, but could not cross the final handspan. An unseen pressure

pushed his arm back. He leaned in with his shoulder. His feet furrowed the gray earth, but he still could not move his hand forward.

As the pressure grew, a metallic taste formed in his mouth. The veins on his left wrist reddened. Togan considered drawing his sword and extending it toward the gate. Then he chose not to. He would not ask his first question of a wall he did not understand with steel.

On his second attempt, he pressed with both hands. His vision turned white. For an instant he thought he saw the edge of the chair, though he was not asleep. When his knees gave way, he drew back and fell.

A stone rolled.

Togan half drew his sword and turned. A long-bearded man emerged between the rocks. Patches held his robe together, and he used the spear in his hand as a walking staff. He did not have the balance of someone who carried a weapon on his shoulder; he dragged his left leg.

"Don't exhaust your strength," the man said. "The gate doesn't open for those who push."

"Don't come closer."

The stranger stopped. He looked in turn at Togan's sword, Burkut, and the tracks he had left on the ground.

"You came alone," he said. "That isn't good."

"You're alone too."

"I didn't come alone." The man looked into the darkness to the left of the Wall. "I was left alone."

Togan did not take the sentence as an invitation to pity. "Who are you?"

"Perren. Once I read script in Metheris. Now I listen for when the stones hum."

"Do you know how to open the gate?"

The lines on Perren's face deepened. "If I did, I wouldn't have spent eleven years here."

"How many people have entered it?"

"None that I've seen. Many approached. Few returned."

"The people from the camp?"

Perren looked in the direction Togan had come. "It was there before me. I saw the last of them nine years ago. One night they walked north. In the morning, their tracks ended before the gate."

"Did they die?"

"I don't know. I won't sell you what I don't know as hope."

Togan did not lower his sword. The answer did not make him trust the stranger. It merely made the man worth hearing.

Perren turned and took two steps. "Don't remain in the open after nightfall. If you see the white room alone for the first time, you may not wake."

Togan's hand tightened on the hilt. "How do you know about the room?"

Perren looked back this time. "Sometimes the chair faces the gate, sometimes the wall. The hum begins inside your chest. That's something we should discuss beside a fire."

Togan had not told him about the dream. The five people he met on the road might have told Perren, but Perren said he had not seen them. That was not proof either.

"Walk ahead," Togan said. "Keep your hands where I can see them."

Perren reversed his spear and held the point down. "There's a second weapon at the shelter door. I'll give you that one too."

Burkut was watching the way Perren went. After a while, Togan followed. He left ten paces between them. The Dawn Gate did not remain behind him. Its light showed at the edge of every stone.

When they reached the shelter, Togan did not enter at once. He sent Burkut above the entrance, counted the tracks around it, and took the second knife Perren had mentioned. Then he sat across the fire where he could see the way out.

The Wall was real. Perren was real too. He did not have to understand what either meant on the same night.



## Chapter 4 — Before the Seven Lords

(KARIA)

When Karia was summoned to the Chamber of the Tide Council, the agenda paper bore only two words: order of succession.

Faelan waited outside the doors. He said Drennar and Calder had arrived in the same carriage, Vorlag had met with Valerius that morning, and two sealed chests had left Severin's manor.

"Did you count the votes?" Karia asked.

"Three certain, two against, two uncertain."

"Did you promise anything in my name?"

"No. I don't know what you've decided."

Neither did Karia. After his seizure, the King had canceled the debate over an heir. Now he was opening the same matter by his own will. It meant he either believed his death was close, or would not allow the Council to gather around his sickbed a second time.

"Stay inside," Faelan said.

"You weren't summoned."

"I can stand behind the door."

"Today they'll decide what to do about men who stand behind doors. Wait outside."

Faelan did not object. Karia entered the chamber alone.

\* \* \*

All seven seats were occupied.

Drennar was arranging the papers before him. Lady Maros twisted a handkerchief between both palms. Hallis and Calder broke off their conversation. Severin did not meet Karia's eye. Vorlag seemed at ease. Lord-Regent Bren was as silent as a shadow hung on the wall.

King Theodoric sat in the head chair. Illness had hollowed his cheeks. Before him stood a dark bottle prepared by the physicians. He had not touched it. The chief physician waited in the adjoining room. A small hourglass at the edge of the table measured out the allotted time.

"Let us begin," the King said.

The doors closed. The scribe raised his quill. First they read the Tide-Heir clause in the will of Valerius the Conqueror. The provision did not require blood kinship. The living ruler would nominate a candidate, the seven-member Council would approve by simple majority, and the chosen person would continue in their present duties until the king died. The heir would hold no power of rule, but would have access to the plans for transition.

Karia had read the text before. Heard aloud in the chamber, each sentence carried another weight.

"My illness taught me two things," Theodoric said. "My death may be nearer than my enemies expect. I have less time to choose my heir than I expected. My nominee is Lady Karia."

It was the first time Karia had heard it from the King's own mouth. Before she could draw even one preparatory breath, the side door opened. Sir Valerius emerged from the room where he had waited with the King's permission.

"I object." He struck a fist against his chest. "The Conqueror's blood runs in me."

Theodoric looked at the hourglass. "I gave you a place to state your objection. You are not a member of this chamber."

"The will may not demand blood, but the country does. An admiral cannot reach for the throne."

Karia stood. "I reached for nothing. This nomination was placed before me while I was doing my duty on a fleet deck."

"And you won't refuse it."

"No."

The answer silenced the whispers in the chamber. Karia knew refusing would not make her look humble. She would be fleeing responsibility while seeing the struggle that would begin when the throne fell empty.

She put her hands on the table. "I never sought the throne. I must think about who commands the navy if the King dies, who distributes the grain, and when seven houses will draw swords against one another. I will accept

that responsibility. If you won't approve me, show me the work I cannot do, not the blood I lack."

Drennar asked the first question. "What will your first order be when the crown falls vacant?"

"I will hold every current command in place for seventy-two hours. I will put the treasury under two signatures. I will open no new campaign before the Council reconvenes."

"What if famine begins?" Calder asked.

"The Harvest shares will be distributed before the crown receives its portion. Palace consumption moves to the end of the line."

Hallis said the navy was personally loyal to Karia and asked whether that threatened the other houses.

"The fleet takes its orders from existing maritime law," Karia said. "I will demand no oath of loyalty to me. If I ascend the throne, I will resign as admiral and transfer command to a successor approved by the Council."

With that answer, Karia had stripped herself of her strongest argument. Drennar made his first note on the paper before him.

Maros released her handkerchief. "You commanded a fleet. How many of the landed houses have you governed?"

"None."

"Then how do we know you won't govern the palace as if it were a navy?"

Karia could not answer at once. "You don't. Neither do I. If I treat every objection as disobedience, I will fail in this office."

This time, the chamber's silence did not favor her. Karia did not try to fill it.

Vorlag tapped one finger on the table. "A good admiral does not make a good sovereign."

"Correct," Karia said. "That is why I am not being crowned today. I am being chosen to close the void that follows the King's death."

Severin finally raised his head. "How will the person keeping me under audit demonstrate that she won't use my file for her own advantage once she is heir?"

Karia accepted that he had the right to ask. "A copy of the file is in the King's private archive. It will remain if I am removed from office. Being heir

neither enlarges nor diminishes the evidence in that file. If you wish, add a third Council member to the oversight of the investigation today."

Calder offered to take the role. Severin did not thank her, but neither did he continue the objection.

Lord-Regent Bren spoke for the first time. "What if Karia dies before the King?"

"The clause is invoked again," Theodoric said. "The crown is not bound to the dead."

"You are casting aside the Conqueror's line," Valerius said.

The King's voice hardened. "I am not casting aside his line because I refuse to read the Conqueror's will as you desire. You have finished speaking."

Valerius turned to Karia. "The road to the throne is long, Admiral. Some never reach the end."

Karia looked at the scribe. The man's pen waited over the paper.

"Should we enter that as part of your objection?" she said.

Valerius looked around him. He saw the trap laid by his own anger too late.

Theodoric signaled the guards. "Surrender your weapon and leave."

Valerius unfastened his sword belt and handed it over. Vorlag did not look at him as he walked to the door.

\* \* \*

The vote began when the hourglass was turned for the second time. Before casting a vote, each member would state the reason in one sentence.

Drennar supported the provision fixing military command in place for three days and voted yes. Hallis cited the promise that the navy would be bound to law. Calder found the limits placed on the treasury and the Severin oversight sufficient. After a long wait, Maros agreed on the condition that famine shares came before palace needs.

Vorlag said the state could not be entrusted to a war commander and voted against. Severin cited the conflict of interest created by the ongoing investigation and voted no. Bren said the measure had been rushed.

Four in favor, three against.

The scribe read the result. Theodoric sealed the Tide-Heir decree. Three further obligations were placed before Karia: the transition plan would be completed within sixty days, three candidates would be prepared for transfer of the admiralty, and no personal oath would be taken in the name of her position as heir.

Karia signed all three.

When the Council dispersed, Vorlag waited at the door. "Congratulations, Lady Karia. From now on, every mistake you make will count twice."

"Then you will watch twice as carefully."

Vorlag smiled and left.

When Faelan entered, he asked first about Valerius's threat. Karia gave him the scribe's copy.

"Watch his men tonight. No arrest order. Record only whom he meets."

"He said he would kill you."

"Saying it does not make him immediately guilty of the act. If he prepares, you gather evidence."

Faelan did not like the distinction. He accepted the order.

\* \* \*

Karia remained alone in the chamber with the King. At last, Theodoric picked up the dark bottle. His face tightened at the first swallow.

"I knew you would accept," he said.

"I didn't."

"Do you regret it now?"

Karia looked at the decree the scribe had left to dry on the table. Ink had bled in one corner. Four votes had not made her queen. They had merely given her the duty of keeping the country from coming apart if the King died.

"I have no time for regret, Your Majesty. I have sixty days."

Her first act was not to visit the throne room. She went down to the naval archive and asked for the service records of three admirals who could replace her.

## Section 10 — The Gate's Shadow

### Chapter 5 — The Hermit at the Gate

*(TOGAN)*

Perren's shelter was a low hollow carved into the rock. Layers of felt had been stretched across its entrance. Inside were two beds, a soot-blackened hearth, and hundreds of marks drawn on stone tablets.

Togan sat near the exit. Perren took the second knife he had promised from beside the hearth and held it out to him. Then he left his spear against the wall within Togan's reach. Burkut remained on the ledge above the entrance. He did not come inside.

The scratches on the shelter's right wall counted days; those on the left copied the gate's marks. In some places the same shape had been drawn and scraped out dozens of times. Perren had not erased his mistaken translations. He had used small symbols beside them to record why he abandoned each one.

As soon as Togan asked how he knew of the white room, Perren threw a dried root onto the fire.

"Because I've been seeing it for eleven years," he said. "Sometimes the chair faces the gate, sometimes the wall. I've never seen anyone sitting in it."

"I saw that dream hundreds of leagues from the Wall."

"Then the Wall called you before I arrived."

Togan did not like the words. He laid his sword across his knees. "Why did you come here?"

"To find Prince Aldric."

Perren explained that he had studied ancient languages in Metheris. When the King's son vanished on the northern road, he joined the final search party as its scribe. Thirty-two people had set out. Nineteen reached the Dead Lands, and seven saw the Wall. Perren did not know how many besides him had tried to return.

The first thirteen had turned back because of illness, fear, and the calculation of their provisions. Perren did not call them cowards. Of the next twelve, five walked away in the night and vanished after the dreams of the white room began. The remaining seven saw the Dawn Gate together.

"Why are you the only one left of the seven?" Togan asked.

"One turned back. Three walked to the gate and their tracks ended. Two blamed each other and went east. I was afraid."

Perren said it neither as shame nor virtue. He left it like the result of an account.

"Did you find Aldric?"

"We found his trail. A tent clasp, the dynasty's seal, and a single line of footprints leading north. The tracks ended in the middle of the earth."

"A body?"

"None."

That absence stirred Togan's hope. Melira had been buried. He knew what that meant. Yet in a place where a person could disappear without a trace, death might be less certain than he had known.

"Was the seal truly Aldric's?"

From a sealed box behind the hearth, Perren took a thin sheet of paper. It held a charcoal rubbing of the dynasty's seal and a drawing of where it had been found. The original seal had been sent to Metherris. Perren had kept the copy.

"It matched the King's archive seal," he said. "The palace armorer recognized the clasp too. It shows Aldric passed through that place. It does not prove the Wall took him, or that he lives."

Togan did not bring the paper closer to the fire. "My wife was buried."

Perren waited.

"Her name is Melira," Togan said. "I closed her grave with my own hands. I came here to bring her back."

"I've seen no record showing the Wall returned the dead."

"A record showing it doesn't?"

"I haven't seen that either." Perren returned the paper to the box. "Two absences don't make hope of each other."

Togan's hand hardened around the hilt. Perren did not draw back.

"I didn't ask you to lie to me," Togan said.

"Then you can stay here."

Perren picked up one of the stone tablets. He had drawn a narrow, tall obelisk on it. The marks along its body resembled those on the Dawn Gate.

"We found this east of the Wall. It trembles when the Current approaches. Its hum grows as the Crimson Host grows."

"What does it say?"

"Stone doesn't speak."

"You said you listened."

"Listening isn't understanding." Perren pointed to three symbols in the drawing. "I've translated these: outside, summons, weight. Change their order and the meaning changes too."

Perren cited a source for each of the three symbols. "Outside" appeared on an ancient boundary stone, "weight" on a pre-Harvest storehouse tablet. "Summons" was the least certain; in another text, the same shape might mean debt or echo.

"Then you don't know the sentence," Togan said.

"I know its pieces. I drew the conjunctions I don't know too."

Perren's work was less like reading a prophecy than counting the stones of a broken bridge. Togan understood that. It still did not carry him to the other side.

Togan looked toward the gate. "The Wall holds those inside."

"Everyone thinks so." Perren returned the stone tablet to its place. "I'm no longer certain. Sometimes the pressure doesn't come from the north. It flows from our side toward the Wall. Perhaps the Wall doesn't protect us from something inside. Perhaps it protects what is inside from us."

Togan stood. "I need a way to open the gate, not a riddle."

Perren did not flinch. "The clearest sentence I have is this: 'The key is not in the heart of the Current, but in the silence it leaves behind.' I read it in an old record of the Inheritors. In the middle of Crimson Week, the Wall falls silent for an instant. The gate changes then."

"How?"

"I stayed to see."

"For eleven years?"



Perren's gaze remained on the fire. "I arrived too late during the last Crimson Week."

Togan looked again at the scratches covering the shelter. Some sets of marks he had taken for symbols were counts of days. Perren had not lost time. He had accumulated it at the foot of the Wall.

"How long until this one?"

"Days. Perhaps a week."

Perren measured the approach of Crimson Week by three separate signs. The obelisk's hum had strengthened a little each day, the rings in the water bowl had tightened, and two of the seven marks in the Dawn Gate's bottom row had gone dark. He did not know what would happen when the last went out.

"Perhaps the gate will open," Togan said.

"Perhaps the Wall will weaken and what is inside will come out."

"What's inside?"

"I don't know. This time I'm saying the same answer too often as well."

Togan could not see beyond the Wall. He thought of Perren choosing this uncertainty again every morning for eleven years.

\* \* \*

As night deepened, Perren divided a soup made from dried roots between two bowls. Togan tasted it and grimaced.

"You've eaten this for eleven years?"

"I made it worse the first year."

Togan laughed despite himself. The sound felt foreign beneath the shelter's low roof.

When Burkut called twice at the entrance, Togan went outside. The eagle held a small rodent found among the stones in its talons. He ate the prey himself and left Togan only the tail. Perren laughed for the first time when he saw it.

"He isn't feeding you," he said.

"He's showing me his share."

"What's the difference?"

"You'll understand when you're hungry."

Togan inspected Perren's supply pit. There were enough roots for two people for a week, three bowls of water, and a little dried fungus. If Crimson Week was delayed, both would starve. He proposed retrieving the salt and usable vessels from the abandoned camp the next day. Perren said he had not touched the camp's belongings in years.

"Their owners didn't return," Togan said. "If they do, we'll write down where we put everything and what we took. Our starving to death won't protect their possessions."

Perren accepted the calculation.

"Did you never try to go back?" Togan asked.

"Three times. Each time I saw the white room. Each time I woke in the morning walking toward the Wall." Perren set down his spoon. "The fourth time, I didn't trust myself."

"Is that why you stayed, rather than Aldric?"

Perren did not answer for a long while. "The first year I stayed for Aldric. The second for the others who vanished. After that, it became harder to say why I remained. Sometimes what I call duty may be fear of going back."

Togan thought of the nights he had set out saying Melira's name. The difference might be smaller than he believed.

He spread his bedding near the door. He took the red cord from his pack, tied one end to his wrist, and fastened the other to an outcrop of rock.

Perren watched. "That cord won't stop you."

"If it breaks, I'll know I woke."

Perren showed him the cord on his own bed. It was tied not to his wrist but to his waist, its other end running through an iron ring in the ceiling to a stone weight. If he walked in the night, the stone would fall and the noise wake them both.

Togan joined the two arrangements. He passed the red cord through the same ring and set a metal bowl beneath the stone. Then he and Perren wrote three rules: anyone waking from the white-room dream would call the other by name; if there was no answer, he would pour water; if there was still no answer, he would pull the cord. The dagger remained the last resort, and they marked a place that would not be fatal.

Before closing his eyes, Togan made himself one promise: if the gate opened, he would enter. If it did not, he would not stay and share Perren's twelfth year.

He told Perren the promise as well. The old man wrote its date on the wall. He did not allow Togan's decision to remain only in his own memory.

## Chapter 6 — The Wreck Queen

*(ZALEENA)*

The Captains' Council gathered in an old Hegemony galleon grounded onshore. Its masts had been removed years ago, and its deck had become a market and meeting place. No captain owned it. That was why everyone could speak there.

Twenty captains came. Each represented at least one registered, seaworthy ship. The voting roll had been posted on the board before the meeting, with two hours allowed for objections. The captains of three ships held under debt could not vote; representatives of their crews observed the meeting.

Roric's chair was left empty.

Zaleena thought of the man alive in the lower cabin. If she revealed his identity, the election might be postponed. Roric might claim his old right or speak for his eight supporters. Hiding him made the greatest obstacle to her candidacy invisible.

Before the meeting, she had told Sorin to bring the sealed record. The surgeon had written that Roric's fever had fallen, but that he could not stand. Roric had placed his mark beneath a statement that he did not wish to reveal himself to the Council. Zaleena would not open the document until the election was over. The rightness of the decision could be debated. It would not be undocumented.

She stood across from the empty chair.

"Roric has not returned," she said. "No one has confirmed his death. The thirty-day period for the missing has not expired. But the interim order cannot be voted on again after every attack. First, we must decide on a permanent method of leadership."

Draven folded his arms across his chest. "The old way is clear. Those who want the throne fight for it."

"The last man chosen by the old way sailed eight ships against an unknown enemy."

"Would cowardice have been better?"

"Reconnaissance would have been better. So would giving the crew the right to withdraw when the objective changed."

Several captains on deck nodded. Roric's returning men had described the losses. It was no longer easy to cover defeat with nothing but heroism.

Kessel asked to speak. "A duel is quick. An election leaves division. But don't forget that a duel looks like unity only because the loser is dead and cannot object."

Draven looked at him. "Which side are you on?"

"First we vote on the method. Then I'll tell you."

Zaleena had the conditions of the two methods read aloud. In a duel, the candidates could fight with nonlethal weapons, but the loser would forfeit his entire command share. In an election, every registered captain would have one vote; if no candidate reached eleven, the bottom two would be eliminated. The chosen leader could be recalled to a new vote by the signatures of thirteen captains.

"Why put the recall clause in from the start?" one captain asked.

"Because leaving no way to remove a bad king except murder makes even a good king dependent on violence," Zaleena said.

The vote on the method was not secret. It took place on the two sides of the deck. Those who wanted a duel moved right; those who wanted an election moved left. The clerks counted them, then asked once more whether anyone had changed sides.

Eleven chose an election. Nine chose a duel.

Draven spat into the sea. "Then I'm a candidate."

"So am I," Zaleena said.

Kessel raised a hand from the back row. "Anyone else?"

Three more captains came forward.

Each candidate first disclosed his shares in ships, his debts, and the harbor contracts held by close relatives. One candidate owed an unpaid debt

to a Delta merchant. Another had overdue death shares to two crewmen's families. Neither withdrew. The information remained before the voters.

Zaleena did not reveal that Roric was alive. Instead, she disclosed her own conflict from another source: she had established the interim watch order and spent from the defense fund in recent weeks. The accounts would be opened to three captains on the day after the election.

"Will you open your lower cabin too?" Draven asked.

Zaleena's expression did not change. "Ship security areas may be inspected upon written cause. That includes captains' cabins."

The question might have been chance. Draven might have heard something. Zaleena left the boundary of her answer in the record.

No one won a majority in the first round. The two candidates with the fewest votes withdrew. One directed his two votes to Draven. The other endorsed no one.

Before the second round, Kessel had his own name removed.

"Why?" Zaleena asked.

"The people voting for me want me to rule the harbor in the old way. I've seen where the old way goes." Kessel turned to the captains who would cast the votes. "I support Zaleena. That doesn't mean I'll obey every order she gives."

Zaleena and Draven remained.

In his final speech, Draven described his circle of eight ships, thirty years of battle experience, and ties with the Delta ports. "A harbor lives not by records, but by who stands in front when the enemy reaches the gate."

Zaleena stood. "Records decide who will stand where when the enemy reaches the gate. One person's memory dies, flees, or remembers falsely. I'm not promising you victory. I'm telling you whose loss will not be hidden from whom."

"The final vote will be public," she said. "Everyone will know who chose this harbor's leader."

Draven raised an eyebrow. "To frighten people?"

"So they can stand behind their choice and cannot deny it later. Anyone may abstain. No share will be cut."

The names were called. The captains spoke their votes aloud. The first six split three to three. At the ninth name, Draven moved ahead. At the thirteenth, they were tied.

Zaleena's twelfth vote came from Kessel. Draven remained at eight.

Kessel walked before the empty chair. "Silent Zaleena has been elected Wreck Queen of Patchwork Harbor."

The applause began with Zaleena's crew. Then others joined. Draven did not applaud, but neither did he reach for his sword.

Zaleena did not sit in the empty chair.

"My first decision is this: every attack, lost ship, and ration of provisions will enter the record. My second: every captain's role in harbor defense will be decided before battle. Third: you won't have to kill me to change those decisions. Thirteen signatures will open a new vote."

A captain in the back row asked, "Did you vote for yourself?"

"Yes."

"Does the queen show no humility?"

"I wouldn't have stood if I didn't believe I could do this work. If I prove I can't, recall me."

The answer had more effect than the applause. Several captains looked at one another in surprise. Zaleena committed their faces to memory.

At last Draven stepped forward. "Eight votes were mine. I don't want you counting them."

"They weren't yours. They were given to you. Their names will remain in the minutes."

Draven bristled for a moment. Then he withdrew without bowing his head. He had suffered his first defeat without a sword.

\* \* \*

That night, Zaleena went down to the lower cabin of the *Sea Ghost*. Roric could sit on the bunk. Beneath the clean cloth on his face, the salve on his burns gave off its smell.

"How many votes?" he asked.

"Twelve."

"Draven?"

"Eight."

Roric breathed through his nose. "Don't humiliate him. If he fights against you, he'll find eight captains. If he fights beside you, he'll bring eight."

"The votes aren't his property."

"Did you tell him that?"

"Yes."

Roric smiled for the first time, then his face hardened as the wound pulled. "Did you sit on the throne?"

"No."

"You will."

"It's rotten."

"Every throne in this harbor is rotten."

Zaleena set the sealed record before him. "The election is over. Tomorrow we'll reconsider disclosing that you're alive to the Council. The secrecy has now served my candidacy. That means I won't decide alone."

Roric looked at the paper. "If you bring me out, they'll try to void the election."

"Perhaps. If I keep hiding you, their objection will be justified."

"Being queen is difficult work."

"It's my first day."

Sorin was waiting at the door when she left the cabin.

"My queen," he said, weighing the word.

"On deck, you'll call me Captain."

"And here?"

"Here too. Use the title in decision papers."

Upstairs, the first record book had been left on the table. Zaleena opened the cover, dated the page, and wrote the election result in her own hand: twelve to eight. Beneath it, she added that a three-person panel would review Roric's sealed record the next day.

A title became useful only when reduced to a number and a boundary.

## Chapter 7 — The Long Shadow

*(TEMUJIN)*

Orkhon entered Temujin's tent while he was working over a map.

"Korgan summons you," he said. "Alone."

Temujin set down the charcoal. "Batu isn't there?"

"No one is."

That meant the order concerned politics more than war.

On the way to the Great War Tent, he passed the Young Wolf fires. Twelve new men had joined the unit since Kaya's capture, while three old soldiers had returned to Korgan's main army. Their number was growing. Their loyalty was not holding the same shape. Korgan saw it too.

No one took Temujin's weapon at the tent. Two guards stood inside, their faces in the shadow of the leather curtains. Korgan stood waiting. On the map across the table, red stones surrounded the Eaglehold pass and three hundred blue stones had been laid in a single line before it.

"I hear your name too often, Young Wolf," Korgan said.

"News of victory is loud."

"Not only victory. Men are saying you could be Khan."

Temujin lifted his gaze from the map. Denying it would look afraid. Accepting it would be treason.

"Men say everything beside a fire."

"What do you say?"

"How to finish the work I'm given with fewer men."

Korgan knocked over one of the blue stones with his finger. "Eaglehold is the Sungurs' last secure pass. It will be taken before Crimson Week begins. You will command three hundred raiders."

Temujin looked at the pass's narrow throat. The map showed only the line of the road, not its elevation. Three hundred people would not fit there. Those in front would fall beneath arrows, and those behind would be unable to cross the bodies.

"Where will the main army be?"

"On the southern plain."

Beyond supporting distance.



"Siege bows? Climbing ropes?"

"From your own provisions."

"How long?"

"By the evening of the third day, the pass will be ours."

Temujin counted the stones. Only one hundred twenty of the three hundred soldiers knew his Young Wolf formations. The rest would be drawn from four different clans. Korgan was not giving him soldiers. He was also placing the cost of men who did not know one another on his shoulders.

"If I take the pass?"

"You will be honored before all the clans."

"If I don't?"

Korgan pushed the fallen stone from the table. It landed on the felt. "Then you will no longer need honor."

Temujin bent, picked up the stone, and returned it to its place. "The pass will be taken."

Korgan's mouth tightened. "If your loyalty is as strong as your ability, you are valuable to the steppes."

"What of the civilians inside when the pass falls?"

"Every Sungur is an enemy."

"Killing the unarmed will make the pass harder to hold."

"Are you making a decision?"

"I'm stating the result. Fleeing families will carry provisions into the mountains, and every child will learn the road for the next ambush. I'll break the armed resistance. I'll take those who surrender as prisoners. I won't pursue civilians."

Korgan did not look at the guards. "If the pass is in my hands, we can discuss your method afterward."

It was not approval. Nor was it an explicit prohibition. Temujin took the sentence as it stood.

\* \* \*

Orkhon was waiting outside. When he heard the order, he asked to see the map. They returned to Temujin's tent and opened the old hunters' drawings

of the pass, the trade caravans' notes, and the questions Kaya had refused to answer during interrogation.

"This is an execution," Orkhon said.

"Not if I succeed."

"If you succeed, he'll fear you more."

Temujin followed the faint charcoal line on the northern slope with his fingernail. "His fear isn't new. Others will merely see it."

"Don't make three hundred men pay for your account."

The warning stopped Temujin's hand. Korgan would measure him, but every raider who died in the pass would be placed on the same scale.

He summoned Sube and four unit leaders. He put the map before them and repeated Korgan's order word for word. He did not conceal that no support would come or that they had three days.

One commander proposed attacking the pass at night; another, maintaining a shield wall until the archers were exhausted. Sube pointed out the goat path to the north.

"Horses can't climb it. Fifty men can go on foot. We'll carry the ropes up."

"What if there's a watch at the end?" Temujin asked.

"I'll send two scouts ahead. If they don't return, we don't climb."

Temujin divided the plan into three parts. Sube would cross the northern slope with fifty men. At dawn, one hundred twenty Young Wolves would light two lines of fires at the main entrance to give the appearance of a large army. The rest would guard the horses and the line of retreat and would not enter the narrow throat until the pass opened.

"At the first rain of arrows, we'll sound retreat," he said.

One unit leader objected. "The men will think we're fleeing."

"So will the Sungurs. I want them to rise from cover for the second shot."

"What if our men really run?"

"We'll show them beforehand which stone marks the stopping point. Anyone who doesn't understand the order won't enter the first rank."

They rehearsed three times in empty ground over the course of the evening. On the first, the retreating riders collided. On the second, the horn could not be heard in the wind. On the third, two hornblowers played the

same signal at different rhythms. Temujin assigned one as reserve and had the single rhythm played again before everyone.

The plan looked complete on the map. On the ground it had broken three times. That was why they rehearsed a fourth.

\* \* \*

Before setting out, Temujin visited Kaya's tent.

"I'm going to Eaglehold," he said.

Kaya's back straightened. "How many?"

"Three hundred."

"Korgan is having you killed."

"Everyone has reached the same conclusion today."

"If Börü is there, he won't retreat."

Temujin recorded that. "The pass's weak point?"

Kaya laughed. "Are you asking me to sell my clan?"

"No. I wanted to see what you protected when I asked."

Kaya's gaze hardened. "Then you've seen it."

"Korgan counted every Sungur an enemy. I will target armed resistance.

If the pass opens, I won't pursue civilians."

"Why are you telling me?"

"So you know which promise to call me to account for if I return."

Kaya raised her bound hands. "And if you don't?"

"It will remain in Lyra's record."

"Records don't protect children."

"No. The men carrying out the order do. I told them too."

Kaya was silent for a while. She did not give him the route through the pass. Temujin did not ask again.

As he walked to the door, Kaya called after him.

"Young Wolf. If you meet Börü, tell him I'm alive."

Temujin inclined his head once. "I will."

This time, both knew he had given his word.

When the force departed that night, they did not carry the standard Korgan had given him. Each party kept its own token in a saddlebag.

Temujin intended to take the pass by the end of the third day. Before that, he had to turn three hundred people into a unit that understood the same order.

## Chapter 8 — Trial at the Foothills

*(TEMUJIN)*

The Eaglehold pass was as narrow as a spear-cut between two walls of rock. The Sungur archers were not visible at the entrance. The arrowheads betrayed their positions when they flashed for an instant in the morning light and disappeared.

If Temujin sent three hundred people into the pass, the first rank would fall before drawing swords.

He halted his units beyond sight on the first night. Cloth was tied around the horses' mouths and the fires were lit in a dry streambed. When Sube selected fifty men, he did not choose only Young Wolves. He asked for men from all four clans who were accustomed to goat paths. If the road opened, the victory must not look like the work of a single unit.

"There may be eagle sentries on the northern slope," Sube said.

"If the first bird takes flight, turn back. I won't launch the main attack."

"When Korgan asks about the third day?"

"I'll explain why the bird flew."

Sube knew that would not prevent punishment. They wound the ropes around their backs and set out before moonrise.

Temujin spent the night rehearsing with the remaining force. The first thirty riders would advance and fall back to a marked white stone when the rain of arrows began. None would flee behind the stone or turn again before the second horn. Reserves would draw away wounded horses while the main body spread across the embankments on both sides of the entrance.

Before dawn, a single stone sounded from the northern slope. Then silence. Sube's two scouts did not return. That did not mean the road was clear. Temujin did not launch the main attack until the time they had agreed upon elapsed.

When the sun touched the first tooth of rock, a red cloth appeared above. It opened and closed once. Sube was in position.

\* \* \*

Two rows of fires burned at the main entrance. The Sungurs were supposed to believe a larger force stood before them. At dawn, the first thirty riders advanced slowly. They held their shields high and rode close together to multiply the sound of hoofbeats.

The first rain of arrows unhorsed three. One horse was struck in the neck and fell, trapping the rider behind it against the stone wall. Temujin ordered the retreat horn sounded.

Five of the soldiers at the front passed the white stone. The reserve commander turned his horse across their path. The men remembered the order and stopped. The Sungurs rose from cover for their second shot.

On the northern crag, Sube's red cloth waved twice.

"Now."

The Azgut horns sounded at once. Sube's men descended behind the archers. Their first targets were not people, but the arrow baskets. They threw two baskets down the cliff and set fire to a third. When the Sungurs turned, the main road opened.

Temujin did not send two hundred twenty riders into the narrow throat. He directed the units to the stone embankments on either side of the entrance. The archers split to defend them. When the first group entered the pass, they dismounted; inside, saddles opened gaps between the shields.

Temujin felt the force of the first arrow strike his shield through his elbow. The second lodged in the leather rim. A raider to his right was hit in the throat and dropped to his knees. Temujin could not pull him away. Two people coming behind moved the body to the side of the road and closed the gap.

One voice restored the Sungurs' order as they retreated.

"Hold the left wall!"

Sky-Eye Börü fought on a stone step. The eagle plume on his head was broken, and blood had darkened the chest of his armor. Even so, the men beside him held their ground around him. Börü stood not before the exit, but at the head of the side path along which the wounded were being carried.

Temujin fought three men to reach him. He turned the first man's spear aside with his shield and struck the second's knee with the flat of his sword.

Instead of taking up the fallen spear, the third man stepped before Börü. Temujin wounded him in the shoulder; the man still refused to yield the way. Sube arrived from above and separated them with his shield.

"Börü!" Temujin shouted.

The Sungur Khan turned his sword toward him. "Where is Kaya?"

The first blow fell from above. Temujin caught it on his shield. His arm went numb to the wrist.

"Alive."

Börü swung again. "If you lie, I'll bury you here."

Temujin moved aside. The sword passed over his shoulder. "Bound, wounded, and angry. Storm lives too."

The eagle's name delayed Börü's stroke by half a breath. Temujin found the opening he sought, but struck the shoulder rather than the throat. Steel split the rings of mail. Börü went down on one knee.

Temujin turned the point of his sword toward the man's neck.

The battle continued around them. The burning arrow basket on the northern embankment had toppled and fire caught the dry felt. Two Sungur parties were withdrawing toward the western exit, and some Azgut soldiers were preparing to pursue them.

If Börü died, the Sungurs would either scatter or turn the pass into a grave. Alive, he could order their withdrawal. Korgan would prefer him dead.

That alone was not enough reason to leave him alive. Temujin saw the warriors carrying their wounded and the tents beyond the pass. He did not want to turn victory into a pursuit of them all.

"Withdraw your men," he said.

Börü held his wounded shoulder. "Why?"

"I have the pass. I don't need your body. Kaya asked me to tell you she lives."

Börü's face changed for the first time. "You saw her?"

"This morning."

"If Korgan touches her, the pass won't be enough."

"Tell him yourself. Take your men out today."

Börü looked at the Azguts behind Temujin, then called to the Sungurs around him. "Withdraw to the western exit. Take the wounded."

Temujin turned to his hornblower. "No pursuit. Hold the pass. Don't touch fleeing civilians."

An Azgut commander continued west as if he had not heard. Temujin caught his horse's reins.

"The Khan's order said every Sungur was an enemy," the man said.

"I command in this pass. You will not pursue anyone who lays down a weapon."

"I'll tell Korgan."

"Tell him with the number of dead."

The man pulled the reins and turned back.

For several paces, neither side turned its back on the other. When the last Sungur vanished around the western bend, the Azguts took the stone embankments. Temujin did not order the victory horn sounded at once. First he had the burning felt extinguished. If the fire reached the shelters, the pass would become unusable.

\* \* \*

The count ended that afternoon. Seventeen of Temujin's men were dead and forty-three wounded. The Sungurs had left eleven dead and seven gravely wounded whom they could not carry. Temujin entered those seven as prisoners and had them placed in the same healer's tent.

One of the units began looting the Sungur provision tents. Temujin had all goods carried to a common counting ground. Three days' provisions needed to hold the pass were set aside. The rest were sealed until their owners could be identified.

Sube handed him the list of dead. "You could have killed Börü."

"I would have won the pass and made an enemy of every mountain."

"Korgan will be angry."

"Korgan needed the pass. He has it."

Temujin did not send the messenger of victory until the seventeen names of the dead had been written. The message also said Börü had withdrawn wounded, the civilians had not been pursued, and seven Sungur prisoners were receiving treatment. Temujin could not stop Korgan from reading only

the part he wanted. He would not remove the part he did not want from the paper.

After establishing the pass's defenses, Temujin set out on the return road. He left fifty of the three hundred people on the embankments and thirty with the wounded. As the rest descended the mountain, they began singing a victory song. Temujin did not forbid it. At the first stopping place, he had the names of the seventeen dead read aloud. The song stopped after the second.

\* \* \*

When he reached the Great Camp, he went first to Kaya's tent. Seeing the dried blood on him, Kaya tried to stand.

"Börü lives," Temujin said. "He was wounded in the shoulder. He took his men west. I gave him your message."

Kaya sank back where she had been sitting. She closed her eyes and took one breath.

"I won't thank you."

"I didn't ask."

"Why did you let him go?"

"A living Khan can order a retreat. I didn't want to fill the pass with bodies. Korgan wanting him dead also made my decision easier."

Kaya opened her eyes. "I wouldn't have believed you if you'd left out the last part."

Temujin turned toward the door.

"How many Sungurs died?" Kaya asked.

"We counted eleven in the field. We have seven wounded. I don't know how many they carried away."

"Yours?"

"Seventeen."

Kaya did not set one number against the other. She lowered her head. When Temujin left the tent, Korgan's messenger was waiting. The Khan had scheduled the victory ceremony for sunset.

Within a few hours, Korgan had learned both that the pass had been taken and that Börü lived. Temujin could guess which news had angered him



more. Before going to the ceremony, he set aside the provision shares for seventeen families.

## Section 11 — Threshold of Crimson Week

### Chapter 9 — The Knife in the Shadows

*(KARIA)*

Faelan laid the hunting invitation on Karia's desk.

Sir Valerius's seal marked the heavy paper. It said that the number of deer beyond the city had grown and that it would be fitting for the Tide-Heir to see for herself the herd threatening the people's fields.

"He must have had help making an invitation this poor," Karia said.

Faelan did not laugh. He produced a second paper. It was a charcoal sketch of the same road. A narrow bridge was marked, with the amount of payment for four men written beside it.

"One of Valerius's former marines brought this," he said. "On the day of the hunt, they're to remove the bridge rail. Your horse will fall into the water. It will be counted as the Current's work."

"Why did the man come?"

"He may think his share of the payment is too small. He may be afraid. He also says he likes you. At least two of the three reasons are lies."

Faelan opened the informant's first statement. It recorded the meeting place and time and descriptions of two of the four attackers. The man had not seen Valerius give the order. He had received the money from Valerius's man-at-arms.

Karia placed the two papers side by side. The handwriting differed. Only the invitation bore a seal.

"This isn't enough to accuse Valerius."

"I can remove him without accusing him."

Karia raised her head.

"Hunting accidents don't happen to only one person," Faelan said. "He could fall from the bridge too."

"No."

"One day that answer will kill you."

"Not today. Today it will find me four good guards and a broken bridge."

Faelan did not leave. "If we put you in the carriage and send Calder in your cloak, we make her the target."

"We'll tell her the plan. If she doesn't consent, we'll find another way."

"She will."

"That isn't a reason not to ask."

When Calder arrived, she read first the invitation, then the sketch. She agreed to wear Karia's cloak. She chose when she would leave the armored carriage and where the guards would stand. Karia would remain in the closed carriage two hundred paces behind the bridge. The trap would not make an unwitting lure of someone else.

\* \* \*

Karia announced that she had accepted the invitation. On the morning of the hunt, she left the palace on her own horse, then transferred to the closed carriage after one hundred paces. Wearing armor, Calder took Karia's cloak on her shoulders and rode at the front of the party.

Faelan's men had hidden beneath the bridge during the night. Two guards dressed as woodcutters waited beyond it, with a healer in the streambed. Karia wanted no one killed during the capture. Faelan had not promised it. He had only built his plan accordingly.

The four attackers arrived near midday. They were caught while loosening the rails. One drew his sword and attacked the guard dressed as a woodcutter. The guard retreated. When Faelan's men emerged from both sides, the attacker jumped into the stream. He slipped in the shallow water, fell on a rock, and broke his leg. The other three surrendered without drawing swords.

They carried silver from the same mint and a warehouse chit from Valerius's house. The coins were placed in separate purses and sealed with the names of the guards who found them.

Karia did not bring the hunting party to the bridge. Calder removed the cloak, saw the four men with their faces uncovered, and signed the recorded

time of capture. It would be harder to claim afterward that Karia's men had planted them.

The fleeing man's leg was splinted. His statement was taken after the healer eased his pain. Karia did not use his injury as pressure to make him speak.

The youngest attacker said the money had come from Valerius's man-at-arms. One remained silent. Another maintained that they had been hired only to remove the railing. The statements were sealed separately.

The man-at-arms was taken that night. The payment list found in his room was not conclusive by itself. Alongside the warehouse chit, it showed that the money had come from the house.

Faelan closed the file and held it out to Karia. "Now it's enough."

"Enough for the King."

"For the Council too."

"If the Council sees this, Valerius's entire house will stand trial. I won't hang his crime around the necks of hundreds of people."

Faelan raised an eyebrow. "Mercy?"

"Refusal of collective punishment. Besides, an open trial would last months. Vorlag would turn it into a dynastic war. We will offer Valerius confession and exile. If he refuses, he goes before the Council."

"He'll try again from outside."

"That's why we'll impose border surveillance and a declaration of assets. We won't say we've ended the threat."

\* \* \*

King Theodoric read the file in bed. His left hand was trembling when he reached the final page.

"I could have him hanged," he said.

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"You don't want that."

"A trial would last months. During Crimson Week, we would have to protect four attackers, the man-at-arms, and the witnesses. Exile puts the crime on record and removes the threat from the city. If he refuses, a court is convened."

The King turned the ring his son had left behind. "Would you say the same if he had tried to kill me?"

"No."

Theodoric looked at Karia for the first time. "Why?"

"Because then the right to pass judgment would not be mine."

"You think it is yours because he tried to kill you?"

Karia stopped at the question. "No. That is why I'm asking you for the order. The file contains records of the capture and payments, not my interpretation."

Theodoric asked for paper. He set the terms of exile himself. Valerius would surrender his rank, provide a list of his armed retainers in the Hegemony, declare where he would live beyond the border, and not return without the King's written permission. His family and the workers of his house would not face collective punishment. The four attackers would stand separate trial, and Valerius's exile would not erase their choices.

The King wrote the order with his own hand and sealed it.

\* \* \*

Valerius was brought to Karia's study that evening. The King's judge, Faelan, and a palace scribe were in the room. On the table lay the payment list, warehouse chit, and sealed order.

"Your man-at-arms confessed," Karia said. "All four men are in our custody."

Valerius touched none of the papers. "What do you want?"

"You will surrender your rank. You will leave Methesis before dawn. You will provide a list of your armed circle and declare where you intend to settle. You will not return to Hegemony territory without the King's permission."

"And if I refuse?"

"You stand trial before the Council. The informant, the four attackers, your man-at-arms, and Calder will testify."

"You don't have the courage to kill me."

Karia pushed the exile order toward him. "Killing you would be easy. You will live and carry the result of your choice."

Valerius read the paper without breaking the seal. The anger on his face gave way to calculation. Outside, he would have friends, money, and time to return. Karia saw him considering it.

"This isn't forgiveness," she said. "I'll keep men at the border. If you return, the trial will no longer be an option."

Valerius did not take the pen. "I choose trial."

Karia drew back the paper. "Then you remain under guard tonight. You go before the Council in the morning."

Valerius looked back for the first time as he was taken away. Karia did not try to change his mind.

An hour before dawn, Valerius sent for the judge. This time he read the exile order twice, wrote the list of his armed circle in his own hand, and signed beneath the confession. Then he asked about his man-at-arms.

"I accepted. Release him."

"His decision is not yours to make. Carrying out your order doesn't erase his own choice."

For the first time, Valerius seemed to hear that loyalty did not erase complicity.

At the door, he turned to Karia one last time. "The throne isn't yours."

"Nor is that the crime we discussed tonight."

\* \* \*

At dawn, the report came that he had passed through the city gate. Two of Faelan's watchers would follow him along the border. Karia had the exile notice state the scope of the crime, the nature of the evidence, and the fact that no collective punishment had been imposed on his family. She did not conceal Valerius's name. The names of the four attackers would not be released until their trial ended.

One copy of the file went into the King's safe and another into Karia's chest. She had preserved her principles. She had not ended the threat, only moved it beyond the walls. She did not claim that a trap completed without bloodshed would prevent the next knife.

## Chapter 10 — The Harbor's Trial

(ZALEENA)

On the fifth night after her election as Wreck Queen, the outer-pier bell struck three times.

Not fire. Not storm. Three strikes meant attack from the water.

Zaleena had not been asleep. She was discussing the final assignments in the first defense roster with Sorin. When the bell sounded, she left the paper on the table and went on deck. The orders were posted on the signal board.

The Rust Tide was already climbing.

Armored backs appeared between the pilings, long fingers gripping the wet wood. The first sentry drove his spear into a creature's chest. The point slid over its shell. The creature seized the spear in both hands and tried to pull the man into the water. A crewman beside him cut the shaft, and the sentry fell backward.

"Ring every bell," Zaleena said. "Clear the outer piers. Cut the rope bridges."

Sorin ran up beside her. "Fire?"

"Test it above the water first. Don't pour the oil barrels into the sea. Burn cloth."

The braziers she had ordered prepared after Roric's expedition were lit on three piers. The crews ignited hooks wrapped in tarred cloth and threw them before the creatures. When the first Rust Tide touched the fire, it made a shrill sound and retreated. Those behind it stopped, but did not return to the water.

"The fire works!" a crewman shouted.

"It frightens them. It doesn't kill them," Zaleena said. "Don't trap them against it. Leave the water open for retreat."

Six people remained on the far side of the second pier before its rope bridge could be cut. Finn's trial boat was lowered into the shallows. Its rudder still locked during hard turns after the latest repair. Finn stood in the stern and steered the rowers by shifting weight.

"Take the six and come back," Zaleena said. "Don't chase the creatures."

Finn took five people on the first crossing. The sixth sentry refused to leave his wounded companion. The boat turned a second time. When a creature caught the side, Finn struck its fingers with an axe. The shell did not break, but the hand released. Both men were carried to the inner line.

Zaleena looked toward the third pier. Draven's line was close to breaking. The ships belonging to captains who had voted against her were on the outside. The creatures' largest mass was bearing down there as well.

She ordered the *Sea Ghost's* head rope cut. When the Current turned the ship sideways, the two small guns along the broadside faced directly into the mouth of the pier.

"Load grapeshot."

The gunner bent over the deck. "Our people are there too."

"Fire when Draven raises the red lantern. One lantern means retreat; two mean the line is clear. Don't touch the fuse until you see the second."

Zaleena sent a messenger along the inner ropes. The outer bridge had been cut, so the boy crossed on a maintenance line connecting the warehouse roofs. When a creature climbed the wall, Kessel's sentries at the armory poured sand from above, making the surface slick.

Draven did not withdraw his men at once when the order reached him. The captain on his right insisted that abandoning the pier would surrender their ships to the creatures. Draven hesitated for two breaths. Then he seized the captain by the collar and shoved him behind the warehouse wall.

The red lantern swung once.

The gunner held the fuse ready. The creatures crowded into the emptying line. Draven's last three men reached the wall.

The lantern rose a second time.

Both guns fired together. Iron fragments broke the shells in the first rank. One creature's back opened, releasing dark water and rust-colored fibers instead of blood. When those behind caught on the burning hooks, the pressure on the pier broke.

Draven counterattacked with his crew. He seized a fallen sailor by the back and dragged him to safety, then made way for the fire team. Zaleena did not allow him to leap into the sea after the creatures. She sounded the return to the inner line.



\* \* \*

No one rang the victory bell when the first attack withdrew. Armored backs still circled beyond the pilings. The creatures gathered outside the reach of the fire and scraped their shells against one another.

Sorin believed the second wave would come from the south. Kessel found fresh scratches on the armory wall; a small group had tried to climb from behind during the first attack. Zaleena sent the reserve brazier to the armory, not south.

The second wave struck there after midnight. This time the creatures did not enter the fire hooks directly. They advanced underwater and emerged among the pilings. Kessel had the powder barrels carried upstairs and blocked the lower door with sacks of salt.

Cannon fire in the narrow space might ignite the armory. Zaleena had fishing nets tied to the ends of long poles and tangled the creatures' arms among the pilings. Finn's crew pushed bowls of burning resin beneath those that became trapped. The fire did not pierce the shells. It dried the fibers and slowed their movements.

When one crewman dropped his pole, a creature reached the wall. Zaleena brought her axe down at the joint. The first blow slid. The second entered between two rings of shell. When the creature pulled back its arm, the axe left Zaleena's hands. Sorin caught her by the belt and pulled her backward.

"Weren't queens supposed to stay out of the front line?" he shouted.

"You were supposed to call me Captain."

Kessel's men poured hot sand from the upper floor. The creature released the wall. Zaleena could not recover her axe.

The fighting continued on three separate lines until dawn. Each time the Rust Tide withdrew, it carried its dead into the water. They saw two uninjured creatures drag a wounded one away by the arms. Whether leaving no bodies onshore was instinct or an order, no one knew.

When daylight touched the first piling, the armored backs withdrew into open water. The sentries wanted to shoot arrows after them. Zaleena refused. The arrows could not penetrate the armor and would only deplete their ammunition.

\* \* \*

The damage count began at sunrise.

Seven sailors were dead and nineteen wounded. Two piers were unusable. The ground floor of a provision storehouse had flooded, and the armory's outer wall was cracked. Finn's boat had taken water twice but had not sunk. The names of the seven people he saved were written before the vessel's damage report.

Zaleena would not let the dead be read out as a number alone. Each captain gave the name of his own loss. The seventh belonged to Draven's crew. His hand whitened at the edge of the table as he spoke it.

"One breath later with the order to fire and you would have cut down my men," he said after the count.

"And if you'd raised the lantern one breath later?"

Draven nodded. "I didn't think you would trust me."

"I didn't. I trusted that you understood the signal I gave, and you trusted the gunner to wait for two lanterns."

"What's the difference?"

"Tomorrow, we can hate each other and still use the same signal."

Draven looked at the record book. "Did you write the seven dead?"

"By name. The wounded and the lost axe too."

"Roric counted only the ships."

"I'll count the ships too. People first."

Draven extended his right hand. "Bring the defense order to the Council. I can't promise my eight votes. I can give my own."

Zaleena took his hand. It was not loyalty. It was the first sound plank. She could put her weight on it.

At the afternoon review, Finn reported the rudder defect, Kessel the uninspected wall, and Draven the delayed order. Zaleena added that when she entered the line with an axe, she lost sight of the rest of the harbor.

\* \* \*

She went out to the outer pilings in a small boat to examine the retreat marks. She lifted one piece of shell with a cloth. Thin red fibers like weed

moved beneath it. Placed in a jar, the fibers gathered on one side as if trying to move away from the water.

"The Delta will have a name for this," Sorin said.

"A name isn't enough. We need to know why they came ashore now, why they drew back from fire, and why they carried their dead away."

"Will they tell us?"

Zaleena sealed the jar. "They'll ask the price."

When she returned to the harbor, she wrote the letter to the Delta. She did not ask for aid. In exchange for the specimen, the time of attack, and the creatures' reaction to fire, she requested their records. In the last line, she named the neutral Razor Reefs as the meeting place.

The first external negotiation under her new order began not with a proclamation of victory, but with seven deaths, three mistakes, and a sealed jar.

## Chapter 11 — On the Threshold of Crimson Week

*(CLOSING: TOGAN / TEMUJIN / KARLA / ZALEENA)*

### The Wall of Light

Perren placed a bowl of water before the obelisk. The rings on its surface had been broad and slow that morning. By evening, they had drawn together, dividing the water with fine lines.

"Do you hear the hum?" he asked.

Togan put his ear to the stone. At first he heard his own blood. Then a single sound rose from the depths and set his teeth aching. It did not stop, and the intervals were contracting.

"I hear it."

Perren showed him the last seven days on the scratched wall. Each day, the interval between hums had shortened a little. Six of the seven marks along the Dawn Gate's bottom row were dark. The last trembled like a thin vein.

"It may be tonight," he said.

"The gate will open?"

"I don't know."

Togan no longer grew angry at the answer. He checked the safety arrangement before the shelter for the third time. The red cord at his waist passed through a ring in the rock opposite the gate; Perren held the other end. They had hung two metal bowls from its middle. If Togan walked in the night, they would strike each other and sound.

Burkut waited on the rock above the shelter. Togan did not tie the eagle to the cord. If he chose to fly when the Wall's hum intensified, Togan would not keep him here.

"If I see the white room, wake me," he said.

"I'll call your name. Then water. Then the cord."

Togan drew his dagger and held it out to Perren. "If none of those work."

Perren did not take it. "I don't know where to strike."

Togan pointed to the outside of his own thigh. With charcoal he marked the place away from the artery and knee. "Here."

"I could kill you."

"If I walk to the gate, I could kill myself. At least this way you won't choose it. You'll be following the rule."

Perren took the dagger and fastened it to his belt in its sheath.

They did not go out in the open to the Dawn Gate. They watched the light from the shelter mouth. Togan recorded the intervals between hums in his notebook. Every ten beats, Perren called out the number of rings in the water bowl.

Near midnight, Togan's left wrist grew warm. He had not touched the Wall. The old wound shone with a red line beneath the skin. Perren saw it and recorded the time.

"Does it hurt?"

"It burns."

"Let's move back."

Togan stood, but did not advance toward the gate. He took two steps into the shelter. The light at his wrist did not fade. Distance alone, then, did not end the effect.

The stone's hum stopped at once.

The silence was unlike those before it. Togan could not hear even his own breath. Every ring in the water bowl vanished at the same instant. The last mark on the Dawn Gate went dark.

The red cord drew tight.

Though Togan was not pulling, it stretched toward the gate. Perren seized it in both hands and braced his heels against the rock.

"Togan!"

Togan heard his name. The white room did not open before his eyes. Behind the light appeared the shadow of a chair. This time there was not a dark stain on the seat, but a hand.

"I'm here," he said.

He could not hear his own voice. Perren saw his lips and did not release the cord.

A dark line as thin as a strand of hair formed between the two wings of the Dawn Gate.

### **The Great Camp**

The black sable coat gifted by Korgan arrived at Temujin's tent before sunset. The messenger said the Young Wolf would be honored before all the clans.

The coat's clasp was gold. Korgan's black bison mark was worked into its lining. If Temujin wore it, he would carry the victory in the Khan's gift. If he refused it, everyone would see him defy Korgan.

Temujin had three merchants value it separately. Even the lowest price would provide two months' meat for the families of the seventeen men who died at Eaglehold.

"Selling it will be taken as an insult," Orkhon said.

"Will wearing it feed the families?"

"No. But you can wear it tonight and sell it tomorrow."

Temujin chose that path. He wore the coat on his shoulders until the ceremony and entered the decision to sell it in the ledger before the ceremony began. The names of the seventeen people who died at Eaglehold lay on the table.

The clan standards were raised around Korgan's great fire. The drums struck three times when Temujin was called. The Khan proclaimed that the

pass had been taken and the Young Wolf had served the steppes. He did not say that Börü had been allowed to live.

He fastened the coat's golden clasp with his own hand.

"Tell them of your victory," he said.

Temujin turned to the crowd. First he said the pass had been taken, the embankments held before the third day ended, and the trade road opened. Then he unfolded the list in his hand.

"Seventeen men died in this victory."

He read the first name. The drummer had raised his mallet to strike again; Korgan did not lower his hand. Temujin read the second, third, and fourth names. The cries of victory from the crowd fell silent.

At the seventh name, a woman tried to come forward. The guards stopped her. Temujin stopped reading and asked which name she had come for. Her son was twelfth. He did not skip to the twelfth name. He continued from the eighth.

When all seventeen names had been read, he announced that the coat would be sold the next day and its price entered into the families' shares.

Korgan turned his one eye on him. "You're selling my gift?"

"Tonight I wear it with your honor. Tomorrow I turn it into the cost of victory."

The crowd waited for Korgan's answer. If the Khan wanted his gift returned, he would have to demand it before seventeen families.

"Sell it for a higher price," Korgan said.

The permission was not friendship. Korgan had kept his anger outside the ceremony. Temujin bowed his head.

Kaya heard the rhythm of the drums and the names from the tent where she was held bound. Storm moved on its perch at every name. Kaya knew Börü lived. She did not know the names of her own dead. That would be the first question Temujin could not keep from her when the ceremony ended.

### **Metheris**

Karia sealed the report stating that Valerius had left through the city gate, then returned to the provision schedule before her.

The grain set aside for Crimson Week was enough for the three palace feasts requested, but not for three days' rations in the lower districts. The

palace officer said the feasts would celebrate both the proclamation of the Tide-Heir and the beginning of the Harvest.

"If we celebrate neither, the people will see weakness," he said.

Karia took the tally stick. One hundred forty sacks of flour, thirty barrels of wine, and four days' kitchen charcoal had been set aside for the three feasts. The same flour could keep eleven ovens operating in the lower districts.

She struck out the palace entry.

"Cancel the feasts."

The officer hesitated. "It is tradition, my lady."

"So is hunger. Let us change one."

"Has the King approved?"

Karia accepted that the question was justified. She was Tide-Heir. While the King lived, she could not control the treasury alone. She took the order to Theodoric. The King read the schedule and assigned half the wine share to the hospital and the ships on watch. He approved the cancellation of the feasts under his own seal.

"They'll tell it as your decision," he said.

"I proposed it. The authority was yours. We'll announce both."

The amount to be distributed to the ovens was recorded that same day. Karia had her own house's kitchen account posted beside the others.

She doubled the watch at the North Beacon. She ordered the harbor chain closed and opened once; two rusted links were replaced. Then she did not remove the lone guard at the foot of the stairs to the King's chamber. She added a second. Valerius was gone. Vorlag remained in the palace.

At sunset, the sea began to recede faster than expected. The harbor bell announced the unnatural tide. Boats at the quay leaned on their lines, and the weed line fell below the stone wall.

When Karia climbed the North Beacon, the Crimson Host appeared brighter than the stars on the horizon. The chief physician came running. Theodoric's pulse had quickened. At the same moment, the Harvest watch reported the first masses of crimson weed washing ashore.

Karia did not combine the two pieces of news in a single order. The physician went to the King, the beacon officer to the coastal records. Karia descended to the harbor defense room.

### **Patchwork Harbor**

Before midnight, the water withdrew hundreds of paces. The ships settled into mud. Red fibers from the Rust Tide remained among the pilings. Some moved even without water.

Zaleena assigned the captains their detachments: Draven would command the outer piers, Kessel the armory, Sorin the messenger boats, and Finn the shallow-water rescue parties. Twenty copies of the orders were distributed.

Two members of the Council said that since the sea had receded, the creatures could not return. Zaleena reminded them that the Rust Tide had moved beneath the water during the last attack.

"They may be under the mud too. No one goes down onto the outer flats."

A band of looters ran toward the metal scraps left by the receding water. Finn's men stopped them at the roped boundary. For the first time on a Wreck night, what washed ashore was not counted ownerless. The ground had been declared a defense zone.

Roric sat at the door of the lower cabin. The three-person panel had postponed revealing the secret until the end of Crimson Week. Zaleena's first decision to hide him remained in the sealed record all the same.

"When the water draws back this far, it returns hard," Roric said. "Don't leave the ships on a single line."

Zaleena added a second stern line to the deck order. She entered the source of the suggestion in the sealed record.

"The letter to the Delta?" Sorin asked.

"On its way."

"What if they attack before the answer comes?"

"We face them with what we have."

The sample of crimson fibers remained inside its sealed jar. Zaleena had it moved from the armory to the stone room. She left a clerk beside it to observe how the fibers reacted when the tide returned. He was forbidden to open the door.



From the unseen water in the distance came a sound like thousands of shells scraping against one another. The sentries lit the braziers. This time none mistook fire for a sign of victory.

The Crimson Host illuminated not the sky, but the wet mud where the water had withdrawn. Before the first wave returned, a dark line had opened in the Dawn Gate, seventeen names had been read at the Great Camp, and Metherris's feast flour had been sent to the ovens.

The night turned crimson before it became day.

Crimson Week had begun.

## 4. Part — Crimson Week

\* \* \*

## Section 12 — First Tide

### Chapter 1 — First Tide

*(TOGAN: Crimson Week, Day One)*

When Togan woke, the cord around his waist was taut.

His feet were outside the shelter. His right hand was still tied to the ring in the rock. His left reached toward the Dawn Gate, fingertips furrowing the earth.

Perren was sitting on the cord with both feet braced against the wall.

"How long was I walking?" Togan asked.

"About three breaths. It felt like three years."

Togan rose onto his knees. The image of the white room remained before his eyes. This time the chair had not been empty. The sitter's face was hidden behind the light; he had seen only the shoulders.

Before untying the cord, Perren made Togan name five people. Kaya, Börü, Melira, Burkut, and Perren. After the fifth name, he asked the season of his birth, his last meal, and which hand held his knife. Togan answered all of them. Only when he tried to form Kaya's face in his mind did the area around her eyes dissolve. After several breaths, the image settled into place.

"You won't record that either?"

"I'll record that in particular." Perren made two short scratches at the corner of the stone tablet. "When the dream makes you walk, the cord stops your body. We don't know what will stop your mind."

Togan shook the dirt from between his fingers. "Names."

"Perhaps."

"If a person wants to return somewhere, he first remembers where he came from."

Perren wrote *five names* on the tablet and tied the cord around his own waist as well. One would keep watch while the other slept. At a wrong answer, both would move away from the gate.

When they went outside, the One Eye hung crimson on the horizon. None of the stars were visible. The Wall's light strengthened and faded at regular intervals, each flare turning the gray earth bone white for an instant.

"First Tide," Perren said.

The bowl before the obelisk was empty. During the night, the water had traveled toward the stone's edge and climbed its northern face in a thin line.

Togan touched the wetness with one finger. Instead of flowing down, the water climbed along his nail.

"Have you seen this before?"

"I wasn't here during the Last Current." Perren made a mark on his stone tablet. "Everything we see this time is a first."

\* \* \*

At noon, the water withdrew from the distant northern shore. The seabed stood exposed for leagues. Pale veins of weed glowed among the black rocks, some curling as if trying to reach land.

Burkut launched from Togan's arm. He traced a half circle toward the shore and returned at once. When he landed, he ruffled his feathers.

Togan smelled the air. Beneath the salt lay the odors of iron and wet earth. A similar smell had come before the crimson floods on the steppes.

"Did the Wall weaken today?"

Perren looked at the shadows of the bronze rods. "No. It only became irregular. We wait until the third day."

"What do we do besides wait before the gate?"

"Stay alive."

The instant the words ended, something moved on the exposed seabed. A four-legged, weed-covered creature rose from the mud. It took two steps toward the light, then collapsed again as smoke rose from its skin.

Perren made a new mark. His hand was trembling.

When the creature rose a second time, it turned not north but toward the shelter. One foreleg was shorter than the others. With every step it sank into the mud, then a fresh mass of weed emerged from within its body and completed the missing part.

Togan took up his bow.

"An arrow won't work," Perren said.

"If we let it approach, we'll learn."

He sent the first arrow into the dark knot he took for the creature's head. The arrow entered its body and opened a thin wound behind it. Inside were not bones, but pieces of chain washed ashore. A metallic taste formed in Togan's teeth. Iron touched by the Current did not remain silent like healthy iron. It scratched at the inside of his jaw.

"There's chain inside it," he said. "Left side. High."

Perren emptied his oil jar onto a ball of cloth. Togan tied the cloth to the point of his second arrow, lit it, and shot into the wound where the chain lay. The flame did not burn the outer weed. It entered and caught in the dry fibers around the metal. The creature collapsed after three steps. This time it did not rise.

At sunset, Perren used a long hook to pull a rusted link from the body. Three symbols like those on the Dawn Gate marked its surface. Standing near it was enough to make Togan's head ache.

"Did the Wall cast it out?" he asked.

"Or something inside carried it as far as the gate." Perren trapped the link beneath a stone bowl. "Until the third day, we won't bind any finding to a single explanation."

Togan looked at the dead mass's trail stretching toward shore. "Then write two explanations."

"What's the second?"

"It found us."

\* \* \*

The same dream took them both that night.

Togan stood behind the chair in the white room. Perren stood beside the door. They could see one another but made no sound. The person in the chair turned toward Togan.

He heard three heavy knocks inside his chest.

When he woke, Perren was sitting up too. Blood ran from his nose.

"You were there too," Togan said.

"You were beside the door."

"No. I was behind the chair."

They fell silent. They had seen the same room, but the room had not placed them in the same position.

Togan pressed his palm to his chest. When the Wall brightened, his heart struck with it. When the light faded, it missed a beat.

Perren took Togan's wrist and counted his pulse, then withdrew his hand.

"I won't put that in the record," he said.

"Why?"

"Because I want to understand what it is first."

When Togan tried to stand, his right leg would not bear him. He fell to one knee. Perren pulled him by the arm and seated him at the foot of the wall, turned his pupils toward the light, then asked for the names.

"Kaya. Börü. Melira. Burkut."

Togan stopped.

Perren's fingers tightened around his wrist. "The fifth."

The face before him was familiar. The name seemed locked inside a chest. The more Togan forced at its lid, the clearer the white room became. He stopped trying. He looked at the stone tablet by the wall, at the lines drawn by the man's crooked finger.

"Perren."

The old man released his breath. "How long did it take?"

"You're asking me?"

Perren cut another notch in the tablet. "Seven breaths."

For seven breaths, Togan had lost the name of the man with whom he had traveled. He remained curious about what the Wall would show him. Now he knew that every answer he received might tear something from him.

He left his sword away from the gate beside Perren's bed.

"Write this too," he said. "Tomorrow you'll stop me even if I tell you not to."

Perren did not hesitate this time. "It's written."

Togan looked at the gate again. Waiting no longer required patience alone. He did not know whether his body would remain his own.

## Chapter 2 — A Bold Move

*(TEMUJIN: Crimson Week, Day One)*

Korgan gave the order to attack before the crimson moon set.

The Azgut army entered the mountains in three columns. Batu held the center, Korgan the south. Temujin had been left the northern slope. After the victory at Eaglehold, sending him into another narrow pass looked less like an execution than a display: Korgan was using his ability while reminding everyone to whom the victory belonged.

Orkhon brought his horse beside Temujin's. "The center wants to crush them with numbers."

"What if Börü retreats?"

"Korgan will pursue."

"What if he surrenders?"

Orkhon did not answer.

Temujin studied the two slopes ahead. Sungur smoke rose from three separate points. Behind the warriors were families, herds, and winter tents. Korgan's map had shown only stones for warriors.

Temujin's map also showed the winter camp, wells, and the cave for the wounded. The number of sentries was uncertain. The map was clear enough not to present the valley as warriors alone.

"If the center takes the hill, this well will close," Orkhon said.

"Then our detachment won't carry water. We'll leave the skins we capture on the stony ground east of the well."

"It will look as though we're giving provisions to the Sungurs."

"I don't want them fighting to reach water."

Orkhon searched his commander's face as if looking for an answer. "Is this mercy or calculation?"

"Must we separate the two?"

"Tell Sube not to close the northern road completely," Temujin said. "Leave a gap wide enough for one person."

Orkhon looked at him. "For them to escape?"

"For the civilians."

"What if Korgan notices?"

"By the time he does, the road will be closed."

Temujin told four corporals that the unarmed, those carrying wounded, and children would pass through the opening. One person's violation would not close the entire road.

"If the Khan asks?" one of the young corporals said.

"Tell him the order was mine."

The answer would not be enough to protect them. Temujin knew that. Yet the only way to stop fear from flowing downward was to give it a name above where punishment could collect.

\* \* \*

The first clash lasted until noon. The Sungurs had turned every outcrop of rock into a small fortress. Temujin did not gather his men into a single line. Two detachments pressed from the front while a third descended the slope behind the defenses.

The slope was a trap. When the third detachment entered between the rocks, two logs rolled from above and cut down the first rank. A horse's scream drowned out human voices in the narrow passage. Temujin did not sound the recall. He lowered the standard to the left. The two detachments at the front stopped their pressure and poured arrows onto the rocks. Orkhon sent six men with shields to those on the ground.

Temujin dismounted. As he tried to free the leg of a soldier trapped beneath the log, a Sungur arrow came between the stones. It pierced the fur above his shoulder. A second arrow lodged in the center of his shield.

"Commander, to the rear!" Orkhon shouted.

"This man first."

Three people lifted the log. The soldier's foot was twisted, but his pulse remained. Temujin told those carrying him to give him water from the well behind the line. The skins they had left for the Sungurs were going east of that same well. A battlefield was a place narrow enough for people killing each other to draw their share from the same water.

When the Azguts took the first position, Temujin stopped to count the dead. He had the weapons of three captured warriors collected and did not



send the prisoners to the rear. Korgan's men used fire to make prisoners speak.

"Carry our wounded," he said. "Then you can go."

One of the Sungurs spat in his face. Temujin did not wipe it away.

"If you send us back, we'll face you again tomorrow," the man said.

"You'll see how much food your wounded have left too."

"Is that why you're releasing us? To learn?"

Temujin wiped the spittle from his face with his sleeve. "So if you want to fight, I don't give you another reason."

The three prisoners were released with a piece of leather recording the hour and Temujin's seal.

When he returned to the northern road, he found that one of the young corporals had closed the opening. An armed Sungur had tried to pass among the civilians, and the corporal had extended one person's violation to the entire road. Temujin removed him from duty and reopened the way. During that half hour, two families had turned back into the valley. He did not know where they reached.

Late that afternoon, a white-haired woman appeared on the northern road. She was carrying a wounded warrior on a litter with two children. The Azguts beside Temujin raised their bows.

Temujin recognized the woman. She had to be the Mother Anya Kaya had spoken of. She was past eighty, yet did not release the front of the litter.

"Lower them," he said.

One raider objected. "The Khan's elder. If we take her, Börü—"

"Lower the bow."

Anya looked at Temujin as she passed. She did not thank him. Nor was she afraid. It was as though she were committing his face to memory for a judgment she would deliver years later.

"Kaya is alive," Temujin said.

The woman's step faltered for the first time. Then she continued carrying the litter.

When the smaller child reached the far side of the pass, he dropped the wooden horse in his hand. An Azgut raider stopped the toy with his foot. Temujin thought the man would break it. The raider bent and offered the

wooden horse to the child. When the child was too afraid to return, he left the toy in the middle of the road.

Both sides watched that wooden horse for several breaths. Then Anya walked back, took it, and caught up to the child without a word.

\* \* \*

Both sides remained in their positions that night. Korgan's central column had taken a hill but failed to hold it. Batu's men had suffered heavy losses in the south. Temujin's northern road was still apparently closed. After darkness fell, thirty-two civilians passed through the opening.

He had his losses and the conditional release of the three prisoners written to Korgan's messenger.

As Orkhon tied the leather, he said, "He'll see this."

"He needs to."

"Tonight?"

"I'll propose another road tomorrow. If I hide what I did today, I can't defend it."

Temujin did not believe Korgan would be persuaded. What he wanted was to prepare not only the road to victory, but the promises that could be kept after it.

Temujin entered Kaya's tent.

"I saw Anya," he said. "She was carrying a wounded man."

Kaya rose despite her bonds. "Did you take her?"

"I let her pass."

"Why?"

"Taking children prisoner is of no use to me."

Kaya understood that the answer was incomplete. "What if Korgan learns you left a road open?"

"Tomorrow he'll learn something more important."

"What?"

Temujin looked at the Azgut fires visible through the tent cloth. "That I want to defeat the Sungurs without killing them."

Kaya did not speak for a long time. At last, she showed him her bonds. "You can begin by releasing one Sungur."

Temujin went outside. The objection was just. Even so, he did not untie her.

In his own tent, he picked up the black stone marking the winter camp. He considered putting it in a pouch where Korgan would not see it, then left it on the map.

The argument in the morning would begin by making him admit that stone existed.

## Chapter 3 — The Harvest Begins

*(KARIA: Crimson Week, Day One)*

The first veins of weed entered Dagger Bay at dawn.

Karia stood at the bow of the flagship, counting the distance between the net boats. The water had receded first. Frail red fibers glowed on the fjord's exposed stones. The gatherers wanted to run for them. Karia sent no one down before the first surge.

During the previous Harvest, two villages that miscalculated the first rise had lost thirty-seven gatherers. This year the merchants named the price of losing an hour. They did not name the price of the dead.

The gatherers would descend in groups of three, and no new group would be sent before one returned. A storehouse officer said this would reduce the first day's yield.

"Put the loss under my order. Don't take it from the crew's share."

"The third line is spread too wide," he said.

The officer beside her raised a signal flag. Two boats drew closer.

The first surge arrived gently. Nets went into the water. Wet weed caught on copper hooks and was drawn onto the decks.

"More plentiful than expected," the officer said.

"The first day's bounty is no measure. Record what reaches the scales separately from what rots onshore."

Before leaving the fleet, Karia looked at the count. What came off the ships did not match what reached the storehouse.

"Have Faelan inspect the warehouse doors," she said. "If we don't find the thief now, we'll lose a fleet at the Peak."

Karia saw the first accident before returning to shore. A net in the fourth line caught on an old ship's keel beneath it. The boat's captain refused to cut the rope because he did not want to lose the crop. When the second surge heeled the boat, two crewmen fell into the water.

The signal horn sounded three times. The neighboring boats approached in the formation set beforehand. While one recovered the fallen men, the other cut the fouled net with an axe. No one died. The captain asked who would pay for the lost net.

"The crown," Karia said.

"You'll collect it from me afterward."

"No. You cut the rope late; that penalty is separate. If I make the crew pay for a net cut to save lives, next time no one will cut it."

She entered the captain's three-day suspension from command in the penalty ledger. On the same page, she added the cost of the rescue net. A rule was not a rule if it did not apply in a moment of fear.

\* \* \*

At noon, a messenger from the palace said the King had risen and wanted to see her.

Theodoric had walked as far as the Salt Throne, but once seated could not stand again. The physician was gathering the bottles when Karia entered.

Seven empty chairs stood before the throne. The lords were required to attend the palace during the Harvest; that morning, only Calder's seal had reached the table. Drennar was with the northern fleet, Hallis was counting storehouses, and Maros had fallen ill upon learning that her goods had been seized. Vorlag's chair was empty by choice.

Theodoric looked at the vacant places. "If you want to see how a kingdom truly works, don't watch the ceremony. Watch the morning when everyone has business elsewhere."

"Maros didn't have business. She had theft."

"Then tax her in her sickbed."

"How is the Harvest?" the King asked.

"The first figures are good. The storehouse loss is bad."

Theodoric laughed, and the laugh became a cough. "You're beginning to give the right answers before you take the throne."

Karia did not kneel before him. The King had forbidden it during their last meetings.

"Aldric was thirteen when he went on his first Harvest," Theodoric said. "He knocked two crewmen into the sea trying to help pull the nets. Everyone told me he was brave. I believed them."

Karia waited.

"When he wanted to go north, I mistook that for courage too." The King removed his ring. "I sent my son into a legend. I made you heir so I wouldn't send you into the same mistake."

Karia's palm closed of its own accord. The Aldric Perren had searched for and the child living in the old man's memory before her were the same person. She wanted to tell his father about the traces left in the north. She had nothing that proved a return. It would be easy to turn hope into comfort for a dying man. It would be a lie she could not take back.

"I'm having the northern records searched," she said. "If I find a result, I'll tell you only what I can confirm."

Theodoric inclined his head by the slightest degree. "That isn't the answer I wanted to hear."

"I know."

"That may be why it's true."

He placed the ring in Karia's palm. A small scratch Aldric had made as a child marked its inner surface.

"I can't take this."

"It isn't the crown. It's a father's mistake. Keep it beside you when you sit on the throne."

Karia closed her fingers around the ring. "I won't sit while you are here."

"That won't be your choice."

Karia did not put the ring on her finger. She threaded it onto the small ring of keys at her belt. Theodoric did not object. Wearing a keepsake and carrying it were not the same. That day, Karia believed she needed the weight of the crown, not its appearance.

When the physician offered the medicine, the King turned his head. Karia asked what the mixture contained. When the physician could not answer precisely, she returned the cup.

Theodoric managed a smile. "You've begun inspecting the palace before I'm dead."

"Protecting you and protecting the throne are the same work today."

\* \* \*

Vorlag was waiting in the corridor. His gaze fell to Karia's closed hand.

"The King has begun distributing family heirlooms," he said.

"If you are so curious about his health, ask him."

"You exiled Valerius. Will you exile me now?"

"If you commit a crime, I'll find the evidence."

Vorlag set the end of his cane on the stone floor. "Valerius was hasty. Patient people leave no evidence."

Karia felt the edge of the ring in her palm. "We shall see."

Vorlag inclined his head and stepped aside.

Yielding the way did not mean he had lost. When Karia had gone two paces, she heard the cane strike the stone floor once. The young clerk at the end of the corridor immediately left through another door. Vorlag carried messages too. The recipient alone was unclear.

Rather than have Faelan follow the clerk, Karia ordered him to record every message door the man used that day. Arresting one person would cut the trail. Seeing where the trail led was more valuable.

Karia returned to her ship before sunset. Two barges belonging to House Maros had been found taking cargo without passing the scales. She had the goods sealed, separated the captain who gave the order from the storehouse clerk, and secured the workers' wages. A small portion of the account remained open.

"Good for the first day," Faelan said.

"Dangerous for the first day."

Karia turned the scratched ring among her keys. Theodoric had given her a father's mistake. Vorlag was shortening time with patience, Maros with greed, and the sea with its tide.

When she left the ship that night, the gatherers' watches were changing. Those returning from the first watch spoke their names one by one at the counting gate. Karia stayed onshore until the list ended. The true measure of the Harvest under way was not the weed in the storehouses, but the people who returned.

## Chapter 4 — Wrecktime

*(ZALEENA: Crimson Week, Day One)*

When the sea withdrew, everything hidden beneath Patchwork Harbor came into view.

Old anchors, split boats, and tangled human bones lay in the mud. The captains were impatient to send their crews down to plunder. Zaleena allowed no ship to cast off before they knew the hour of the first surge.

"We're losing Wrecktime," Draven said.

"The living will see the second tide too."

Zaleena had white stakes bearing return times planted at the receding water's edge. Everyone going down to the wrecks would give a name and destination. She wrote the first name herself. Sorin, Kessel, and finally Draven followed.

"A king's bookkeeping," he said.

"So we know whom to count missing when we search for bodies tomorrow."

Draven did not answer. He put his own crew in line.

Kessel came on deck with a woman in a thin robe. A copper reed seal of the Rivan Delta hung at her neck.

"Deputy of the Delta storehouse in the harbor," Kessel said. "She wants to see you."

The woman did not bow. "The letter you sent Lady Amara cannot have reached the Reed Throne yet. But a copy of your attack record reached me."

"You're quick."

"We have goods here. We have to be." The deputy opened a small leather roll. Inside lay a piece resembling the shell of the Rust Tide. "The creatures

flee loud sounds. Fire only changes their direction. Beneath their shells are salt sacs; fresh water makes them lose their balance."

"Your name?" Zaleena asked.

The woman hesitated for the first time. "Neris."

"Who tested this information, Neris?"

"The Delta's northern observers."

"How many died?"

"That isn't part of this bargain."

"It is the first part if my people are to test it."

Neris opened the second strip of the leather roll. It named three observers, two dates, and the channel where the test was conducted. One had died; another had lost his right hand. Fresh water did not kill the creatures. It briefly disrupted their sense of direction.

Zaleena had Kessel read the text as well. The information would not become a defensive order before it was heard from a second mouth.

Zaleena did not touch the fragment. "The price?"

"During Crimson Week, Delta boats pass through the inner channels without inspection."

"No."

"Then there is no information."

Zaleena pointed to the Delta storehouse on the southern pier. "When the water rises, that is where the first attack will land. If I don't defend it, your goods will go into the sea with your information."

The woman pressed her lips together. "What do you propose?"

"A temporary agreement for seven days. Your boats receive priority, but their cargo is recorded. You give the defense all your observation notes and the fresh water you hold. If Amara's answer comes, we discuss permanent terms at the Razor Reefs."

"We have private cargoes."

"I have private prisons."

At last the deputy extended her hand. "Seven days."

Zaleena took it. "Seven days."

The agreement was written in two copies with three conditions: Delta boats would be searched, would receive priority only, and the privilege would



end at the stated hour on the seventh day. Neris and Zaleena signed; Kessel and Draven witnessed.

Zaleena had learned the greatest danger of temporary power from Roric. People quickly mistook a privilege without a written end for a right.

\* \* \*

The first surge came that afternoon. It was carrying the wreck of a Hegemony merchant ship toward the harbor. Three captains set sail without waiting for a signal.

The Hegemony's faded gull emblem was still visible on the wreck's stern. Those onshore said it might have tide-steel in its hold. Within minutes the rumor became certain news, and certain news became a quarrel over shares.

Zaleena had the lookout's ledger opened. The wreck had to be the *Patient Gull*, lost three months earlier among the northern rocks. Its recorded cargo was grain, sailcloth, and twelve chests of glass. There was no tide-steel.

"Signal them," she said. "The fortune they're chasing is moldy flour."

The captains either failed to see the signal or refused to believe it.

Zaleena swore. "Draven, circle north of them. Kessel, take the middle. Don't let them approach the wreck alone."

The *Sea Ghost* went ahead. The water around the wreck moved against the wind. Zaleena ordered the bell rung when the first armored head appeared at the gunwale.

A pack of Rust Tide waited beneath the wreck.

When the first creature came through the broken side, one of the fleeing ships cut off another as it turned. The masts struck. A crewman fell between the two ships and his shoulder was crushed. The race begun for plunder had taken its first casualty before the pack attacked.

Zaleena put the *Sea Ghost* between the wreck and the harbor. She did not try to kill the creatures. She had the bells struck at different intervals. The pack moved away from the broadside where the sound was densest and crowded into the quiet channel. The Delta's barrels were waiting there.

Kessel placed his ships side by side to form a narrow corridor. Draven opened the return route for the captains who defied the order. Zaleena tested

the information supplied by the Delta deputy: she had two barrels of fresh water tied to hooks and emptied before the pack.

The creatures' legs folded when the water touched them. They lost their direction on the surface and collided with one another.

"It works," Sorin said.

"Until the barrels run out."

The ships abandoned the wreck and returned to the harbor. No crewmen were lost. That evening, Zaleena cut the plunder shares of the three captains who defied the order and added the cost of rescue to their debts.

She separated the injured crewman's debt from his captain's share. The man had not chosen the captain who ignored the order. He merely worked on that ship. When the harbor healer said the injury might be permanent, Zaleena paid him seven days' wages from the common defense fund.

The three captains said they had not seen the signal or had wanted to claim the fortune for the harbor. The lookouts confirmed that the return flag had been clear.

"Your shares have been cut," Zaleena said. "Your ships haven't been taken. Tomorrow you enter the defense roster."

"You punish us and then trust our command?"

"I don't trust you. I'm assigning a recorder beside you."

\* \* \*

Roric read the agreement's record in the lower cabin.

"You've opened the door to the Delta," he said.

"I've put my foot on the threshold."

"They'll think it's the same thing."

"They'll learn they're wrong."

Roric returned the paper. "The first poison of power is believing you're cleverer than everyone else."

Zaleena folded the record. "What's the second?"

"Thinking warnings come only from your enemies."

Zaleena left that unanswered. When she returned to the deck, the Delta's barrels of fresh water were being distributed among the piers.

Before the distribution ended, Neris said there were eight more barrels in the Delta storehouse. Zaleena left the drinking share to the warehouse workers and took the rest for the defense.

"The agreement says all the fresh water," Neris said.

"If we turn what people drink into a weapon, there will be no harbor left to defend on the seventh day."

"Amara may call that weakness."

"Then put the numbers in your report too."

Neris left without bowing her head. Zaleena understood that the Delta's first test would concern their decisions under scarcity more than their knowledge of the creatures.

The list of those who failed to return that night was empty. Wrecktime had brought the harbor no fortune. That day, it had taken no one either.

## Section 13 — The Broken World

### Chapter 5 — Light Within the Silence

*(TOGAN: Crimson Week, Days Three and Four)*

The sea rose throughout the second day. The shelter was leagues from the shore, yet salt water seeped between the stones that night. Togan kept watch at the gate while Perren emptied the bowls.

The water did not emerge from the cracks in the ground at the same speed. In the fissures nearest the gate, it swelled upward, then retreated when the rhythm of the light changed. Togan scattered a handful of ash across the cracks. Three lines where the Current moved appeared. All ran beneath the shelter toward the Wall.

They raised the provisions, wrapped the tablets, and left themselves a line of escape to the distant hill. If the Wall suddenly grew stronger, they would not return to the shelter.

"How many hours does the third-day weakening last?" Togan asked.

"Six to nine in the old measurements."

"How close will you let me go?"

"Three breaths on the first attempt. If you give the names correctly, five on the second."

"And if that isn't enough?"

Perren tucked the wet tablet beneath his arm. "We live with insufficient knowledge."

Togan did not like the answer. Even so, he tightened the knot of the red cord at Perren's waist with his own hands.

At dawn on the third day, the Wall faded.

The shadows cast by Perren's bronze rods had shortened, and for the first time all the symbols on the gate were visible at once.

Perren approached the gate alone first. The instant the empty bronze rod in his hand entered the unseen boundary, it turned white and split down the middle. The old man sprang back. But when Togan touched his arm, the

same boundary did not pull the rod; it pressed toward a point beneath his skin.

"This isn't protection," Perren said. "Don't think it has accepted you."

"Can you tell acceptance from a trap?"

"No. That's why we have the cord."

Togan removed his sword, bow, and the pieces of iron at his belt. The pressure in his chest grew with every step toward the gate. The invisible boundary that had stopped him the day before now yielded.

He reached out.

His palm did not touch the light. The light entered his palm.

The veins along Togan's arm shone as white lines. His knees struck the stones. The hum of the gate vanished; so did the sea, the wind, and Perren's shout.

The white room formed around him.

Someone sat in the chair. A thin, almost human hand opened toward Togan. Its fingers were too long. The face remained unseen.

Togan tried to speak Melira's name. No sound came from his mouth.

Five lines opened on the wall behind the chair. A different image trembled within each: a clan camp beneath snow, a shore of black stones, a woman with bloodied hands, a copper ring tied to a cradle, and three people kneeling before the light. Whichever Togan watched made the others fade. He tried to make out the woman's face. The white room forced his head toward the cradle.

The copper ring bore the three symbols taken from the weed creature on the first day.

The open hand closed.

Hundreds of symbols on the gate changed direction at once. Togan heard not his own heartbeat, but another rhythm from across the room. It was not examining him. It recognized him.

Perren pulled the cord with all his weight. Togan tore free of the boundary and fell onto his back. Sound returned at once. Blood ran from his nose and from the old cut in his right palm.

Togan tried to sit up; the world tipped to the left. Perren rolled him facedown. There was nothing in Togan's stomach but water and dried meat. Still, he retched for a long time.

"The names," Perren said.

"Kaya. Börü. Melira. Burkut. Perren."

"Where are you?"

"The Dawn Gate."

"What day is it?"

Togan watched the light fade and strengthen twice before answering. "The third."

Perren looked at the hourglass tied to the end of the cord. "You were inside for three breaths. Forty-one passed here."

Togan did not remember spending that long in the white room. An invisible piece had been added between his memories.

Perren held his arm. "What did you see?"

Togan could not answer. Instead of falling to the ground, the blood on his hand extended toward the light like a fine thread. When the boundary strengthened, the thread broke and splashed down.

"It recognized me," he said at last.

Perren looked at the gate. "The Wall?"

"Someone behind it."

\* \* \*

Perren spent the entire afternoon measuring Togan's pulse, eyes, and the heat of the wound in his palm. He added his failure to record the first night's heart rhythm to the tablet as an error. Concealing a finding he did not understand had not made it safer. When Togan drank water, he tasted metal. Burkut would not approach. The eagle watched from two paces away with his feathers raised.

The wound in Togan's right palm did not close. Every time the blood clotted, a thin white line crossed the edge and divided the clot again. Perren wanted to cauterize it with hot iron. The metal began to tremble a finger's breadth from Togan's skin.

"Leave it," Togan said.

They bound the wound tightly with linen. Perren did not throw the bloodied cloths into the fire. He placed them in a stone vessel and took them away from the gate. He wanted to test the Wall's reaction to Togan's blood again. Togan disliked seeing something from his own body become a finding. But there was no other way to reach an answer.

"In eleven years, I've seen six people approach the gate," Perren said. "Two tried to touch it. Both were thrown back from the boundary. The light entered no one's veins."

"Are you asking what I am?"

"I don't think you know."

Togan pressed the bloody cloth to his palm. "The Sungurs found me in the ruins of a clan camp. No one knows my mother or father."

Perren reread the cipher on the stone tablets: "The key is not in the heart of the Current, but in the silence it leaves behind."

"Blood," he said. "Perhaps the silence isn't an instant. Perhaps a certain blood disrupts the Wall's attunement."

"My blood?"

"I don't know."

Togan trusted the answer. If Perren had spoken with certainty, he would not have believed him.

Perren brought the copper ring taken from the weed creature. He asked Togan to draw its symbols as he had seen them in the white room. Togan completed the first two and stopped at the third symbol's curve. In his mind, the shape had no end.

"I was certain I saw it."

"Seeing and bringing it back with you may not be the same thing."

Togan set down the charcoal. "What else didn't I bring back?"

Perren did not answer. He asked for the five names again. Togan knew them all. Then he asked how the tale Anya had told him last winter ended. Togan remembered the tale. He did not remember its ending.

The loss seemed small. Its smallness made it more frightening.

\* \* \*

The gate weakened again on the fourth day. This time Togan passed the cord through two rings in the rock. Perren tied it around his waist. Togan put only his fingertips into the gate's boundary.

He was not supposed to approach after the first attempt. They had written the rule together. When morning came, Togan took the cord. Perren would not give it to him.

"You lost forty-one breaths yesterday."

"Today I'll ask one question."

"The gate doesn't answer you. It directs you."

Togan raised the bloodied cloth in the stone vessel toward the Wall. Fine fibers had climbed to the vessel's lid. "If we return to the Old City after seeing this and doing nothing, the people there will ask why we didn't try a second time."

"We'll tell them we wanted to live."

Togan tied his end of the cord around his waist. "Three breaths. Then I'll come out before you pull."

Perren held the cord for a long time. At last, he checked the knots on both rock rings again. "If one name is late, I pull on the second breath."

The light moved into Togan's veins again. This time he endured three breaths without drawing back.

On the first breath, he saw the white room.

On the second, the chair was empty.

On the third, he heard Melira's voice.

"Togan."

The voice was the same, even to the slight break at the end of a breath. But when Melira was angry with him, she shortened his name. When she was afraid, she drew it out. This voice did neither. It had copied the shape of a memory without learning its intent.

He drew back his hand without waiting for the cord. He dropped facedown. He did not hear his name in her voice again.

"The gate is using her," he said. "To keep me inside."

"Are you certain?"

Togan raised his head. His eyes were wet; his voice was steady. "That isn't how Melira said my name when she called me."



Perren asked for the five names. Togan answered. He did not ask how the tale ended.

"We could try again," Perren said. The words seemed to have escaped him unwillingly.

This time, Togan was the one who had to stop. He thought of the cradle on the white room's wall, the bloodied woman within the lines, and the possibility that the answer he sought stood only one step away. Then he felt the empty place where the forgotten end of the tale had been.

"No."

Perren's hands trembled as he untied the cord. "Why?"

"Because you just wanted it."

The old man looked at his hands. The gate was not pulling only Togan. It could bend anyone waiting for an answer toward its own purpose.

They cut and burned the cord from the two rock rings. They did not approach the gate again that day.

The gate had not opened. Yet two days earlier, Togan would have given his life to open it. Now he knew he would not take another step before learning what the thing behind it wanted.

## Chapter 6 — Breaking Point

*(TEMUJIN: Crimson Week, Day Four)*

On the morning of the fourth day, the Sungurs withdrew into the final valley. Its entrance was too narrow for five horses abreast. Here, the Azguts' numbers created congestion rather than advantage.

Two attacks had been attempted before sunrise. Stones stopped the shields and buried stakes stopped the horses. The mouth of the pass was full of wounded.

Temujin stopped the third assault. He had three lines of stretchers established beyond arrow range. Azgut and Sungur wounded were not carried separately. One Sungur warrior bit the arm of the Azgut healer who touched him. The healer bound the bleeding vein all the same.

"The Khan ordered the attack," Batu's messenger said.

"There is no road left to attack through. No one enters until the bodies are cleared."

The messenger wanted to record it as disobedience. Temujin showed him the casualty board and wrote the sentence himself: *The third assault was postponed because the pass was physically obstructed*. He pressed his seal beneath it.

On the casualty board in Korgan's war tent, the dead, wounded, and missing were marked with the same stroke. When Temujin asked for the three numbers to be separated, the clerk said it would be done after the battle.

"Separating the living from the dead after the battle does the soldier no good," Temujin said.

The clerk added three new columns at the bottom of the board. Korgan heard the exchange but did not stop it. Temujin took this not as approval, but as time given before the coming argument.

"Who is in the winter camp before the valley?" Korgan asked.

Batu answered. "The old, children, and wounded. The warriors' families."

"Gather them. Drive them into the front rank."

The tent went silent.

Batu's hand moved toward the black stone marking the winter camp, then stopped. He hesitated not because the order was wrong, but because he would have to make his own men carry it out. Temujin saw the distinction. Korgan must have seen it too.

Orkhon raised his head. "My Khan?"

"A Sungur cannot shoot an arrow through his own child. They will open the gate."

Temujin looked at the winter-camp stone on the map. Not everyone who had passed along the road he left open on the first day had reached the valley. If Korgan's order was carried out, Anya might be among those taken.

"It will open this valley," Temujin said. "It will close every valley after it."

Korgan turned to him. "Speak plainly."

"No clan will ever surrender to us again. A warrior who knows he will see his women before our line will fight until he dies. To save one hundred men today, we will lose a thousand in the next ten battles."

"The Sungurs are our enemies," Batu said.

"Today." Temujin pointed to the three columns on the casualty board. "In the steppes Korgan wants to build, tomorrow they'll stand the same watch. If we use their children as shields, they'll carry the common standard only from fear."

Korgan's gaze sharpened. "Do you know what I want to build better than I do?"

"No. But I know what people won't forget."

"What is your account?"

Temujin pointed to the broken line north of the valley. "There's a goat path behind the mountain. Sube can cross it in two days with fifty men. When the Sungurs see they're surrounded, we begin discussing surrender."

Temujin had found the goat path in an old song of Kaya's. The three junipers named in its verses truly stood in the same order on the northern slope. Eagle scouts had seen a single-person trail among the rocks at noon. Its destination was not certain. If Sube's men could not cross, in two days they would be unable either to return or join the battle.

"You may lose fifty men," Korgan said.

"If we put the winter camp in front, we may lose the steppes."

"And if there is no negotiation?"

"We attack. But without using civilians."

Korgan's hand came down on the table. The stones jumped. "Don't teach me morality, boy."

"I'm telling you the cost of victory."

Batu put his hand on his sword. Orkhon did not move. Korgan looked at Temujin for several breaths.

"Until sunset on the third day," he said. "If you have no result, you will clear the winter camp yourself. You will put the people in front yourself."

Temujin turned the deadline in his mind. Sube had to signal by the sixth day of Crimson Week. If the path took half a day longer than expected, the entire plan would collapse.

"I don't accept the second part of that order," he said.

Batu's sword rose a finger's breadth in its sheath.

Temujin continued. "If I have no result, I'll relinquish command. I won't put the winter camp in front."

Korgan walked around the table and stopped before him. An arm's length remained between them. "When you relinquish command, someone else carries out the order."

"Then it will be your decision. Not mine."

The wind outside filled the tent cloth. Korgan could have killed Temujin where he stood. Instead, he repeated his first condition.

"Sunset on the third day. I want a result."

"You'll have one."

"Your promise was heard here."

Temujin did not repeat the second order. Everyone in the tent heard the omission.

\* \* \*

When they left the tent, Orkhon caught Temujin's arm.

"You just refused Korgan's order."

"I gave him a better road."

"You can tell it that way to yourself. He won't."

Temujin described the goat path to Sube. Fifty people would travel in light armor; they would use the horn if the way opened, smoke if they became trapped.

"If we see smoke, we can't send help," Orkhon said.

"I know."

Sube knew too. He gave Temujin the names of those selected. "Our families' shares, if we don't return."

Temujin put the list in his inner pocket. A plan looking fine on a map did not lighten the fifty lives inside it.

"Don't attack when you reach the valley. Plant the standard where they can see it. Knowing the way out is closed will be enough."

\* \* \*

Kaya turned the knot in the rope around her wrists as she listened to the news.

After the escape attempt, she had been tied to the pole in the middle of the tent. Temujin sent the sentries outside and left the door open. He would not be alone with Kaya, nor would anything he said become an unwitnessed bargain. Orkhon stood at the entrance.

"Korgan will use the winter camp," she said. "If time runs out, he'll crush you too."

"Time won't run out."

"Börü won't surrender."

"Would he if you told him?"

Kaya raised her head. Temujin took a small strip of leather and a piece of charcoal from his pocket.

"Write to him in your own hand. Tell him I have the road behind them. Tell him his clan will be unharmed if he surrenders."

"Is Korgan giving that word?"

"I am."

"They aren't the same thing."

"I know."

Kaya did not take the charcoal. "Do you have the power to keep your promise?"

Temujin was silent for a moment. "I have to win this war to have it."

Kaya drew the leather toward her. "Then choose the right words."

They composed the first sentence together.

Kaya did not tell Börü to surrender. She began, *When the valley is closed, listen to a promise that will keep the people alive*. She added the goat path, that Anya lived, and that the civilians who passed along the northern road had not been harmed. At the end, she drew an eagle mark only Börü would recognize.

"Choose who will carry the letter," Temujin said.

"He won't believe one of your men."

Kaya chose one of the wounded Sungurs who had been released on the first day. Temujin granted him safe passage only as far as the valley.

The warrior tucked the leather inside his shirt. "What if Börü says no?"

"You don't have to come back," Temujin said.

The man looked at Kaya. "I will."

As night fell, Sube's fifty people disappeared on the northern slope. The Sungur carrying the letter walked toward the valley with a white cloth tied to his spear. Temujin watched the two small groups draw away from each other in the dark. One had to reach the back of the mountain; the other had to reach Börü alive.

The only answer he could give to Korgan's order depended on both completing their roads.

## Chapter 7 — Monster Day

*(KARIA: Crimson Week, Day Five)*

The lookout bell struck seven times before dawn.

The seventh strike was the monster signal. Everyone working in the harbor ran to the place assigned during drills. The gatherer boats headed to the western shelter, the supply barges behind the stone breakwater. To prevent a crush at the city gates, the coastal districts were evacuated up three separate slopes.

Karia had left her armor at the palace. On the way to the deck, she took a chain shirt from an armory attendant. Its shoulders were narrow, and she could not fasten the front. Kaelan handed her a short-hafted axe rather than the ceremonial sword.

"If the weed tangles in the ropes," he said.

Karia hooked the axe to her belt. "If it reaches me today, we're in the wrong place."

Kaelan did not answer. They both knew they would find themselves in the wrong place.

When Karia reached the wall, the kelp giant stood at the mouth of the fjord. Its mass of wreckage, bones, and dark crimson weed walked through the water. Each step drove a wave against the shore. Masts embedded in its body swayed like a forest of ships.

Pieces of vessels from years past covered the giant. A prow bearing the Hegemony emblem stood upside down on its left shoulder. Lower down, it

dragged half a fishing cage with skeletons still inside. The creature was not made of weed alone. It had made a body of what the sea had swallowed.

"Close the northern chain," Karia said. "Bring the gatherers into the inner harbor. The guns will fire at the forelegs."

The first order went by flag. When the capstan drawing the northern chain jammed, six workers in the tower threw their bare hands against the wheels. The chain came above the surface only when the giant entered the fjord's narrowest point. When the mass struck it, the foundation stone of one tower cracked.

"Cut it?" the attendant shouted.

"No. Make it narrow the giant's approach."

Karia knew the chain could not stop it. If it shifted the creature's path by one ship-length, the shore guns would find the angle for a second shot.

The first salvo scattered the giant's right side. The surrounding weed closed the cavity within a few breaths.

The second salvo was delayed. The fuse on the third gun had become wet. While the gunner prepared the fire again, an arm of weed reached the wall. Two soldiers on the battlement were drawn into the mass. Karia pulled the axe and cut the fibers reaching for her. The severed ends twisted like worms on the deck.

Kaelan caught one man by the belt at his waist. Only the other's helmet remained. Karia asked his name. No one knew. The unit clerk shouted from below, "Edran, Hallis coast!"

Karia repeated the name. Not so he would be remembered after the battle, but so that in that moment he would not remain only a number.

"Striking the body isn't enough," Sir Kaelan said.

Karia knew. According to old records, a dense core lay inside the mass. Its position was not fixed. It moved through the weed as the giant moved.

She sent two warships to the giant's flanks. A heavy harbor chain was stretched between them. When the ships rowed in opposite directions, the chain cut through the body. The layers of weed opened. Deep inside, a glow shifted from yellow to red with every contraction.

The captain of the eastern chain ship closed the angle too early. The chain slipped upward across the giant. Karia spun the white flag twice: slacken and

take again. The captain followed the first signal and hesitated at the second. An arm of weed swept the oar bank, knocking four men into the water.

"A rescue boat can't go out," Kaelan said.

Karia had the short-range net launcher on the wall turned downward. The heavy net, normally used to catch soldiers boarding a ship, fell over the men in the water. Three caught the rope. The fourth vanished beneath the giant.

"The core is beneath starboard," Karia said. "Pass the second chain below."

An arm of weed snapped the mast from one of the ships. Ropes scythed across the deck. The officer beside Karia fell into the sea. Kaelan pulled him back with a hook.

The officer's arm was broken below the elbow. Kaelan wanted to send him back. The man raised the signal flag with his good hand. Karia took it and had the healers carry him away. Allowing him to continue would not honor his courage. It would mean watching him bleed to death.

The second chain failed to reach beneath the giant. Karia pointed to the tide-steel ram at the flagship's bow. It was normally used to tear open the sides of enemy galleys.

"Turn us toward the glow."

Kaelan looked at her. "If we strike, the ship stays there."

"If we don't, the city doesn't stay here."

The rowers took their places. The two chain ships opened the giant's body again. Karia stood at the ram's release lever. The mechanism could not be operated remotely. As pieces of weed rained onto the deck, the flagship entered the open wound.

Crimson fibers stuck to the face of the first rower. He did not release the oar; the crewman beside him scraped them away with a knife. The drummer in the stern did not break rhythm even when a wave washed over the deck. Karia could not see the rudder. She knew the ship's direction only by the changing sound of the oarstrokes.

The core's glow moved from right to left. Kaelan told her to release the lever. Karia waited. If the ram fired too soon and lodged in the outer weed, there would be no second shot.



The glow disappeared for an instant. Karia waited.

When the yellow light flared again, she lowered the lever.

The tide-steel ram tore free of the ship and drove into the core. Three barrels of incendiary mixture behind it exploded together. The heat threw Karia across the deck.

Her brow struck the ram lever. A red curtain covered her sight. Her right ear heard nothing after the explosion. As she lay on the deck, she knew the ship was being drawn inside the giant from the way the planks bent beneath her feet.

The kelp giant made no sound. Its body lost its will. As it toppled like a tower, it began pulling the flagship beneath it.

"Cut the lines!"

Kaelan cut the first with his sword. Karia struck the second with her axe. At the final instant, the ship broke free from the ram line. The wave from the falling mass carried them as far as the walls.

\* \* \*

When Karia regained consciousness, she was lying on the deck. Blood seeped from her left brow and her mouth was filled with the taste of burned weed.

"The city?" she asked.

Kaelan sat her up. "Standing."

The count came toward evening: thirty-one dead and two ships heavily damaged. Enough lifeless weed had filled the harbor to be processed for months. The people at the quay were shouting Karia's name. Karia asked first for the list of the dead.

Edran was on it. Karia ordered the families' shares set aside before the accounts for funeral and cleanup. Not everything washed ashore was profit.

The palace messenger found her there.

Theodoric was waiting in bed. When he saw the cut on Karia's face, he pointed to the stool beside him.

"You killed a giant."

"A fleet killed it. I pulled the lever."

"That's the right way to put it." Theodoric gathered his breath. "Tomorrow the songs will place you alone at the ship's bow again."

"The records won't."

Karia placed the list of the dead on the table beside the bed. The King tried to read the first three names; the letters must have blurred before his eyes. Karia took back the list and read all thirty-one aloud. Theodoric inclined his head slightly after every name.

"Good. Live long enough to correct the historians when they lie."

Karia smiled. The King closed his eyes and gathered his breath.

"The people spoke your name today," he said. "Not mine. I thought that would anger me."

"Did it?"

"No." Theodoric let his hand rest on the bed. "That means I can sleep for a while."

Karia took his hand. She did not know how she had held her father's hand as a child. Theodoric was not her father, and neither had ever named him so. Yet the fine bones in his palm felt as though they had suddenly lost all the weight of the state they had carried for years.

"I'll bring the Harvest account in the morning," she said.

"Bring it."

Without opening his eyes, Theodoric added, "If you're late, keep doing your work."

As Karia left the chamber, the physician shook his head. The noise of victory reached as far as the palace. Inside, the King's breath was weaker than the noise.

## Chapter 8 — Lord of the Depths

*(ZALEENA: Crimson Week, Day Five)*

On Monster Day, the sea stopped all at once.

The stillness appeared first in the pendulums around the harbor. While every ship leaned slightly with the wind, three boats in open water remained upright. Then the clappers inside the coastal bells fell silent together.

Neris opened the Delta observation roll and spread it across the stone table. The Sea-Shaker records showed two different intervals between waves:

forty to fifty breaths in young creatures, an irregular thirty to seventy in large ones. They did not know whether noise or movement accelerated the wave.

"Is that all you know?" Zaleena asked.

"If you see a blue light turning clockwise, the second wave will be wider."

"You didn't tell us that at the beginning."

"No one asked."

Zaleena drew the paper from before Neris. "From today on, lethal information will not wait its turn in a bargain. Either you give us all of it, or we end the agreement now."

Neris did not object. She opened the two small appendices beneath the roll as well.

A mile of water outside Patchwork Harbor remained flat as a mirror despite the wind. Zaleena recognized the sight from an old expedition Roric had described.

"Recall every boat," she said. "Sea-Shaker."

The return signal went out by flag, bell, and black smoke. Two fishing boats answered. The farthest remained in the center of the still ring.

Draven pulled stone-laden barges to the harbor mouth to be sunk. Kessel distributed rescue lines.

A blue light flared beneath the water.

The first wave could not be seen. All five fishermen on the boat collapsed onto the deck together. The oars fell from their hands. Gulls dropped from the air into the water.

Two lookouts in the harbor's outer tower collapsed as well. The wave did not travel only over the water. It had passed through the stone breakwater as vibration. One man's tongue blocked his throat. The watchman beside him forced open his jaw with a wooden shaft and saved his breath.

"Mark the range," Zaleena said.

Kessel had a white stake driven into the point of the still ring closest to shore. Even if the water moved again, the creature's reach would remain in the record.

Sorin gripped the rail. "Are they alive?"

"Paralyzed."

The blue organ went dark again. Zaleena counted the time from the first flare to its fading. Then the second light began.

"Forty-eight breaths," she said.

"For what?"

"Its waves."

The second light spread clockwise from the first. It was the sign in Neris's appendix. The interval was shrinking.

"We'll use the worst calculation. We must be out in thirty-two breaths."

The trip to the fishing boat and back took forty breaths under normal oars. The wind blew only from outside toward the harbor; it would help them on the way out and hold them on the return. Zaleena had the stern sails set at the reverse angle. On departure, they would have to turn the ship almost halfway around inside the ring to catch the wind.

She took twelve people aboard the *Sea Ghost*. Everyone was tied to the ship at the waist. Hooks and stern sails were prepared.

She put Finn at the helm. The old craftsman had brought his trial boat out of the shallows twice during the last attack. No one in the harbor could read a broken tiller faster. He left the rescue parties onshore to his two apprentices. Zaleena wrote Finn's name on the duty roster with her own hand. Taking him aboard was necessary. Its necessity did not diminish the danger.

She removed anyone who had already been struck by the paralyzing wave. In their place, she chose the people who made the fewest errors at oar and rope.

"Anyone who doesn't want to go should say so now," she said.

No one spoke. Zaleena did not count that as proof of courage. On a deck where fear could not be spoken, silence was not consent.

"If I stay outside, Sorin takes command. Anyone who leaves loses no share."

One of the young crewmen unfastened his belt. Without lifting his head, he stepped ashore. One of Draven's men took his place. No one laughed after him.

Draven stepped before her. "You can't risk the queen for one fishing boat."

"Whom will you risk if I don't go?"

"Me."

Zaleena studied him. "You have the northern pier. If the creature turns toward the harbor, they'll need you more than me."

He did not like the answer. He withdrew all the same.

"If you don't return, I'll convene the Council," he said.

"Convene it. But put it to a vote before you sit in the chair."

The corner of Draven's mouth moved. "Still making rules while you die."

"If I die, that's when they'll be needed most."

\* \* \*

The *Sea Ghost* waited at the edge of the still ring. The blue light flared. When the wave passed and carried dead fish across the surface, Zaleena lowered her hand.

"Now."

The wind carried the ship into the ring. The crew bent to the oars. Thirty-one breaths had passed when they reached the fishing boat.

Two hooks caught its side. The crew began pulling the unconscious fishermen aboard one by one. When the fourth man came over the rail, the blue light below the water flared early.

Twenty-nine breaths had passed. Their calculation was wrong not by four breaths, but by seven.

"Cut the boat loose!" Sorin shouted.

The fifth fisherman was still entangled in the rope.

Zaleena did not release the hook. She hauled the man over the gunwale herself. Blue light spread beneath the ship.

The fisherman's foot was wrapped three times in the rope. Zaleena tried to draw her knife; the first vibration numbed her fingers. Sorin took the knife and cut the line in two places. As the boat drifted toward the creature with the Current, the man struck the *Sea Ghost's* side. His brow split. Zaleena caught him by the collar and pulled him onto the deck.

"Sail!"

The *Sea Ghost* turned. The first paralysis began in Zaleena's fingers. Her right hand locked on the hook. Sorin caught her at the waist and pulled her

onto the deck. By the time the ship left the still ring, Zaleena could no longer feel her knees.

The wave felled two crewmen in the stern. Those on the mast did not release the sail. The wind carried them beyond range.

The creature's third light flared behind them. This time the wave shook the ship's rudder and cracked one of its iron fittings. The tiller swung left with all its weight and crushed Finn against the stern rail. The air left the old craftsman's mouth; no sound followed. The rudder locked to starboard. Sorin sent two rowers aft. They thrust long oars crosswise into the water and turned the ship's bow toward the harbor. Finn's eyes were open when he was lifted from the deck, but he could not answer Zaleena's question.

Hundreds waited behind the barges onshore. Draven had sunk one stone barge early to keep the route open and drawn the others back by chain. As the *Sea Ghost* passed through the narrow gap, her side scraped stone. The last barge was sunk behind her as soon as she entered.

\* \* \*

Zaleena could not walk when she returned to the harbor. The crew carried her ashore on a door plank. Finn, wrapped in a stripped sail, was taken to the infirmary immediately before her. Four of the five fishermen they rescued had opened their eyes. The fifth was breathing but could not speak.

One of Draven's crewmen who had volunteered for the mission had lost the use of his right arm. Blood ran from the ears of two rowers. Zaleena told the healers to take them first. When the people carrying her ignored the order, she tried to climb down from the plank. Her legs failed and she fell onto the stones.

"Them first," she said again.

This time they listened.

The crowd did not cheer. They saw what the sea could do even to a ruler and made way in silence.

As soon as the oldest rescued fisherman could speak, he asked who owned the boat they had left outside. Zaleena told him it was lost. The man began to weep. Five lives had been saved, yet his family's entire livelihood remained in the sea.

Zaleena expected no gratitude and did not immediately promise a new boat. She had the man's name and the name of his lost boat recorded.

Sorin returned from the infirmary at sunset. In his hand was Finn's resin-darkened chisel.

"He died," he said.

Finn had not regained consciousness. He left no final word saying whom to blame or what should be done with his boat. Zaleena asked for the duty roster. Beside Finn's name stood her own handwriting: *helmsman*. She did not cross out the word. She wrote the hour of death beside it.

Roric left the cabin at night and came to Zaleena. He walked with one arm against the wall.

"Your foot?" he asked.

Zaleena moved the toes of her left foot. "Coming back."

"Going out there was foolish."

"Draven said so too."

"You both know we're right."

Zaleena looked at her hands. They were still trembling. "We brought back all five."

"One day you won't."

"That day I'll know whom I left behind."

"Knowing won't make it easier to carry."

"I don't want it to."

Roric held out the bowl of water beside the bed. Zaleena had to take it in both hands. After a few swallows her stomach turned, and she gave it back.

"If you had died today," Roric said, "the harbor would speak not of the five people you saved, but the void of conflict you left behind."

"That's why we wrote the election rule."

"You have a rule. You don't have a successor."

Zaleena closed her eyes. Kessel could keep the records, Draven could command the defense, and Sorin could hold people together. None could carry the harbor alone. Perhaps that was the problem: the harbor should never again fit inside a single person.

Roric did not answer. He looked at the ledger of the missing on the table. Then, for the first time, he asked for the pen and wrote his own name beneath the survivors.

Beneath it he added the names of those who returned from the rescue ship, the five fishermen, and the two lookouts struck by paralysis onshore. He wrote Finn's name alone beneath the people he had saved. Then he left one blank line.

"What's that for?" Zaleena asked.

"For the name we'll leave behind one day when we can't bring them all back."

Zaleena did not close the blank line. Nor did she throw the ledger into the fire. Fear needed a place in Monster Day's account. Otherwise the next queen would sail into the same sea listening only to the songs.



## Section 14 — The Valley's End

### Chapter 9 — The End of the Valley

*(TEMUJIN: Crimson Week, Day Six)*

At dawn on the sixth day, three small fires burned behind the valley.

Sube had crossed the goat path.

The center fire went dark and flared again. The road was held; the unit was incomplete. Orkhon counted forty-six people.

"They're waiting for the order to attack," Orkhon said.

Temujin tied white horsehair to the spear. "They won't receive it."

During the night, the two hundred warriors Korgan had assigned to the winter camp had prepared to move. Batu had slowed the order by making his men check the horses' shoes again. The small delay might last until noon. Temujin had that long to negotiate.

Temujin untied Kaya's wrists. He did not return her sword, but had her horse and eagle prepared. When Storm settled on her arm after so many days, Kaya's knees gave way for an instant.

Temujin's healer applied oil to the wounds at her wrists one last time. Kaya did not thank him. Temujin expected none. Not injuring a prisoner was not worthy of praise. It was the minimum part of the account.

"You don't have to come back once you enter the valley," he said.

"You aren't releasing me. You're taking me to a negotiation."

"When the negotiation ends, you can choose."

Kaya indicated the absence of her sword. "The choices don't weigh the same."

Temujin drew his own short sword and gave it to Orkhon. He too would go unarmed. Kaya did not consider that sufficient, but did not object again.

"Who has my sword?" she asked.

"It was sent into the valley with the Sungur prisoners. A woman said she would bring it to you."

"Her name?"

Temujin had calculated hundreds of people and conditions, but had not asked the name of the woman to whom he gave the sword. "I don't know."

"Begin the treaty with names."

"You could flee," Temujin said. "Sube would see you. Korgan would take your family."

"You don't need the threat." Kaya mounted. "I'm coming to see whether you'll keep your promise."

They approached the valley entrance with a spear bearing white horsehair. The Azgut archers remained behind. Anya emerged first from the other side, then Börü with his shoulder bandaged. The Sungur warriors' bows were drawn.

Temujin planted the spear in the earth and showed both hands. Kaya dismounted. She released Storm into the air. The eagle circled not toward the Sungur line, but broadly above both sides.

Anya did not embrace Kaya. First she examined her face and wrists. "Did they beat you?"

"No."

"Starve you?"

"No."

"Force you to make a promise?"

Kaya answered without looking at Temujin. "They tried. I made none."

Only then did Anya touch her forehead to Kaya's.

When Börü saw Kaya, the hardness on his face broke apart. He took one step. Kaya raised a hand to stop him.

"The people first," she said.

Temujin pointed to the three fires on the ridge behind them. "The escape road is closed. Korgan's army stands in front of you. At the end of the seventh day, he will put the winter camp in the front rank."

Anya's jaw tightened. "You're in his army too."

"That's why I'm here."

Temujin left his terms written on leather on the flat stone between them. Börü did not take it. Kaya read the text aloud.

The Sungurs would keep their weapons, council, and lands; the Azgut raids would end. In foreign war, Korgan would be recognized as High Khan,

all prisoners would be released, and the final decision would be made at the kurultai.

Kaya turned the leather over. The Azgut army would withdraw from the valley, the Sungur storehouses would not be seized, and accusations would be directed at named individuals, not the clan. Kaya and Orkhon would serve as joint witnesses to violations.

"Orkhon isn't here," Börü said.

Temujin signaled the line behind him. Orkhon approached alone and stood on the far side of the spear.

"Will you bear witness against your Khan's order?" Anya asked.

Orkhon looked not at Temujin, but at her. "No matter who stands against the word I give."

Anya did not say she accepted the answer. She merely had his name added to the leather.

"This isn't surrender," Börü said.

"No," Temujin said. "It's a war we can end."

"You can't end the dead." Börü adjusted the bandage at his shoulder. "This leather won't reconcile them."

"It wasn't written to reconcile them. It was written so we don't add new names tomorrow."

Börü weighed Temujin's words. "The passes you took?"

"Equal shared watches until the kurultai. The army will remain outside the valley."

"Korgan won't accept that."

"On the sixth day of Crimson Week, I will announce to the whole army that the Sungurs recognize his common standard. Then Korgan will either become the Khan who united the steppes or the man who broke his word."

Anya studied Temujin as she had on the first day. "You're giving a promise in his name."

"In my own."

"Will your name stop Korgan's sword?"

"We'll learn today."

Sube lowered his standard on the northern ridge to show the negotiation continued. Movement began in the Azgut line. The soldiers Korgan had prepared for the winter camp were coming forward.

Temujin did not conceal that time was short. "If you don't sign the leather now, I'll go back and try to stop them. I can't promise I'll succeed."

"Your first honest threat," Anya said.

"It isn't a threat."

"The truth from someone with power can sound like one."

Temujin could not dispute it.

Börü looked back at the valley. The wounded leaned against the stones. Children waited beyond arrow range. Then he turned to Kaya.

"What do you say?"

Kaya folded the leather. "This man took me prisoner. I escaped and he bound me again. He concealed me from Korgan when he could have used me. I don't trust him." She looked at Temujin. "But keeping our people alive is worth testing his promise."

Börü raised his right hand to the sky. "My clan will not kneel."

Temujin raised his own hand. "It will not kneel."

Anya placed her hand between the two. The treaty was sealed in that way.

Then the hands separated. Neither Azguts nor Sungurs shouted. Börü ordered the warriors behind him to lower their bows. Temujin raised the white spear three times toward his own line. Orkhon ran back. Sube remained behind the mountain to watch over the withdrawal.

\* \* \*

The news reached the camp before Temujin. The warriors had begun saying that Korgan had gathered the steppes beneath one standard.

The claim of victory was not true. Correcting it at that moment, however, would endanger the treaty. Temujin did not silence the drums. Instead, he gave the heralds the same sentence: *The Sungur clan, retaining its own council and land, has accepted common war.* Korgan's name was spoken. The word surrender was not.

He could not call back every false proclamation. He did not allow the word surrender into the official record.

Korgan kept only Batu in the tent. When Temujin entered, he threw the leather treaty onto the table.

In Batu's left hand was the list of the unit bound for the winter camp. In his right were the victory shares waiting to be distributed. He had not yet decided which paper to hold.

"You've given them autonomy."

"They gave you High Khanship in common war."

"I am their Khan."

"If they had accepted that, they would have died by tomorrow. Now they will carry your name without battle."

"They aren't carrying my name. They're carrying their conditions."

"They also wrote whose summons they will answer when the first common enemy comes."

High Khanship granted no authority to interfere in their internal affairs, but the call to foreign war would still issue beneath Korgan's seal. It was not everything he wanted. It was a beginning he could tell the steppes.

Korgan stood. "You cannot distribute my name."

The drums of victory sounded outside. Every beat carried the news to another clan.

Temujin lowered his voice. "You can stop the drums. Then you can tell all the steppes that you broke the word the Sungurs gave."

"You're threatening me with your own victory."

"I announced this victory in your name."

"Then it is mine."

"With its conditions."

Batu took his hand from his sword. Korgan saw it.

"Until the kurultai," he said at last. "Then we'll discuss the terms again."

"That is what the treaty says."

Korgan took the winter-camp list from Batu's hand and threw it into the fire. Temujin did not feel relief as the paper burned. The order had been withdrawn not because civilians were untouchable, but because the treaty offered Korgan a greater victory. The same man might make another calculation on another day.

"Tomorrow you'll ride beside me," Korgan said. "Everyone will see who won this treaty."

"First I'll complete the prisoner exchange."

Korgan's jaw tightened. "By noon."

Temujin did not bow his head. "By noon."

Victory stood between them. Each counted it as his own work.

\* \* \*

Storm sat on Kaya's arm as she returned to the Sungur line. She called to Temujin from her horse.

"Releasing me doesn't settle my debt."

"You have no debt."

"That isn't yours to decide either."

Orkhon returned Temujin's sword. Kaya had seen that he did not carry it during the negotiation.

Temujin smiled openly for the first time. "What will you tell Togan when he returns?"

Kaya's face closed. "First I'll ask why he left. Then I'll decide about you."

She turned her horse. Temujin did not stop her. When Storm took flight, the shadow held in the camp for weeks returned to the valley with it.

That evening, the Azguts and Sungurs burned their dead on separate hills. No common drum sounded. Sube's fifty men had also returned before midnight; one had a broken foot. Temujin closed the list. He did not think the war was over. Only that no new name would be added to it the next day.

## Chapter 10 — The Last Shard

*(TOGAN: Crimson Week, Days Six and Seven)*

On the sixth day, the Wall hardened again. Togan's teeth ached even though he stood five paces from the boundary. Perren measured the bronze rods one last time; their shadows had returned to their former places.

The salt water on the shelter floor had withdrawn, leaving thin white crusts behind. The copper ring taken from the weed creature on the first day

had gone quiet inside the stone vessel. The metallic taste still came when Togan approached, weaker than before but deeper.

Perren placed the bloody cloths near the boundary. The most recent piece was drawn more strongly toward the light.

"Are we taking these to the Old City?" Togan asked.

"One."

"The others?"

Perren prepared the fire. "Four pieces carrying your blood mean more danger than answers."

Together they burned the cloth that showed the strongest response. The flame turned first white, then blue. Perren would carry the one remaining sample in a sealed copper box.

"The window has closed," he said.

Togan looked at the gate. He wanted to hear Melira's voice again and feared it at the same time. For a year, he had believed she called him from within death. Now he understood that the gate might only have used what he wanted to hear.

"I couldn't have brought her back," he said.

Perren was transferring the measurements to a stone tablet. "We don't know that."

"We don't." Togan nodded. "That's why I won't open the gate."

Perren asked for the five names. Togan gave them all. Then he asked Perren himself to test him on Anya's tale.

He told its beginning and middle. In place of the final passage, the emptiness still came. Togan could fill it with an ending he invented; Perren might never know. He did not.

"I don't remember."

Perren wrote the same words on the tablet. "Perhaps it will return."

"And if it doesn't?"

"Then it will be a memory we know is incomplete. Safer than a memory we invented."

Togan turned Melira's bracelet in his palm. He wondered if his memories of her would one day become incomplete in the same way. So he told Perren the story of their first meeting. The old man entered it on the tablet in short

sentences. Imprisoning a memory in stone would not preserve it. It could, however, leave a second witness who would notice the loss.

This decision weighed more than failure. He was giving up by his own will. It felt like laying Melira in the earth a second time.

Perren closed the tablet. "The Wall didn't tell you who you are. It only showed that it recognized you."

"Who can answer?"

"The Inheritors."

The archives of the Old City held records of the northern expeditions, ruined clan camps, and missing children. If any trail led to Togan's mother, it was on those shelves, not before the Wall.

"Is Aldric's record there too?" Togan asked.

Perren turned his head. "Perhaps."

"You were searching the Old City for him."

"At first, for him." Perren showed him the oldest of the seven tablets he had chosen. Half of Theodoric's seal remained along its edge. "Then what I saw here came before everything else. I gave a promise to one person and turned into a gate."

"Now we'll search for both."

Perren did not accept at once. "Finding the King's son isn't your debt."

"It isn't yours alone either."

"Come with me," Togan said.

Perren did not answer at once. He looked at the stones of the shelter. The days he had drawn on the walls surrounded the gate.

"I tried to leave three times."

On the first, he heard Aldric's voice and returned. On the second, he woke before the gate with his feet bleeding. On the third, he nearly strangled himself with the cord tied around his neck.

Perren had not told him this before. Togan was not angry. For the first time, he could measure how old the man's fear was.

"This time the cord won't be around our necks," he said.

"On the fourth, you won't be alone."

\* \* \*



On the seventh day, Perren fit his belongings into a single sack. Of the hundreds of stone tablets collected across eleven years, he took only seven. He wrapped the rest in oiled cloth and arranged them in the shelter's driest corner.

At the entrance, he left a warning in three languages telling people to stay away from the gate. Beneath it, Togan added one sentence: *If a voice resembles the voice of someone you love, don't answer it.*

Perren did not erase the sentence.

"Will you come back?" Togan asked.

"I don't know. Saying I don't know feels easy today."

Before setting out, Togan checked the cords, waterskins, and sealed box twice. He tied a white cloth to Burkut's leg. The bird did not try to fly toward the Wall. It wheeled above the road to the south.

They began walking south. Perren stopped at the first league stone. It was the farthest point he had reached during his earlier attempts to escape. His hands trembled. The white room must have come before his eyes.

Togan tied the red cord around both their waists.

"If I pull, you'll fall," Perren said.

"I'll pull you too."

They passed the stone together.

On the far side, Perren bent as if he might vomit. Togan did not pull the cord or touch his shoulder. He only waited beside him. When the old man straightened, the first thing he did was ask for the five names.

Togan gave them all. Then he turned the question on him.

"Aldric. Theodoric. Karia. Togan. Perren," Perren said.

His voice diminished on his own name. He said it all the same.

Perren did not look back. After a while, his trembling stopped.

That afternoon, the Crimson Host began to fade and the One Eye turned white again. Togan stopped at a fork. The trail west led to the steppes; the southeastern road to the Old City.

He wanted to return to Kaya, Börü, and Anya. He did not know what he would say. His hand remained on the road marker.

"Truth first," he said.

The decision was not an abandonment of the steppes. It was choosing what he would carry when he returned to Kaya. Saying that a gate recognized him would be easy. Without knowing why, the knowledge might draw a new danger onto the Sungurs. If he found records in the Old City, he would carry evidence home, not a claim.

He took the road to the Old City.

He drew Melira's bracelet from inside his shirt. "I haven't forgotten you," he said. "But I won't believe everything that steals your voice anymore."

As he put the bracelet away, he realized he could not remember the shape of one knot in the braid. When he looked at the cloth, the knot was there. The memory did not return.

Togan stopped and drew it. Perren put the date beside the drawing. They would not conceal the loss.

Burkut flew ahead. Perren adjusted the sack on his shoulder and caught up beside him. The Wall remained visible behind them. For the first time, a road larger than it lay ahead.

## **Chapter 11 — Between Dawn and the Throne**

*(KARIA: Crimson Week, Day Seven)*

### **Wake Me If Morning Comes**

The servant who woke Karia was trying not to cry.

"The King died in the night, my lady. The physician said he did not suffer."

"Who witnessed it?" Karia asked.

The servant was not prepared for the question. She named the night physician, two chamber attendants, and the guard at the door. Karia ordered that none of them leave the palace. A second physician would examine the body, the final medicine would be sealed, and the time of death written with two witnesses. Theodoric was old and ill, but an expected death should not be an unquestioned one.

Karia asked the hour and the state of the harbor. She put on her black coat and walked to the palace. She feared that if she stopped, she would not be able to move again.

In the streets, the weed left by Monster Day was being cleared. The workers had not yet heard of the death. For one moment, Karia wanted to shelter in their ignorance. When the black standard was unfurled on the palace steps, movement in the square slowed. The news passed through faces before it passed through the bell.

The curtains in Theodoric's chamber had not been opened. The King's right hand hung over the edge of the bed. Karia placed it on the coverlet, then took the scratched ring from her palm.

She put it on her finger. It caught at one joint; Theodoric's hand had been broader than hers. Karia did not force it. She returned the ring to its old place on the ring of keys.

"You wanted me to carry it," she said. "I will."

No one but the physician and two servants heard.

The night physician's record was clear. Theodoric had refused the final medicine, asked for water, and inquired about the Harvest account Karia was to bring. His last sentence had been *Wake me if morning comes*. Morning had come. Karia could not wake him.

\* \* \*

## The Last Keeper of the Salt Throne

Faelan was waiting when she stepped into the corridor. "The Council has assembled. Vorlag wants to see you before the ceremony."

"Orders first. The harbor won't stop. The funeral won't be paid from the people's Harvest share. The gates remain open; double the watch."

"The announcement of death?"

"After two physicians seal the record. The lords will hear at the same time as the people."

Faelan looked up as he wrote. "Vorlag will be angry."

"Giving him separate word would make him think he owns the death."

Faelan made a note. "You're speaking like a queen now."

"There has been no ceremony."

"Death doesn't wait."

\* \* \*

Vorlag was alone in the empty Council chamber. He placed two documents before her.

Theodoric's chair at the table had been covered. Vorlag sat not in his own place, but across from it. Karia would have to take the King's chair or remain standing. She read the documents at the clerk's side table. She did not make the empty throne part of the negotiation.

The first was an old compact protecting the rights of the Seven Lords. The second was a short undertaking that Karia would not dissolve the Council once she became queen.

"If you want me to put my hand in the water," Vorlag said, "I want to know you won't turn the Hegemony into a naval headquarters."

"You're threatening to leave the throne dry."

"I'm bargaining."

"Before the King's body has cooled."

"That is why the truth of the terms is clearer. Tomorrow, when everyone wears mourning clothes, the same words will look more beautiful."

Karia did not surrender to the ease of hating him. What Vorlag was doing was ugly. It also constrained the expected void of power in writing. A demand that could be signed was preferable to a coup behind closed doors.

Karia read the second document. It preserved the Council's powers over budgets and war, while the lords agreed not to reopen the Tide-Heir decision. The last line placed every appointment under Council approval. Karia struck it out and wrote a right of reasoned objection requiring a two-thirds majority against high officers. She retained the power to make temporary wartime appointments.

A neutral scribe reread both copies. No seal was applied until the texts matched.

"You won't make my appointments. But if six lords join you, I can't protect the wrong person."

Vorlag read the change. "A purge against the houses of Valerius?"

"Crime is personal. No one will be touched without evidence."

"My house too?"

"Your house is neither outside the law nor beneath it."

Vorlag took the pen. "Your King was easier than you."

"That's why he survived thirty years."

They signed the document. The truce rested not on trust, but on putting each other's limits in writing.

Before lifting his seal, Vorlag said, "Theodoric would not have signed this."

"I know."

"You won't be loved as he was."

Karia gave the second copy to Faelan. "I know that too."

For the first time, Vorlag could not use the answer he had prepared.

\* \* \*

The coronation was set for the same evening as Theodoric's funeral preparations. The Hegemony would not remain without a sovereign even for one night.

Both physicians recorded natural death; no poison was found in the final medicine. Karia opened the records to the public at the Council doors.

Near noon, a man shouted, "Karia killed the King." The guards moved to seize him. Karia had only his name and statement recorded and ordered him released as long as he committed no violence. If she imprisoned the first person to voice suspicion on the day she took the throne, the physicians' records would be worthless.

Sea water stood knee-deep in the Drowned King's Hollow. The Seven Lords gathered around the circle of stone. With the wound from the weed still bandaged, Karia entered the water.

The crown, made from repaired seashells, rested on a stone at the shore. Karia said she demanded no lord's loyalty by force in the wake of death.

Calder took the first step. She put her hand into the water and touched Karia's shoulder. Drennar, Hallis, and Maros's representative followed.

"I carry this crown not for my blood, but for the duty given me," Karia said. "Before the Tide, I swear to protect the Hegemony's shore, bread, and law."

"The law against yourself too?" someone in the crowd asked.

The voice echoed in the cove. The guards searched for the man. Karia stopped them.

"Against myself too," she said. "The limits I signed today may be used against me tomorrow."

She put her hand into the cold water.

Drennar, Hallis, Calder, and Maros followed in turn. Severin hesitated. Bren chose the side of the crowd.

Vorlag was last.

Only dripping water could be heard in the cove. The old lord looked at the ring in Karia's hand. Then he gave his cane to his attendant and entered the water to his knees.

He dipped his hand.

The crown did not remain dry.

Vorlag did not touch the water to Karia's shoulder. He only immersed his own hand and withdrew it. That was enough under the ceremonial law. Part of the crowd wanted to jeer. Karia raised a hand and silenced them. Loyalty shown by force was weaker than a written truce.

Kaelan placed the crown on her head. When the circlet touched the wound at her brow, pain spread across her face. Karia did not clench her jaw to hide it. The people had already seen that a sovereign could be wounded.

When Karia returned to the palace, she wrote her first decree. Theodoric's funeral would be paid from the treasury, and the same document would guarantee the family shares of those who died fighting the kelp giant.

For the first time, she did not write only "Karia" beneath the decree.

She wrote "Queen Karia" and pressed the seal.

Some lords would find it improper to place the funeral and the family shares in the same document. To Karia, Theodoric's final day and the day of those who died in the fjord were not separate.

After everyone withdrew that night, she removed the crown and left it on the stool beside the desk. The scratched ring remained among her keys. She opened the provision account for the Season of Chaos. The first line gave the repair time for the two ships lost in the kelp giant attack.

She had taken the throne. Several hours late, she finished the account she had promised to bring in the morning.

## Section 15 — Four Records

### Chapter 12 — The First Flagstaff

*(ZALEENA: Crimson Week, Day Seven)*

The numbness in Zaleena's legs passed on the morning of the Last Shard. When she stood, Roric was waiting at the door of the lower cabin. He wore a clean shirt and had not covered the burned side of his face.

Zaleena's right knee failed on her first step. She caught the edge of the bed. Roric did not offer a hand. He had to lean against the wall himself.

"You can't walk before the Council," Zaleena said.

"Neither can you."

Sorin prepared two carrying chairs. Zaleena wanted to refuse hers, then realized refusal would serve nothing but display. They were carried onto the deck side by side. The harbor saw its old king and new queen on other people's shoulders at the same time.

"Bring me before the Council today," Roric said.

"Can you walk?"

"No. Bring me all the same."

"Why now?"

Roric looked at the wrist without its hook. "Because if I live pretending to be dead in the harbor where you were crowned, both our words will rot."

"If you appear today, the election may rot too."

"Then you'll be elected again or step down." Roric gripped the doorframe with his sound hand. "Every day you hide me, the decision becomes a little more yours and a little less the harbor's."

Zaleena had no answer. She ordered Kessel to summon the twenty captains and keep the meeting open to the shore.

She would tell the Council first that Roric was alive. The rest of the harbor would learn minutes later. Even that small difference was a privilege. Otherwise, knives might be drawn in the meeting.



Zaleena summoned the twenty captains to the deck of the sunken galleon. She gave no reason. Conversation stopped at once when Roric climbed the stairs between two crewmen.

A woman in the crowd onshore screamed. She had lost two sons in Roric's expedition. Other voices rose after hers: those calling his name, those calling him a fraud, those giving thanks for his return. Kessel had the armed crewmen around the deck take two steps back. Showing weapons to suppress anger would confirm the rumor.

Draven half drew his sword. "What is this?"

"Roric," Zaleena said.

"You said he was dead."

"I said he was missing. When I learned he was alive, I hid him."

"To win the election."

Zaleena did not deny it. "To protect him. To protect the harbor from tearing itself apart. I knew both benefited me."

"How long have you known?" Draven asked.

Zaleena gave the date. Kessel confirmed it from the record book. It was before the election.

A murmur began on the deck. Zaleena explained the days Roric was unconscious and the panel's decision to delay disclosure. She did not hide her first decision behind the panel.

"I decided on the first night," she said. "On the following days, Kessel and two harbor healers served as witnesses."

Kessel stood. "True."

The captains began shouting. Kessel struck the table, but no one fell silent. When Roric raised his sound hand, the noise slowly faded.

"I agreed to remain hidden," he said. "Because on the day I returned, eight of you would have killed me, and the other eight would have cut one another apart in my name."

"What would the other four of us have done?" a captain in the back row asked.

Roric laughed for the first time. "Said you had joined the winning side."

For one moment the tension broke. Then the voice of the woman who lost her sons came from the shore.

"Our children died. You hid."

Roric turned to the crowd. "Yes."

He added no excuse. No one silenced the woman.

"The election is void while the throne is yours," a captain said.

Roric looked at the empty chair. "The throne isn't mine." He took the old Wreck King's seal from his belt and laid it on the table. "I lost the expedition. I didn't listen to my men. Today I renounce the title."

Kessel had him confirm point by point that the renunciation was permanent and included his rights in fleet and treasury. Roric signed the document with his sound hand.

"My ship?" he asked.

"Missing," Sorin said.

"Then giving that up is easy too."

Draven sheathed his sword. "This doesn't absolve Zaleena."

"I don't want absolution," Zaleena said. "I won the election while concealing information." She placed the seal of office on the table. "I'm giving up the office now. Anyone who wishes to stand may do so again."

At Kessel's suggestion, the oldest neutral captain took over the meeting. Draven first asked that the legal question be put correctly: since Roric had withdrawn, would the harbor merely ratify the previous election, or would everyone vote again knowing the information from the start?

"I don't like her," he said. "But we'll ask the question in the right order."

The old election was declared void. When nominations reopened, Draven and Zaleena stepped forward. No one else did. Zaleena did not speak in her own favor. She stated again the date of the concealment, her reasons, and the advantage it had given her.

The votes were public. The result was thirteen to seven. Kessel entered the new election beneath the first result as a separate record.

Zaleena watched each of the seven hands raised against her. She would not treat the harbor's approval as property acquired on one day.

When the result was announced, Zaleena still did not sit in the chair. A king's disappearance would no longer be enough to call an election. It would require death, resignation, or removal from office. When fate remained

unknown, a three-person panel with limited powers would serve for twenty-one days.

Zaleena put the first signature beneath the rule forbidding what she herself had done.

Draven tilted his head. "You're forbidding your own act."

"Working once doesn't make it right."

\* \* \*

Roric went before the people that afternoon. Standing behind the table where the missing lists were read, he spoke the names of the ships. A rotten fruit thrown by a captain struck his burned cheek. Roric did not stop speaking.

Zaleena did not have the attacker arrested. A second stone would bring intervention. Anger remaining a piece of fruit meant the harbor was holding itself back.

"Zaleena didn't defeat me," Roric said. "I sank myself. She pulled me from the water. From now on, she is the Wreck Queen. I'll remain here if I can serve in whatever work she gives me."

"What work?" someone in the crowd shouted.

Zaleena answered. "None. The Council will write the office first."

Roric looked at her. They had not discussed it. Zaleena would not give the old king office merely because of his name.

The crowd's applause was not whole. Some were silent, some swore, most listened. Zaleena counted that as enough. True acceptance would not come from a single speech.

\* \* \*

Finn's two apprentices did not bring a flag to the table. They left a small model of their master's unfinished shallow-water boat. They had not repaired the crack in its rudder. Zaleena did not place the model among the designs. She had it set beside the harbor's first common rescue record. Finn could be remembered without being made a symbol.

An empty flagstaff rose from the deck of the sunken galleon. Zaleena left the record of the new election, Roric's renunciation, and Finn's model on the table beneath it. No flag was raised that day.

As she left the staff that night, her legs trembled again. This time she took Sorin's arm. The flag would not be ready the next day. For the first time, Zaleena considered that delay might be the right decision.

## Chapter 13 — Four Records

(CLOSING: TOGAN / TEMUJIN / KARIA / ZALEENA)

In the wake of Crimson Week, the sea left dead weed, broken ships, and wealth to be worked along the coasts. On land, armies counted their wounded. The Season of Chaos began.

When the last light of the seventh day faded, the Crimson Host had withdrawn south and the One Eye had turned white again.

Crimson Week was over. Its accounting had only begun.

### **The Road to the Old City**

Togan cleared the carved book on the road stone with his fingers. The arrow beneath it pointed southeast. For the first time in eleven years, Perren stood before the mark of the Inheritors.

Perren's feet blistered during the first three days. When Togan slowed their pace, the old man objected; that afternoon, his bleeding heels forced him to stop. Togan did not blame him as he cleaned the wounds. Waiting before the Wall for eleven years had not prepared a person for the road.

Every morning and night, they performed the test of five names. Togan knew them all. The ending of Anya's tale did not return. He could no longer draw the knot in Melira's bracelet without looking at it. When he saw the drawing, he recognized it.

Beside both, Perren wrote *unchanged*. A loss that did not improve needed to be recorded as much as healing.

"How many days?" Togan asked.

"It depends on our pace."

"The old scholar's answer?"

"Twelve." Perren took up his sack. "My feet say sixteen."

Togan moved some of the provisions not into Perren's sack, but onto his own back. By the time the old man noticed the help, they were halfway along the road.

"You won't carry me," Perren said.

"I'm not carrying you. I'm carrying the tablets."

"They're in the same sack."

"Then you can write your objection in the Old City."

Perren laughed. It was the first time Togan had heard him laugh while the Wall was still visible behind them.

Togan looked one final time toward the western road to the steppes. Then he followed the arrow to the Old City.

He left a small cairn on the western road. He carved the Sungur return mark on it. Kaya would not come that way; the mark would not reach her. Togan did it not as a message, but as a promise to himself that he would return.

### **The Sungur Valley**

Börü held one copy of the treaty, Korgan another, and Temujin the third. Kaya had asked for a fourth.

During the prisoner exchange, three people absent from both lists emerged. One had fled to another clan, one had been recorded under the wrong name, and the third had been found dead at the northern pass.

As Temujin wrote *dead* beside the third name, Kaya took the leather from his hand. She knew the man's mother. She would carry the news herself.

"The treaty didn't save him," she said.

"No."

"Will you say that in your victory speech?"

Temujin looked at the fur-lined coat Korgan had sent for the noon ceremony. "I won't give a speech."

"What if both Khans forget their word?" Temujin asked.

"I'll read it to them."

"And if they don't listen?"

Kaya put the leather into Storm's saddlebag. "Then I'll read louder."

Kaya added the dead man's name to the fourth copy.

Around the first common fire rising from the valley, the Azguts and Sungurs formed separate circles. A spear's length of empty ground lay between them. Temujin did not count the space as victory. He counted it only as a beginning.

An Azgut child carrying a bowl of meat approached the space. A Sungur child in the opposite circle rose at the same time. When they saw one another, both stopped. Their elders called and they returned. The distance between them did not close.

Temujin gave no order about it. Some distances diminished not by decree, but by the repetition of safe days.

Korgan watched him from the opposite fire.

Batu stood beside Korgan, and between them lay an unlit torch. They had not agreed who would light the common fire. When the night ended, the torch was still unused.

### **Metheris**

Karia wore no crown when Theodoric's coffin was lowered into the sea. She held the scratched ring he had given her in her right hand.

The coffin had been made from the sound planks of a ship damaged on Monster Day. Karia had objected at first. Kaelan found one of Theodoric's old decrees: no new timber was to be cut for a sovereign's funeral. Even after death, the King was interfering in the navy's accounts.

The Seven Lords stood onshore in black cloaks. Vorlag remained two paces behind Karia rather than beside her.

When the water took the coffin, every bell in the harbor sounded once. Then the workers returned to the storehouses and the crews to their ships. Mourning did not feed the city. Order did.

Karia remained onshore after the last bell fell silent. Theodoric's coffin dwindled in the Current and vanished behind the northern rocks. She wanted to believe the physician's words, *he did not suffer*. There was a place where belief could not be confirmed by a record.

Kaelan did not bring her the crown. He held out only the Harvest schedule. Karia thanked him.

At the palace, Karia opened the "Season of Chaos Provision Account." Vorlag's first objection, concerning the shares set aside for bereaved families,

waited on her desk. She answered by citing the authority clause in the document they had just signed. The truce was being tested on its first day.

She began work before the seal dried.

At midnight, the crown still rested on the stone beside her desk. The scratched ring held open the pages of the provision ledger.

### **Patchwork Harbor**

The new staff was raised on the deck of the sunken galleon. Since no one knew which flag would fly, only an empty line hung from its top. Captains, workers, and fishermen drew their marks on pieces of cloth. Draven brought a blank one.

Roric did not ask for a place on the panel. He said he had exercised his right when he surrendered the old black flag.

"I couldn't decide," he said.

"That may be the first honest design."

Draven left the cloth on the table. "Perhaps we don't know what we are."

"A flag showing that we don't know can't remain blank forever."

"Then we won't hurry."

Zaleena had not expected those words from him. She wrote them in the ledger exactly as spoken.

Roric laughed in the distance. Zaleena placed the blank cloth with the others. She would not allow the flag to be born in haste.

Finn's model boat with its crooked rudder stood on the shelf beside the recording table. The five fishermen were entered on the list of the saved and Finn on the list of the dead. Neither account of the same voyage could erase the other.

The condition that lethal observation data be shared in full from then on was added to Neris's Delta report. Patchwork Harbor was preparing not only a flag, but the terms on which it would speak to the outside world.

\* \* \*

Three days later, an Inheritor courier at the Granite Pass loaded four leather satchels onto a mail mule bound for the Old City.

The courier's name was Evin. He wrapped the seals and hid the four bags in separate places. The mark of the Inheritors sometimes offered protection. Sometimes it showed a thief what to steal.

One held northern reports concerning the unknown response of the Wall of Light during Crimson Week. The second carried the Azgut-Sungur treaty. In the third was the seal of the Hegemony's new queen; in the fourth, merchant records concerning the election in Patchwork Harbor.

Karia's seal still smelled of fresh wax. In the Patchwork Harbor record, two contradictory merchant notes saying that Roric was dead and alive stood side by side.

The archivist in the Old City would find none of them extraordinary alone. The fact that all four had changed during the same seven days would form a shape invisible on separate shelves.

Before leaving the Granite Pass, Evin stopped at the first inn along the road. The innkeeper said an old scholar and a warrior with an eagle were walking on the southern road. Evin took no interest. Two people walking were not part of his postal duty.

The mail mule passed Togan and Perren on the road to the Old City that same evening. Togan stepped aside to let the animal pass. The four sealed satchels came close enough to brush his shoulder.

One of the metal buckles on the mule's saddle had been altered by the Current. As Togan passed it, a brief pain ran between his teeth. He turned toward the animal.

"What is it?" Perren asked.

"The buckle is wrong."

Evin stopped several paces away and inspected it. Fine crimson veins marked the surface. Togan told him not to touch it with bare hands. Perren offered a piece of cloth. The courier wrapped the buckle, placed it in a separate pouch, and entered both their names in the transport ledger as witnesses.

"The Old City?" Evin asked.

"Yes," Perren said.

"If you catch up with the post, find the Inheritors' inn at the eastern gate. Travelers after Crimson Week are being recorded there."



Togan did not know that the ledger bearing his name traveled beside four separate seals. Evin did not know that the man before him carried in his blood the center of the reaction described in the northern report.

The roads had not yet joined.

Only one step remained between them.

*(END OF BOOK ONE)*